

WORLDS

WITHOUT NUMBER

TABLE OF CONTENTS

TALES OF THE LATTER EARTH	1
CHARACTER CREATION	4
THE RULES OF THE GAME	38
MAGIC AND THE ARCANES TRADITIONS	60
THE WORLD OF THE LATTER EARTH	94
CREATING YOUR CAMPAIGN	114
CREATING ADVENTURES	222
CREATURES OF A FAR AGE	280
FACTIONS AND MAJOR PROJECTS	322
ARTS OF THE GYRE	344
HEROIC CLASSES AND CHARACTERS	356
LEGATES	358
ITERUMS AND THEIR DWELLERS	370
ADDITIONAL GM TOOLS	376
INDEX	394

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TALES OF THE LATTER EARTH

The stars gutter and the skies fade and the earth grows weary with years. Ages of men and of Outsiders have ascended and been forgotten, and only the bones of their cities and the dust of their dreams remain upon this tired world. The Legacy of their laws is woven deep now, the edicts of dead gods and fallen sorcerer-kings made to trace patterns of power we no longer understand. We are heirs to their unseen empires.

Yet our kings are beggar-princes at best, and our sages but stumbling children. So deep is the past of Latter Earth that no one truly understands what has gone before or can lay sure hands on the Legacy we have inherited. We wield strange powers we no longer comprehend and summon forces that were never meant for our petty purposes. We live in a world haunted by those who came before us, and we suffer for the sins of their dead.

Our kingdoms struggle to survive in this mis-made world. We toil with muscle and the work of beasts rather than the strange devices of sorcery our ancestors wielded, and our lives are ones of simple labor. Sages have preserved inscriptions of the ancient mechanisms, but their subtle arts no longer work in this decayed age and the Legacy has changed from the days when they were still of use. Nothing is sure any longer save for the strength in a human arm and the sharpness of an iron blade. Our armies grip spears where our ancestors wielded suns.

Humanity has not always been the master of the Latter Earth. In former ages Outsiders came from the skies to be lords over us, changing our world to better suit their purposes. We were forced below, into the earth to dwell within the Deeps, and the world was made hollow with our delving. Only after long ages were our sorcerers and heroes able to drive out the interlopers. The remnants of their rule remain on the surface, *arratus* of strange plants and terrible beasts and wastes that choke a man with their noxious vapors. Sometimes these Outsider lands still hold a scattering of the old lords, bitter and hateful against their usurping slaves, and sometimes they come out to punish our lands.

We, too, have changed with the eons. Both the Outsiders and ancient sorcerer-kings worked changes on humanity, forming some among us into other beings more suitable to their ends. Some of these changed ones remain allies to their human cousins, while others nurse only the fury of ancient instinct or present bitterness. Some have their own kingdoms and domains in distant parts of the world, and some hide in nighted places where they can better prey on us. They are the hands of the past, the living relics that often work us woe.

Yet we are not content to struggle with the past and its changed children. We must also war against each other in the present, princes and lords vying over rulership of some miserable spit of land or patch of blood-soaked earth. Some fight over the rich tombs of the ancients, while others bloody each other out of pride, ambition, or the simple pleasure of conquest. A strong king brings peace to his people, but his neighbors will ever be jealous of that strength. Heroes are needed to fight in defense of their homes and their lords.

We have heroes still. Men and women graced with no more than courage and resolve may yet rise to light a new age with the fire of their example. Some may yet even rise to become Legates, blessed with a direct link with the Legacy and the gift of its superhuman powers. A Legate may be wicked or just, selfish or compassionate, but they all bear the strength of the ancients. The warriors among them strike like the fury of the storm and Legate-sorcerers invoke marvels out of a forgotten age. The greatest among them might cleave armies with their naked blades or call up cities from a barren waste.

Yet one need not be a Legate to be a hero, nor wield the powers of the ancients to give precious help to the present. Throughout the Latter Earth there are countless lands and people in need of help. Defense against the depredations of monstrous beasts, protection from the anger of the Outsiders, wisdom to defeat wicked lords and mend bloody quarrels... a brave heart and a strong arm can never be useless in this world.

Even those who care little for the troubles of others will find profit in daring the black delvings of the Deeps and bringing up the treasures of the past from the grip of the once-men who yet hold them. Terrible wildernesses of alien beasts and strange flora still shroud the ruined cities of the Outsiders, and brave explorers can weight their horses with gold if they can find safe paths through these desolations. The world is wide, and strange wonders await over each new horizon.

This is the Latter Earth but it is not the end of days. Our ancestors rose and fell ten thousand times, and we can rise yet again. Our lands are impoverished and our people are hard-pressed by their own folly and the shadows of a bottomless past, but we have courage still. There have been ages of darkness worse than this, and dawn came again when they passed. The stars gutter and the skies fade and the earth grows weary with years, but it has not ended yet. There is time enough for new heroes to rise from the ashes we have inherited.

Will you be among them?



HEROES OF A TWILIGHT AGE

Worlds Without Number is a fantasy role-playing game set in the far future of the Latter Earth, after innumerable eons of human history, alien rule, and unfathomable arcane evolution. The players take up the role of adventurers in this fading age, raising sword and sorcery against the foes of humanity and the obstacles that hinder their own ambitious aims. Many will perish on the spears of bitter rivals, be rent by the talons of monstrous beasts, or fall prey to their own reckless daring. Others, however, may yet live to obtain a name more glorious than kings.

WHAT DO YOU DO IN THIS GAME?

The characters in *Worlds Without Number* are assumed to be budding adventurers, men and women who have particular talents suitable to a life of daring exploration, bloody battles, or ruthless intrigue. They are skilled and capable practitioners of their particular specialties, but all of them are acutely mortal, and a too-ready recourse to their blades is likely to get them killed early in their career.

More experienced and skilled heroes have less to fear from an unlucky spear-thrust, but even the most hardened hero must be wary of a quick death when facing numerous foes. A gritty life of swords and sorcery awaits them.

Every hero in the game has some sort of goal or ambition. It may be an honest and simple desire for wealth beyond their dreams of avarice, or it might be a quest to avenge himself on a tyrannical lord, or it could be a dream of establishing a new nation for her exiled people. A hero may never live to see their ambition become real, but every PC has *some* sort of goal to drive them, even if that goal may change over time.

Some heroes pursue their goals through scavenging the remnants of a more glorious past. The ancient sorcerer-kings raised mighty cities and wrought wondrous marvels, many of which are still functional enough to be precious to modern humanity. Adventurers willing to plumb their ruined cities or search their ancient strongholds can come out bearing a king's ransom on their backs, or discover artifacts that could shift the balance of power among nations. Given the perils awaiting in such places, however, there are always far more who go in than ever emerge again.

Others delve into the depths, exploring the ancient subterranean Deeps that once incarcerated humanity during the age of the Outsider lords, the aliens who once ruled the Latter Earth. Many of these Deeps were never opened after the sorcerer-kings overthrew their masters, and the bones of their inhabitants now lie tangled with the common trinkets and tools that have become precious to their heirs. Monstrous Outsider beasts and maddened automatons still lurk in the darkness, as well as the degenerate and crazed remnants of the original human prisoners.

A few heroes are even bold enough to venture into the howling wastelands of the *arratus*, the desolate xenofomed territories poisoned by the Outsiders to make them more homely to the aliens. The hideous flora and fauna that infest these places are lethal to humans, but the treasures there are often richest from the difficulty of reaching them. Ancient human cities or Outsider strongholds are sometimes buried in the heart of an ancient *arratu*, their wealth preserved for the heroes brave enough to dare their poisoned streets.

Yet ruin exploration and expeditions into the wilderness are not the only adventures to be had. The lands of the Latter Earth are a patchwork of young kingdoms, savage tribes, and sullen empires, all of them with their own quarrels and ambitions. Adventurers often find themselves enlisted by the powerful to carry out their more dangerous tasks, and can easily be drawn into the intrigue between rival powers. A hero who dreams of forging their own empire can hope to achieve it with enough coin, enough friends, and enough luck. Nations are always rising and fading away in the roil of the present day, and there are less likely kings to be found than a cunning and successful hero.

Exploration and intrigue are paths for pursuing a hero's ambitions, but an accomplished adventurer must also deal with the simple human challenges of life in a hard and half-tamed world. There will always be petitioners seeking the help of the strong, injustices to pique a hero's ire, and calamities that threaten people and places they care about. The Latter Earth is old and careless of its inhabitants, and many terrible things come to pass for want of brave souls capable of forestalling them.

HOW DOES THIS GAME PLAY?

Worlds Without Number is based on an "Old School Renaissance" rules chassis strongly inspired by the classic gaming books of Gary Gygax, Dave Arneson, Tom Moldvay, and Zeb Cook. The roots of this system date back to the very earliest days of the hobby. There are millions of people worldwide who understand the basic outline of the system, and this enormous well of familiarity is one of the main reasons it was chosen as a base.

The system in *Worlds Without Number* has received years of effective use and playtesting in the form of its compatible sci-fi sister game, *Stars Without Number*, and I'm confident that the great majority of readers will find it a perfectly solid, playable, effective framework for their sword and sorcery adventures. Even so, I understand that a good many readers will have their own preferences in game systems, and may have a different rule system in mind for running their campaigns.

This is perfectly reasonable, because ultimately, *Worlds Without Number* is more about supporting a *style* of gaming than a particular system. This game is built from the ground up to support the GM in running



a “sandbox” style of campaign, one where the thrust of the action is entirely dependent on the ambitions and goals of the players. The tools in this book are built to support this play style no matter what game system is being used.

Modern gamers may be unfamiliar with sandbox-style tabletop gaming, as it’s a style that has fallen partially out of use since the early days of the hobby. The earliest campaigns were almost all sandbox-style, with rotating troupes of PCs venturing around a shared campaign landscape and plunging into whichever adventurous opportunities seemed most appealing. Contemporary gaming tends to favor “story arc” style campaigns, where the PCs are faced with a preordained series of challenges and plot points that they must negotiate as best they can. These story arcs can come to very different conclusions based on the actions and choices of the PCs, but the campaign is fundamentally about a single, particular plot and the PCs’ engagement with it. It’s a style of gaming that allows for precise story beats, unified themes, and a lot of other qualities that many gamers enjoy a great deal.

Sandbox gaming offers pleasures of its own, however, and some of them are harder to find in modern story arc campaigns. A sandbox campaign focuses around the goals and ambitions of the PCs rather than a pre-existing story. The GM provides the PCs with interesting situations and opportunities, but it’s up to the PCs to decide which of them they want to engage with and what hooks they want to pursue. At the end of every session, the GM asks the players what their goal for the next session will be, and the preparation they make for the next evening’s game will be based on that goal.

Sandbox campaigns offer endless surprises and freshness to the GM. Even they don’t know what’s going to happen in each session, because there’s no plot they need to follow and no need to worry about the PCs doing the “right thing” to “move the adventure forward”. Each

session is simply an opportunity or a situation; it’s up to the PCs to make the most of it, and if they fail, well, they can try something else next time. The campaign is about the things they want it to be about, when they want it. They’re never locked into a particular story arc and never compelled to stick around a tedious situation, so there’s much less chance of the GM finding the party bored with a campaign thread that’s overstayed its welcome.

Some GMs are intimidated by this style of campaigning because they don’t feel confident in their own preparations. If the players can go anywhere and seek anything, they reason, don’t they have to build an entire world out before the first session? Isn’t that a crushing amount of creative work, the vast majority of which will never become relevant to the players?

Worlds Without Number is designed to allay this concern and give the GM the tools, methods, and procedures for reducing the preparation to a manageable amount of work. This book will show you how to build out the bare skeleton of your campaign setting, establish only the parts that actually matter in play, and handle the session-by-session administration and prep work necessary for actually running the game. You’ll never have to build more than a single game session ahead of your players, a prospect that can make sandbox gaming even easier on a GM than story arc gaming. After all, you’ll never flesh out a five-session plot only to find the players getting bored halfway through the arc.

Now that you understand both what heroes are intended to do in *Worlds Without Number* and what a GM can expect to find in this book, it’s time to start your hero’s career. With luck, discretion, and the right amount of boldness, it may yet prove to be a long and glorious one. Lacking these qualities... well, there’s a reason that character creation is at the front of the book.



CHARACTER CREATION

The first step in playing *Worlds Without Number* is to roll up each player's character, or "PC". While it's possible to play the game with just a single player and a game master, or "GM", it works best with a group of three to five players and a GM. A solitary hero is hard-pressed to survive the myriad perils of Latter Earth, and a number of trustworthy companions are needed if a hero is to have much chance of victory.

It's generally best to make characters together with the others in your group, so as to make sure everyone's hero is the sort to play well together. PCs don't always have to *like* each other, but if they can't trust each other to watch their backs, their adventures are apt to end in swift and unhappy ways.

The character creation below assumes your heroes will be adventuring in the world of Latter Earth, as described in the chapter starting on page 94. Readers who have an interest in the setting's particulars can page forward and look it over before continuing. Those who just want to get started creating their adventurer can continue on below.

WHAT PLAYERS NEED TO KNOW

Your character is an adventurer in the ruins of the Latter Earth, a world set unfathomably far in the future. Untold eons of human and alien development have come and gone, and you and your companions are natives of a now-savage and primitive world built on the grave of the past.

Magic exists in the form of ancient relics, enigmatic powers that respond to the correct rituals, and creatures fashioned by inexplicable sciences. Sorcerers cultivate the scraps of understanding that they have preserved in order to wield these powers, and the occasional eruptions of ancient, twisted magic are a hazard in many places still.

Most nations on Latter Earth are feudal or monar-chic, ruled over by some tyrant with the strength to maintain order or some military elite capable of protecting their charges from the perils of monstrous foes and jealous neighbors. Some dynasties are ancient bloodlines of magically-blessed nobles, while others are no more than this season's bandit king and his henchmen. The common folk survive as best they can, making the bargains they must with their lords in exchange for protection and some semblance of law.

Technology is primitive, with brute force and the occasional windmill or water mill powering the little industry that exists. The natural laws of physics have been so corrupted by prior eons of meddling and the accrued changes known as the Legacy that more advanced technology is unreliable at best. This capriciousness has all but extinguished scientific curiosity or technological advancement among the people of Latter Earth, as what use are such studies when the subtler laws of nature are always changing?

In this world, your hero seeks adventure. Whether fighting against the constant peril of monstrous creatures, defending communities from the depredations of their neighbors, delving into the ancient Deeps that humanity once occupied, or exploring the trackless wilderness of an Outsider-altered Latter Earth, there is treasure, glory, and terrible death to be found by the brave.

Your hero may have had a very mundane past. Perhaps they were no more than a peasant girl who tired of her little village, or a young sailor who wants better pay for his courage than a sea captain can offer. Yet your hero has some sort of knack or capability that marks them out as being fit for adventure, whether that's a gift for violence, exceptional talent at a skill, or some modicum of magical prowess.

Your hero must, however, have a purpose. They must have some goal or direction for their ambitions, because *Worlds Without Number* is a sandbox-style game where the PCs will be the ones to decide what kind of adventures are sought. If you don't have a goal, you won't be able to contribute to that direction.

And not least of all, your hero must be able to cooperate with the rest of the group. Loners and troublemakers work well in novels but terribly at the table; be good to the other players, and make someone who will actually participate usefully with everyone else. Adventuring is dangerous, and going it alone is a recipe for swift death.

With these things said, it's time to start making your character.

LEGATES

The rules in this section describe the creation of normal PC heroes. They might be gifted swordsmen, capable young wizards, or talented thieves and explorers, but they are fundamentally normal human beings. They lack the link with the Legacy that makes for the superhuman powers of a Legate.

In the example campaign world of the Latter Earth, a heroic PC can hope to become a Legate only after reaching the peak of their potential. Only after exhausting the limits of normal human capacity can they gain the recognition of the Legacy and inherit its gifts.

In other campaign settings, superhuman heroes such as Legates may not exist at all. In a sword & sorcery pulp setting, it might be entirely inappropriate for heroes to ever become so personally mighty, while a high fantasy setting might make such divine strength more available to PCs.

Assuming Legates exist in your campaign, the rules for advancing in their powers appear in the deluxe version of *Worlds Without Number*, as given in the table of contents.



A SUMMARY OF CHARACTER CREATION

For your convenience, here's a quick summary of the character creation process. Experienced players can simply go down the list to generate their next bold adventurer, while those new to the game can use it as a guide as they go through the steps detailed on the following pages. A blank character sheet suitable for printing can be found toward the end of this chapter.

Note that some steps indicate that you should roll or pick skills from those listed on page 10. The first time you roll or pick a skill, it starts at level-0. The second time, it becomes level-1. The third time, you can instead pick any other skill of your choice that's less than level-1. No novice hero's skills can exceed level-1.

1. Roll your six **attributes** in order or assign them from an array, using Strength, Dexterity, Constitution, Intelligence, Wisdom, and Charisma. Attributes reflect the basic potential of your hero. Roll 3d6 six times and assign them in order, or use an array of 14, 12, 11, 10, 9, 7 assigned as you wish. If you randomly roll your scores you may then pick one attribute to change to a score of 14.
2. Mark down your **attribute modifiers** for each score. When rolling dice that are affected by an attribute, you don't apply the whole score; instead, you apply the attribute modifier. A score of 3 is a -2, 4-7 is a -1, 8-13 is no modifier, 14-17 is +1, and 18 is +2.
3. Pick a **background** from the list on page 11, and note down any particular details you decide for it. You gain the free skill listed under the background name at level-0, which equates to an ordinary professional knowledge of it.
4. Decide whether to roll for additional skills or pick them. If you pick skills, you can choose two more skills from the Learning table for your background, with the exception of entries that say "Any Skill", which you may not pick. You cannot pick entries from the Growth table. If you're not sure what to pick, just take the "Quick Skills" listed for your background at level-0.
5. If you choose to roll for your skills, you can roll up to three times, dividing up your rolls between the Growth and Learning tables as you wish. When you roll on the Growth table, some results may say "+2 Physical" or "+2 Mental". In the former case, you can add two points to either Strength, Dexterity, or Constitution, or one point to two different stats. In the latter case, you can add two points to either Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma, or divide the bonus between two of them.
6. Choose your **class** from those starting on page 18, representing those talents you have that are most relevant to an adventurer's lifestyle. If your hero isn't well-described by Warrior, Expert, or Mage, you can choose Adventurer and mix classes.
7. Choose your **Focus**, representing the side talents or particular specializations of your hero. You can pick one level of a Focus of your choice. Characters with the Expert class or the Partial Expert feature of the Adventurer class get one level of a non-combat Focus for free in addition to this. They can spend both levels on the same Focus, starting with level 2 in it if they wish. Characters with the Warrior class or Partial Warrior feature of the Adventurer class can do the same in choosing one level of a combat-related Focus.
8. Optionally, if your GM is allowing non-human PCs, you can make your character into one such creature by spending a Focus pick on the appropriate origin Focus. Nonhumans are described in the bestiary chapter, starting on page 280. Note that not all campaigns allow non-human PCs, even if they exist in the campaign world. They may not fit the particular tone of your GM's game.
9. Now **pick one skill** of your choice to reflect your hero's outside interests, natural talents, hobby expertise, or other personal focus.
10. If you've chosen the Mage class or chosen to be an Adventurer with the Partial Mage class, you need to pick a tradition for your sorcerer. These are listed in the Magic chapter starting on page 60. You may be a full-fledged High Mage, Necromancer, or Elementalist, or you may be an Adventurer with only a partial class in these arcane arts, or expertise in the magically-gifted partial classes of Healer or Vowed.
11. If you're a full High Mage, Elementalist, or Necromancer, or a Partial in two of these, choose four starting spells from your class' first level spell list. Partial Mages of these classes pick only two. Record these on the back of your sheet.
12. Roll your maximum **hit points** and add your Constitution modifier, to a minimum of 1 hit point. The die you roll depends on the class you chose. Warriors roll 1d6+2, Experts roll 1d6, and Mages roll 1d6-1. Adventurers use the tables on page 21, depending on which partial classes they took. If you lose all your hit points, your PC will be mortally wounded or slain outright.

WORLDS WITHOUT NUMBER

NAME _____ **PLAYER** **19** **HOMELAND** _____ **OCCUPATION** _____ **RACE/SPECIES** _____ **GOAL** _____ **DESCRIPTION** _____

BACKGROUND **DETAILS** **3** **CLASS** **6** **BENEFITS** **10**

ATTRIBUTES **STR** **1** **DEX** **2** **CON** **3** **INT** **4** **WIS** **5** **CHA** **6**

HIT POINTS AND SYSTEM STRAIN **Hit Points** **12** **Current** _____ **System Strain** _____

SAVES **PHYSICAL** **16-M STR/CON Mod.** **EVASION** **16-M DEX/INT Mod.** **MENTAL** **16-M WIS/CHA Mod.** **LUCK** **16-M** **18**

WEAPONS **15 16** **NAME** _____ **Bonus to Hit** _____ **DAMAGE** _____ **RANGE** _____ **SPECIAL AND SHOCK** _____

AMMUNITION _____

ARMOR CLASS **17** **DEX Mod.** _____

WORN **Armor** **AC** **Special**

READIED ITEMS **14** **MAX Total** _____ **Readied Items + STR + 2, rnd. down** _____

FOCI **+1 Focus at Levels 2, 5, 7, & 10** **7-8** **Lvl.** _____

SKILLS **SKILL POINTS** _____

Administer	Lea 1	Sail
Connect	4-5	Shoot
Convince	Notice	Sneak
Craft	Perf	Stab
Exert	Pray 9	Survive
Heal	Punch	Trade
Know	Ride	Work

+3 Skill Points/lvl (Experts: +1 extra non-combat)
Cost: New Value +1 Max +2 at lvl 3, +3 at lvl 6, +4 at lvl 9

13. Note down any **base attack bonus** you may have. This will vary based on your class; you can check the class tables starting on page 18 to see what your hero's basic martial aptitude might be.
14. Choose one of the **equipment packages** on page 29 or roll 3d6 x 10 to find out how many starting silver pieces you have with which to buy gear.
15. Mark down your total hit bonus with your weaponry. This is equal to your base attack bonus, plus either your Punch, Stab, or Shoot skill depending on the kind of weapon it is, plus your relevant attribute modifier. The weapon table on page 37 will tell you what attribute is used for a particular weapon. If two attributes are listed, use the best one for your hero. If you haven't even got level-0 skill at combat, take a -2 penalty on the hit roll.
16. Note down the damage done by your weapons. This is equal to its base damage dice plus its attribute modifier. If it's a Punch weapon, you can add your Punch skill to the damage as well.
17. Record your **Armor Class**, the measure of how hard it is to hurt your hero in a fight. The armor table on page 35 gives the score for a given harness. Different suits of armor grant different Armor Classes; if you aren't wearing any armor at all, your base AC is 10. Add your Dexterity modifier to this AC. In order to hurt your PC, an enemy has to roll an attack roll on a d20, adding their attack bonus and equaling or exceeding your AC.
18. Note down your beginning **saving throw** scores for your Physical, Evasion, Mental, and Luck saving throws. Physical saves against poison, disease, or exhaustion are 15 minus the best of your Strength or Constitution modifiers. Evasion saves to dodge sudden perils or dive away from explosives are 15 minus the best of your Intelligence and Dexterity modifiers. Mental saves to resist psychic influence or mind-bending sorceries are 15 minus the best of your Wisdom or Charisma modifiers. Your Luck saving throw is a flat score of 15, and rolled when pure chance is your only hope of avoiding some random disaster. To make a save, you need to roll equal or better than it on a d20 roll.
19. Lastly, wrap up your PC with a **name and a goal**. Every hero needs to have a goal when they set out adventuring. This goal might change, but your PC should always have some reason to go out and interact with the world before them. Stay-at-home PCs, aloof loners, excessively prudent heroes, and those unwilling to dare greatly for their aims are rarely fun to play.

ATTRIBUTES

A hero's native capacities are their *attributes*, each measured on a scale from 3 to 18. A score of 3 is as deficient as it's possible to be while still being functional as an adventurer, while an 18 reflects a degree of development that's close to a human's peak potential.

To generate a hero's scores, roll 3d6 six times, assigning them in order to the character's Strength, Dexterity, Constitution, Intelligence, Wisdom, and Charisma. You may then change one attribute of your choice to 14, because your adventurer has to be unusually good at *something* to have made it this far in life.

Clement GMs may optionally allow players to put their rolled scores in any attribute they wish. Other groups may prefer to let the rolls stand in order, to encourage players to try out unexpected character concepts.

If you dislike random generation of your hero's scores, you may instead put the following scores wherever you wish: 14, 12, 11, 10, 9, and 7. If you assign scores, you cannot replace one of them with a 14.

Once you've generated your ability scores, record the modifier for each of them. Thus, a score of 5 would have a -1 modifier and a score of 18 would have a +2. If your attribute changes later in the game through rolls on your background's Growth table or development as you advance in experience, remember to change the modifier if necessary.

Attribute	Affects...
Strength	Lifting heavy weights, breaking things, melee combat, carrying gear
Dexterity	Speed, evasion, manual dexterity, reaction time, combat initiative
Constitution	Hardiness, enduring injury, resisting poisons, going without food or rest
Intelligence	Memory, reasoning, intellectual skills, general education
Wisdom	Noticing things, making judgments, reading situations, intuition
Charisma	Force of character, charming others, attracting attention, winning loyalty

Attribute Score	Attribute Modifier
3	-2
4–7	-1
8–13	No Modifier
14–17	+1
18	+2

ATTRIBUTES AND ABILITIES IN PLAY

Attributes matter in *Worlds Without Number*, but not nearly as much as the choices you make and the risks you choose to run. A good Strength roll can give your PC an aptitude for swordplay, but poor judgment or reckless overconfidence will kill them long before an extra +1 bonus on a hit roll can save them.

With that in mind, don't be disheartened if your attribute rolls are low. The free score of 14 ensures that your character will be gifted in some way, and low scores or penalties in other fields can help to focus your creativity in other directions.

It's the custom in many modern RPGs to use a character's abilities and powers to directly resolve challenges in play. If you face a fight, you look up your fighting scores. If you've got a negotiation to manage, you check your sheet for your social skills. If the world throws you an odd situation, you look for the powers your PC has that might resolve the obstacle. Skillful play lies in making good choices in acquiring the right abilities and using them in an efficient way.

Worlds Without Number is built on a somewhat different philosophy, because the abilities a PC has don't always map well to the problems they face. A PC Warrior is a good combatant, but there are a lot of foes they can't reasonably defeat. A PC Expert is superb at

their chosen skills, but there's no guarantee that those skills will be particularly relevant to the adventure's challenges. Even the multifarious sorceries of the PC Mage are often awkward or unrelated to a problem.

Instead, players are encouraged to think of ways *around* problems instead of going straight through them. If the tools your attributes and powers give you aren't what the problem asks for, the players need to think of ways to *make* them what the problem needs. They need to *change* the terms of the situation to ones they can better handle, pull back to find a different route to their goal, or make a bet that what they've got will be enough in the end.

While this style of play can be challenging for many players, with solutions so often reliant on their own creativity and ability to shift the situation, it also has its special rewards. In *Worlds Without Number*, if your hero wins through to their goal, it wasn't because you picked the right combination of classes or efficiently optimized your character build. It was because you, the player, made the right choices at the right times. You ran when you needed to run, fought when you had to fight, and trusted to your luck no more than you had to. Your victory is *yours*, and that's a pleasure no dice-luck or forum build can grant.

SKILLS

Your hero's particular proficiencies are called *skills*. Every hero can at least *attempt* to do almost anything, whether or not they're particularly expert at it, but a hero with the right skill will have a much easier time finding success with their efforts. Of course, some particularly esoteric challenges, such as magic theory or advanced mathematics, might be impossible to attempt without the right skill.

Skills are measured on a ranking from level-0 for ordinary practitioners up to level-4 for the best of the best. Novice adventurers will begin play with skills of level-0 or level-1 as determined in the next section, where you pick or roll your hero's background.

Skill Levels

Level-0	An ordinary competence at the skill as might be had by a common practitioner
Level-1	A veteran professional at the skill, one noticeably better than most
Level-2	One of the best in the city at the skill, a veteran and talented master of it.
Level-3	One of the best in the kingdom, an inspirational master at the skill
Level-4	One of the best in the world, able to push the skill to its physical limits

SKILL CHECKS

When a hero attempts to pull off some feat of exceptional expertise, they must make a *skill check*. The player rolls 2d6 and adds their relevant skill level to it and the modifier of their most pertinent attribute score. If they have no relevant skill at all, they subtract 1 from their roll.

If the total is equal or higher than the check's difficulty the attempt is a success. If less, then either they fail, they succeed in a way that doesn't help them, or cruel fate intervenes to spoil their effort.

The particular attribute used with a skill check will vary with the situation. Lifting a heavy rock might be a Str/Exert skill check, while running a marathon might be more a Con/Exert check. The GM decides when the case is ambiguous. In the same fashion, if two different skills might be applicable to a check the player can choose which of the skills to use.

Some skills can't even be attempted without at least level-0 skill, if they're particularly obscure or specialized undertakings. Any hero can climb a cliff or try to fashion a good wooden spear, but only someone skilled in Craft could hope to forge a complex suit of armor.

Skill checks are only meant for unusual or exceptional challenges to a hero. Tasks that are common to their background never require a skill check.



THE SKILL LIST

Administer: Keep an organization running smoothly, scribe things well, plan out logistics, identify incompetent or treacherous workers, analyze records or archives, or otherwise do things that an executive or middle-manager would need to do.

Connect: Find or know people who are useful to your purposes, make friendships or social acquaintances, know who to talk to get favors or services, and call on the help or resources of organizations you belong to. Connect covers your PC's ability to find the people you need, though convincing them to help may require more than this.

Convince: Persuade a listener that something you are saying is true. Naturally, the more implausible the claim or more emotionally repugnant it is to them, the more difficult it is to persuade them. Furthermore, how they act on their newfound conviction is up to them and their motivations, and may not be perfectly predictable.

Craft: Craft or repair goods and technology appropriate to the PC's background and society. The Craft skill can be used for a wide range of artisan pursuits, though a GM is within their rights to keep the PC from building complex things that are too far away from their past background and experience.

Exert: Run, swim, climb, jump, labor for long periods, throw things, or otherwise exert your physical strength, stamina, and coordination. Even a PC with poor physical attributes might have a good Exert skill reflecting athletic training and expertise in making the most of their available talents.

Heal: Treat wounds, cure diseases, neutralize poisons, diagnose psychological health issues, and otherwise tend to the wounds of body and mind. The Heal skill cannot cure lost hit points directly, but it's a vital skill in stabilizing Mortally Wounded allies or ensuring clean recovery from grievous injuries.

Know: Know matters of history, geography, natural science, zoology, and other academic fields appropriate to a sage or scholar. While some sages might specialize in particular fields, most learned men and women in this age have a broad range of understanding, and will rarely be unable to even attempt to answer a question relevant to this skill.

Lead: Inspire others to follow your lead and believe in your plans and goals. Manage subordinates and keep them focused, loyal, and motivated in the face of danger or failure. A successful leader will keep their subordinate's faith and confidence even when reason might make the leader's plan appear questionable at best.

Magic: Cast or analyze magic and know things about famous mages or notable magical events. Classes that can't cast spells obtain only intellectual and scholarly benefits from this skill.

Notice: Notice small details, impending ambushes, hidden features, or concealed objects. Detect subtle smells, sounds, or other sensory input. Notice cannot be used simply to detect a lie, but keen attention can often discern a subject's emotional state.

Perform: Sing, act, dance, orate, or otherwise perform impressively for an audience. Compose music, plays, writings, or other works of performance art. Most performers will have a particular field they excel at, though polymaths might exist if the PC's background is appropriate for such versatility.

Pray: Perform the clerical rites of your religion, and be familiar with the gods, demons, and taboos of major and minor faiths, and identify iconography and persons of religious importance. Pray also helps you know the state of local faiths and the important persons in their hierarchies.

Punch: Fight unarmed or with natural body weaponry. Punch, kick, grapple, or otherwise brawl without the benefit of man-made tools. This mode of fighting is inefficient at best without some special Focus to improve it, but it's reliably non-lethal.

Ride: Ride an animal, drive a cart or carriage, or otherwise deal with land transportation. This skill also includes competence at mount care and tending, basic cart or carriage repair, judging good horseflesh, and other skills appropriate to a beast-rider of whatever society the PC comes from.

Sail: Sail or repair a ship, build small craft, navigate by the stars, read sea weather, manage sailors, and otherwise conduct the business of a professional mariner. This skill may apply to more esoteric means of vehicular travel in some societies.

Shoot: Fire a bow or crossbow or throw a hurled weapon. Maintain ranged weaponry and fletch arrows.

Sneak: Move silently, hide in shadows, avoid notice, pick pockets, disguise yourself, pick locks, defeat traps, or otherwise overcome security measures.

Stab: Fight with melee weapons or throw a hurled weapon. Maintain and identify weaponry.

Survive: Hunt, fish, navigate by the stars, mitigate environmental hazards, identify plants and wildlife, and craft basic survival tools and shelter. A PC's Survive skill is most pertinent to the environments in their background, but the basic principles can be applied in all but the most alien environments.

Trade: Buy and sell at a profit, identify the worth of goods or treasures, deal with merchants and traders, find black-market goods and services, and know laws regarding smuggling and contraband.

Work: This skill is a catch-all for any profession that might not otherwise merit its own skill, such as a painter, lawyer, farmer, or herdsman. The precise skill it represents will vary with the PC's background.

BACKGROUNDS

Every hero comes from somewhere, and the particular past of your PC is their **background**. Very few heroes come immediately to their ultimate calling of sorcery or swordplay, and even the most resolute hero is likely to have had some more mundane place in life before taking up their grand ambitions. In this section, you'll determine what this past might have been.

A background is simply a thumbnail description of the kind of life your hero led before becoming an adventurer. Each entry on the table below offers a different possibility, and you can either roll or pick from the list. Within these categories you should feel free to decide how exactly they relate to your hero.

For example, someone who rolls or picks a "Scholar" background might decide that they were an unsuccessful apprentice mage, frustrated with their uselessness until they took up a sword. The specific details of your past background are up to you, provided the GM finds them reasonable.

The specific interpretations of your background will depend on the campaign setting you're using. If you're playing in a desolate desert kingdom, a Sailor background might not make much sense. Talk with your GM about such details when you make up your hero's past.

If you want a background not listed here, work with your GM to choose Growth and Learning tables that fit your concept and use those as you would a listed background.

BACKGROUNDS AND SKILLS

Once you've rolled or chosen your background, you get the free skill associated with it at level-0 proficiency. After that, pick one of the three options below and continue on to choosing a character class.

- Gain the background's listed quick skills. Choose this if you just want the common skills of the role and don't want to bother more with it. *Or...*
- Pick two skills from the background's Learning table, except for the "Any Skill" choice. Choose this if you have specific preferences for your PC's skills. *Or...*
- Roll three times, splitting the rolls as you wish between the Growth and Learning tables for your background. Choose this if you don't mind accepting the dice's decision in exchange for an extra skill or a chance at improved attributes.

The "Any Combat" pick can be used to choose either Stab, Shoot, or Punch, while an "Any Skill" roll lets you choose any skill you wish. All new skills are gained at level-0, but if you pick or roll the same one more than once, they can be improved.

GAINING SKILLS AND ATTRIBUTES

When you roll or pick a skill, you gain it at level-0, reflecting a basic, ordinary proficiency at the skill. Level-0 is sufficient to earn a living with a skill or be counted a normal practitioner of it, but it's no particularly remarkable talent.

If you roll or pick the same skill again, it becomes level-1. Such skills are well-honed and mark you out as a veteran with noticeably superior talent to the ordinary run of those who use the skill.

You cannot pick a skill a third time. If you roll it a third time or are forced to take it by some Focus or other trait, you may instead pick any other skill you wish, gaining it at level-0 or improving it from level-0 to level-1 if you already have it.

No novice hero can have a skill above level-1. Only experienced adventurers can develop such mastery.

If you roll randomly on the Growth table and get an attribute bonus, you may use it to raise an attribute and potentially improve its modifier. Bonuses to Physical attributes may be applied to Strength, Dexterity, or Constitution, and bonuses to Mental attributes can be added to Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma. No attribute can be raised above 18, but a +2 bonus can be split between two different attributes.

d20 Background

1	Artisan , blacksmith, tanner, carpenter
2	Barbarian , savage hermit, wild man
3	Carter , hauling goods or riding post
4	Courtesan , harlot, artful companion
5	Criminal , thief, con man, burglar
6	Hunter , trapper, lone hermit, or recluse
7	Laborer , skilled or unskilled urban worker
8	Merchant , trader, peddler, or shopkeeper
9	Noble , spare son, exile, black sheep
10	Nomad , raider, tribal wanderer
11	Peasant , farmer, rural laborer, serf
12	Performer , bard, dancer, singer
13	Physician , village healer, healer-monk
14	Priest , monk, nun, holy hermit
15	Sailor , bargeman, fisherman, pirate
16	Scholar , sage, apprentice mage
17	Slave , indentured laborer, runaway prentice
18	Soldier , bandit, mercenary, guardsman
19	Thug , ruffian, gang member, village bully
20	Wanderer , exile, explorer, traveler



ARTISAN

Your hero was a crafter of some variety, whether a blacksmith, carpenter, shipwright, weaver, or a maker of more exotic goods. In humble villages an artisan is most likely to make the bulk of their living by the same subsistence farming as their neighbors, but in towns and cities they might be full-time professionals, perhaps belonging to some guild or brotherhood specific to their craft. While an artisan's Craft skill is chiefly applicable to those works related to their background, they often know enough or can improvise sufficiently to make competent efforts at other types of work.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Craft-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Connect
	2	+2 Physical	2	Convince
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Craft
Trade-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Craft
Connect-0	5	Exert	5	Exert
	6	Any Skill	6	Know
			7	Notice
			8	Trade

BARBARIAN

Your people or past were counted savage even in a world as brutal as this one. Primitive hill tribes, hard-pressed jungle clans, or simple frontiersmen too long out of contact with a more sophisticated civilization might all qualify for this background. You know how to live without the comforts a softer and more pacified people might require and you have a ready acceptance of violence that can keep you alive where others might perish. Still, the material privation of your life does not mean you are necessarily stupid or unadaptable, nor that you lack your own forms of culture.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Survive-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Any Combat
	2	+2 Physical	2	Connect
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Exert
Any Combat-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Lead
Notice-0	5	Exert	5	Notice
	6	Any Skill	6	Punch
			7	Sneak
			8	Survive



CARTER

Overland transport is hard and dangerous, and it requires an equally hard breed of men and women to carry it out. Carters might be caravan workers hauling precious goods over hundreds of miles, or independent shippers running a cart between isolated hamlets, or they might be messenger riders risking grave peril to deliver small packages. A carter may be a low-born peasant, but he might end up seeing more of the world than the gentry of his homeland. These far-traveled haulers commonly learn quickly how to handle themselves in perilous circumstances.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Ride-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Any Combat
	2	+2 Physical	2	Connect
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Craft
Connect-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Exert
Any Combat-0	5	Connect	5	Notice
	6	Any Skill	6	Ride
			7	Survive
			8	Trade

COURTESAN

Your hero made a profession of companionship, whether carnal or otherwise. Common street harlots or rented boys are by no means unknown among adventurers, but there are also exquisitely polished courtesans and graciously platonic artists of song, dance, and cultured companionship. Some have wearied of the particular strains of their work, while others mean to take advantage of their special talents in smoothing the social interactions of an adventuring party with an often-suspicious world.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Perform-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Any Combat
	2	+2 Mental	2	Connect
Quick Skills	3	+2 Mental	3	Convince
Notice-0	4	+2 Physical	4	Exert
Connect-0	5	Connect	5	Notice
	6	Any Skill	6	Perform
			7	Survive
			8	Trade

CRIMINAL

Some would argue that all adventurers are criminals sooner or later, but your hero made it their profession from an early age. Con men, charlatans, fraudulent merchants, pickpockets, sneak thieves, impostors, footpads, and ne'er-do-wells of every description often filter into the adventuring lifestyle, if only to ensure that their travels take them well away from the sites of their former activity. Given the general unscrupulousness, quick wits, and daring required of a successful criminal, many make excellent adventurers. Other less gifted examples make excellent corpses.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Sneak-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Administer
	2	+2 Mental	2	Any Combat
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Connect
Connect-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Convince
Convince-0	5	Connect	5	Exert
	6	Any Skill	6	Notice
			7	Sneak
			8	Trade

HUNTER

Both primitive tribals and bored nobles require hunts for their table and their pleasures, and such efforts often require professional hunters to help in the work. Hunger or greed has also been known to send poor peasants into the game preserves of their lords or deep into dangerous wilderness. A few hunters are actual gamekeepers employed to ward off poachers, while others are simply hermits who have no love for any company but their own. The marksmanship and stealth of a well-practiced hunter tend to be useful skills in an adventurer's line of work.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Shoot-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Any Combat
	2	+2 Physical	2	Exert
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Heal
Survive-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Notice
Sneak-0	5	Exert	5	Ride
	6	Any Skill	6	Shoot
			7	Sneak
			8	Survive



LABORER

In the villages and rural regions of the world, the vast majority of the populace are simple peasants. In the cities, the great mass of unskilled workers are laborers instead, day-workers and unskilled help employed by the artisans and craftsmen of the town. Their lives are hard, precarious, and unpromising, but the chance to live in a city and the opportunities for wealth and status it offers are enough to beguile many poor village lads and lasses. In the absence of a lucky break or fortuitous apprenticeship, some laborers find themselves willing to risk the life of an adventurer rather than endure their poverty meekly.

MERCHANT

Merchants range from the gilded merchant-princes of the great trading cities to the humble peddlers who roam between villages with packs full of sewing needles, tin pans, belt knives, and other household needs. Trade is a dangerous thing in this world, constantly subject to the rapacious demands of lords or the brutal exaction of bandits, and few cowards take up the work. Merchants with a particular fund of courage and an exceptional appetite for gold might even become adventurers, the better to obtain capital and contacts for their work.

NOBLE

Nobility is a quality that varies from culture to culture, some bestowing it for personal virtue, others to particular bloodlines, and some to those who fulfill specific roles in the culture. Whatever the particulars, your hero was of the noble caste of their home, one of the elites who governed and ruled. Alas, some circumstance has driven you out of your former place, forcing you to seek companions in adventure and make your own way in the world. You may no longer have the dignities and advantages of your former rank, but you at least have the benefit of its education.

NOMAD

Some peoples are forced to travel far to find their sustenance, whether they are beast-riders, drivers of great wagons, or simple masses of people walking from one waystation to another. Their native land may not be rich enough to support them and their herds for long at any one place, or some shifting peril might require them to be constantly on the move. Nomads are often mistrusted by settled folk, as it's all too easy for them to commit some depredation before moving out of reach of reprisal, but their skills at riding and surviving harsh environments are of use to any adventurer.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Work-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Administer
	2	+1 Any Stat	2	Any Skill
Quick Skills	3	+1 Any Stat	3	Connect
Connect-0	4	+1 Any Stat	4	Convince
Exert-0	5	Exert	5	Craft
	6	Any Skill	6	Exert
			7	Ride
			8	Work

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Trade-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Administer
	2	+2 Mental	2	Any Combat
Quick Skills	3	+2 Mental	3	Connect
Convince-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Convince
Connect-0	5	Connect	5	Craft
	6	Any Skill	6	Know
			7	Notice
			8	Trade

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Lead-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Administer
	2	+2 Mental	2	Any Combat
Quick Skills	3	+2 Mental	3	Connect
Connect-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Convince
Administer-0	5	Connect	5	Know
	6	Any Skill	6	Lead
			7	Notice
			8	Ride

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Ride-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Any Combat
	2	+2 Physical	2	Connect
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Exert
Survive-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Lead
Any Combat-0	5	Exert	5	Notice
	6	Any Skill	6	Ride
			7	Survive
			8	Trade



PEASANT

A peasant's life is never easy, though in some lands it's a kinder fate than others. Even in the richest states, however, a peasant's life is often marked by hunger, poverty, and a constant struggle to obtain the very minimal necessities for life. Most are accustomed to a world in which anything they can't personally grow, make, scavenge, or steal is something they won't have. Such ruthless resourcefulness and tolerance of pain and toil are useful qualities to any adventurer... and there are enough of them that a few who perish in some trackless waste are no grievous loss to their lords.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Exert-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Connect
	2	+2 Physical	2	Exert
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Craft
Sneak-0	4	+2 Physical	4	Notice
Survive-0	5	Exert	5	Sneak
	6	Any Skill	6	Survive
			7	Trade
			8	Work

PERFORMER

Singers, dancers, musicians, actors, poets, orators, and all other entertainers and edifiers might be found in this background. In a world such as this one, there are precious few who can earn more than the barest living off their art, and those who prosper are inevitably the ones who can cozen and beguile some rich patron into favoring their efforts. Even a wandering bard reliant on the generosity of taphouse keepers and bored yeomen must have a way with people, and this skill at managing their affections is often useful for an adventurer.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Perform-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Any Combat
	2	+2 Mental	2	Connect
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Exert
Convince-0	4	+2 Physical	4	Notice
Connect-0	5	Connect	5	Perform
	6	Any Skill	6	Perform
			7	Sneak
			8	Convince

PHYSICIAN

Healers are needed in any society, and your hero was one such physician. In a town or city, they might have been a classically-trained professional, versed in subtle arts of medical horoscopes, therapeutic gemstones, and the imbibing of precious metals, while a village healer might simply know the proper use of herbs, sutures, and splints. Adventuring bands always prize the help of a trained healer, whatever their background, and many consider it an essential to have someone in the party capable of patching up a bleeding ally or treating a fevered friend.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Heal-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Administer
	2	+2 Physical	2	Connect
Quick Skills	3	+2 Mental	3	Craft
Know-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Heal
Notice-0	5	Connect	5	Know
	6	Any Skill	6	Notice
			7	Convince
			8	Trade

PRIEST

Priests run a wide gamut in this world. Some live as moral exemplars for their flock, teaching them of the ethical demands of their religion and encouraging them in their faith. Others are simple spiritual technicians, performing rituals to propitiate and coax their god with no concern for anything but the correct execution of the rite and the timely receipt of payment. Adventuring priests often tend more toward the latter, assisting their companions with their prayers and expertise in handling people. A few priests even have magical powers, either given to them by their deity or learned as part of their youthful training.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Pray-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Administer
	2	+2 Mental	2	Connect
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Know
Convince-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Lead
Know-0	5	Connect	5	Heal
	6	Any Skill	6	Convince
			7	Pray
			8	Pray

SAILOR

Your hero was a sailor, a voyager on the salt tides or deep rivers of their home. They might have been captain of a ship of their own, or a bargeman on the great rivers, or a simple seaman willing to take ship with any craft that would have him. Some nations might even have ships of a more than nautical nature, aircraft or stranger things in need of a trained crew. Whatever their usual berth, sailors are accustomed to lives of sudden peril and hard labor, and the self-sufficiency forced by a life on the waves is often useful to an adventurer.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Sail-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Any Combat
	2	+2 Physical	2	Connect
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Craft
Exert-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Exert
Notice-0	5	Exert	5	Heal
	6	Any Skill	6	Notice
			7	Perform
			8	Sail

SCHOLAR

Dedicated scholars are few and far between in this world, but your hero is one of those rarities. Either through noble birth, a wealthy background, or dedication to some institution of knowledge, your hero has had the opportunity to become immersed in a life of study. You may have a particular field of focus, but scholarship in this age is a broad undertaking, and every scholar is expected to know something of the natural sciences and the nations surrounding their home. Given this education, those scholars with the daring to become adventurers can find themselves called upon to perform highly perilous field research.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Know-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Administer
	2	+2 Mental	2	Heal
Quick Skills	3	+2 Mental	3	Craft
Heal-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Know
Administer-0	5	Connect	5	Notice
	6	Any Skill	6	Perform
			7	Pray
			8	Convince

SLAVE

Slavery in this world varies from the pampered life of some favored house slave to a short, brutal existence in the mines and manufactories. It's not unknown for the same slave to experience both ends of the spectrum as their charm fades or financial need forces a slimming of the household staff. In some lands a former slave can have hope of attaining honor and status, while in others they might expect an even worse state, without even the assurance of sufficient bread for their labor. Runaways, rebels, and ex-slaves are all well-represented among the desperate class of adventurers.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Sneak-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Administer
	2	+2 Physical	2	Any Combat
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Any Skill
Survive-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Convince
Exert-0	5	Exert	5	Exert
	6	Any Skill	6	Sneak
			7	Survive
			8	Work

SOLDIER

Mercenary, regular soldier, temple knight, monastic defender, village militiaman, or savage raider; whatever the specifics, your hero made their living by war. You may have wearied of the endless killing, or lost your former employer, or simply became dissatisfied with the meagre rewards offered for your shed blood, but whatever the cause you have decided to take up an adventurer's life instead. Every group values the help of a strong sword arm, even if you may have developed skills far different from that in pursuit of your trade.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Any Combat-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Any Combat
	2	+2 Physical	2	Any Combat
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Exert
Exert-0	4	+2 Physical	4	Lead
Survive-0	5	Exert	5	Notice
	6	Any Skill	6	Ride
			7	Sneak
			8	Survive

THUG

A soldier belongs to some larger organization, whereas you were simply a thug. Whether a village bully, street ruffian, assassin, bandit, outlaw, or neighborhood enforcer, you got what you wanted through the strength of your right arm. Not every ruffian is a simple criminal, however, and it may be you were a protector to your family or gang, or a defender of your neighborhood against hostile outsiders or an oppressive lord. Necessity or ambition has turned you to an adventurer's life, however, and your combination of raw violence and calculated social expertise is likely to be useful in the trade.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Any Combat-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Any Combat
	2	+2 Mental	2	Any Combat
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Connect
Convince-0	4	+2 Physical	4	Convince
Connect-0	5	Connect	5	Exert
	6	Any Skill	6	Notice
			7	Sneak
			8	Survive

WANDERER

Some people simply have no home, and your hero is one such unfortunate. You may have been driven into exile by hostile neighbors, or a turn of political fortune, or a crime you may or may not have committed. Your former home might have been destroyed by enemies or transformed by events until it no longer had a place for you. Whatever the particulars, you journey for your own reasons and seek whatever it is you hope to find in this world. Adventurers often have a tolerance for such vagabonds that is not to be found in more settled society.

Free Skill	d6	Growth	d8	Learning
Survive-0	1	+1 Any Stat	1	Any Combat
	2	+2 Physical	2	Connect
Quick Skills	3	+2 Physical	3	Notice
Sneak-0	4	+2 Mental	4	Perform
Notice-0	5	Exert	5	Ride
	6	Any Skill	6	Sneak
			7	Survive
			8	Work



CHOOSING A CLASS

While a hero's background defines their upbringing and common profession, a **class** determines what special skills and abilities they use to succeed in their adventuring. Not everyone has a class; most people are just ordinary men and women who might be soldiers, thieves, nobles, or other ordinary professions. A PC is rare in that they have the seeds of true greatness within them, and the potential to vastly exceed the power of their ordinary peers.

There are four classes available in the game. You should pick the one that provides the kind of tools you want your hero to use while adventuring.

Experts are masters of non-combat skills, such as stealth, medicine, diplomacy, and other practical talents. While any hero can become quite skilled in such undertakings, an Expert learns these skills faster and can use them more effectively than other classes, often succeeding where a different hero would surely fail.

Mages include not only classical wizards but also those heroes who rely on supernatural powers for their usefulness, such as magical healers, ascetic unarmed combatants, and supernaturally wise sages. Each Mage belongs to a specific magical tradition which defines their powers and indicates any special taboos they must respect. While their arts are powerful, mages tend to be frailer and less combat-capable than other heroes.

Warriors fight, using sword or bow or fist to overcome their enemies and survive the violence they might inflict. Combat is a dangerous undertaking in this game, and death comes easy to every hero. A Warrior has the tools to survive mistakes that would prove lethal to other classes and to overcome foes in combat that might otherwise prove too much for less martial heroes.

Adventurers are the class for those players who can't quite decide, or who have a concept that mixes elements of more than one class. An Adventurer can choose two of the other classes above and mix them together, gaining some of the benefits of both at the cost of never being quite so capable with either sphere as a full practitioner would be.

Each class comes with a table that indicates the class's hit dice, attack bonus, and which Focus picks they gain. Your novice hero will usually begin the game at first level, so you'd use the first line on these tables to mark down your hit points and attack bonus and to indicate how many Foci you can pick.

When picking a class, don't feel obliged to choose one that fits naturally with your background. Instead, choose one that suits how you want to play. You can always explain later how your hero came to a new trade or discovered some hidden talent.

THE EXPERT

Your hero is an expert at some useful skill. Thieves, diplomats, healers, scholars, explorers, artisans, and other such heroes should pick the Expert class if they wish to focus on developing their special skills and performing tremendous feats of mastery with them. Experts gain the widest variety of non-combat skills and are the quickest to learn more of them.

An Expert has an uncanny knack for wielding their skills successfully at a crucial moment, whether or not it's a skill they've taken for their specialty. Once per scene,

the Expert can reroll a failed non-combat skill check, gaining a second chance to yank victory from the jaws of otherwise certain failure. Their natural focus on personal development and determined refinement of their skills bleeds through even into those talents they don't make their special domain.

Experts are also capable combatants, fully able to hold their own in the midst of a murderous fray. It's not unknown for some Experts to specialize in professions related to martial pursuits, such as an assassin who relies heavily on their superb powers of stealth and deception to reach their unwary foes.

CLASS ABILITY: MASTERFUL EXPERTISE

Once per scene, the Expert may reroll any non-combat skill check as an Instant action. This allows the Expert to make a roll and then immediately use this ability if the resulting total isn't good enough to succeed. In cases where it matters, the better of the two rolls may be used.

CLASS ABILITY: QUICK LEARNER

When you advance a character level, you gain an extra skill point which may only be spent on gaining or improving non-combat skills or raising attributes. You may save this point to spend later if you wish.

Level	Hit Dice	Attack Bonus	Focus Picks
1	1d6	+0	1 Any + 1 Expert
2	2d6	+1	+1 Any
3	3d6	+1	
4	4d6	+2	
5	5d6	+2	+1 Any
6	6d6	+3	
7	7d6	+3	+1 Any
8	8d6	+4	
9	9d6	+4	
10	10d6	+5	+1 Any

THE MAGE

Your hero wields arcane powers and otherworldly arts in the service of their ambitions. Some Mages are taught in formal sorcerous schools, while others gain their education from the careful instructions of a wizened master. A few who practice more primal traditions might even awaken spontaneously to their power, obtaining strange abilities without any formal education at all.

Every Mage belongs to a particular magical tradition, one which describes the nature of their powers and the breadth of their capabilities. The Magic chapter beginning on page 60 lists the various traditions described in this book, but more doubtless exist and several might be specific to the particular campaign world you are playing in. If playing a Mage, consult with your GM to find out which traditions exist in your campaign setting.

Not all magical traditions necessarily involve classical spell-flinging and conjury. Some traditions are much more physical in nature, granting the practitioners remarkable bodily prowess or unique magical gifts they can exercise. Some Mage traditions involve no spellcasting at all, restricting their focus entirely to the strange arcane gifts their forebears have developed.

While these spells and occult powers are impressive, they tend to come at a cost. A Mage must spend so much time focused on their studies and training that they have little time to master any other art. Most are notably weak combatants with little ability to survive hardships that would merely wound or weary a Warrior.

In addition to this, many traditions have their own specific limits on practitioners. Initiates of the High Mage tradition, for example, cannot cast their spells while wearing anything heavier than normal clothing, thus making it impossible for them to wear armor and still wield their spells. The hindrances of some traditions extend beyond physical limitations to social penalties or difficulties in dealing with mundane humanity; a necromancer may have impressive powers of magic, but they are often unwelcome in civilized lands and are sometimes subject to the panicked justice of frightened locals and their lords.

Level	Hit Dice	Attack Bonus	Focus Picks
1	1d6-1	+0	1 Any
2	2d6-2	+0	+1 Any
3	3d6-3	+0	
4	4d6-4	+0	
5	5d6-5	+1	+1 Any
6	6d6-6	+1	
7	7d6-7	+1	+1 Any
8	8d6-8	+1	
9	9d6-9	+1	
10	10d6-10	+2	+1 Any



The ways of magic tend to be specific to settings in a way that swordplay or skillful arts are not. Your GM may disallow certain Mage traditions or partial classes based on the particulars of their own campaign world or the specific sort of game they want to play. Some campaigns set in historical periods or very low-magic worlds might not include Mages at all, leaving heroes reliant on the strength of their own arms and the cunning of their own native wits.

Whatever the setting, Mage heroes need to rely on careful planning and a cooperative party to get the most from their abilities. While potent, the spells they wield are few in number and usually narrow in effect; even the mightiest sorcerer of the Latter Earth is just not going to be as effective as their Warrior peers in slaying fearsome enemies or their Expert companions in carrying out the mundane activities of stealth, persuasion, or investigation. Instead, Mages excel at providing carefully-planned impossibilities, those selective defiances of reality that allow their teammates to pull off incredible schemes or overcome otherwise insurmountable odds.

CLASS ABILITY: ARCANES TRADITION

The Mage may pick one magical tradition to represent their occult powers, as listed in the Magic chapter starting on page 60. This tradition may give them a number of additional benefits and restrictions.

THE WARRIOR

The Warrior is a hero born to the blade, a man or woman gifted with a superb capacity for physical violence. Savage barbarians, hardened mercenaries, courageous young farm boys, and ordinary laborers who just happen to have an undiscovered capacity for massive bloodshed all might qualify as Warriors.

Warriors aren't all formal soldiers or recognized veterans of the blade. Any adventurer who excels in dealing with their problems through violence might qualify as a Warrior, however peaceful their background. It's possible that their very talent for killing was what forced them out of their old life after some terrible event or awful encounter compelled them to recognize their gifts.

Warriors have more hit points than heroes of other class, and are capable of surviving wounds and hardships that would kill an ordinary man. They're also gifted with a superior attack bonus, and a native ability to inflict more damage than other PCs. They even have the ability to ensure a hit or force a miss by an enemy once per scene, making them lethal foes to common combatants.

CLASS ABILITY: KILLING BLOW

Whenever a Warrior inflicts damage with any attack, spell, or special ability they may add half their character level, rounded up, to the damage done. This damage is also added to any Shock they may inflict.

Combined with Foci meant to improve Shock attacks such as *Armsmaster*, *Close Combatant*, or *Shocking Assault*, this ability ensures that an experienced Warrior will almost always kill any ordinary human soldier or minor monster, regardless of their attack roll result.

Level	Hit Dice	Attack Bonus	Focus Picks
1	1d6+2	+1	1 Any + 1 Warrior
2	2d6+4	+2	+1 Any
3	3d6+6	+3	
4	4d6+8	+4	
5	5d6+10	+5	+1 Any
6	6d6+12	+6	
7	7d6+14	+7	+1 Any
8	8d6+16	+8	
9	9d6+18	+9	
10	10d6+20	+10	+1 Any

CLASS ABILITY: VETERAN'S LUCK

Once per scene, as an Instant action, the Warrior may turn a missed attack they have made into a hit. Alternatively, they may turn a successful attack against them into a miss, also as an Instant action. This ability is particularly lethal when used with the *Make a Snap Attack* action and leveled against weaker monsters or ordinary human warriors, as explained on page 44.

Only one exercise of this ability is possible in a scene, either to force a miss or ensure a hit on a foe; both options may not be employed in the same fight.

A Warrior may use this ability with crew-served weapons they are assisting in firing. This ability cannot be used to negate environmental damage or damage done to a vehicle or mount they are riding.



THE ADVENTURER

Not every hero is perfectly reflected by one of the three main classes, even with the wide latitude of concepts each one allows. For those heroes that straddle the roles, there remains the class of Adventurer.

An Adventurer picks two of the three main classes to reflect their own particular talents. A spell-slinging swordsman might choose to be a Partial Mage/Partial Warrior, while a stealthy assassin might be a Partial Expert/Partial Warrior, and a gifting mountebank-wizard might be a Partial Expert/Partial Mage. The player should pick whichever pairing serves best.

The adjacent tables provide the hit dice, attack bonus, and Foci picks gained by each of the three possible pairings. Thus, a first level Partial Expert/Partial Warrior would roll 1d6+2 for their hit points, have a +1 attack bonus, and pick three Foci: one expert, one warrior, and one free pick.

Adventurers tend to have a wider range of abilities than a more focused PC, and the extra Focus pick can make a significant difference at low levels. The absence of the strongest class abilities of Experts and Warriors make a difference in the longer run, however, and a Partial Mage will never attain the same magical power in their tradition as a focused specialist.

PARTIAL EXPERT

A Partial Expert is treated just as a full Expert, including gaining the benefits of the **Quick Learner** ability. They do not have the **Masterful Expertise** ability, however, as they lack the polymathic versatility of a full Expert.

PARTIAL MAGE

A Partial Mage is treated as a Mage, and gains the **Arcane Tradition** ability, allowing them to pick a magical tradition for their powers. That tradition's abilities will be more limited for Partial Mages, however, as described under each of the paths.

It's even possible for a PC to pick the Partial Mage class twice for two different magical traditions, gaining portions of both arcane powers. They then use the usual full Mage chart for hit dice, attack bonus, and Foci, and the spellcasting table on page 64 if both partial classes cast spells.

A Partial Mage must adhere to the restrictions and limits of their magical tradition in order to use its abilities, regardless of whatever other partial class they may have.

PARTIAL WARRIOR

A Partial Warrior gains certain of the benefits of a full Warrior, including the improved hit die and a somewhat improved attack bonus. They do not have the **Veteran's Luck** special ability or the **Killing Blow** power, however, and must trust to their own talents to land blows and crush their enemies.

Partial Expert/Partial Warrior

Level	Hit Dice	Attack Bonus	Focus Picks
1	1d6+2	+1	1 Expert + 1 Warrior + 1 Any
2	2d6+4	+2	+1 Any
3	3d6+6	+2	
4	4d6+8	+3	
5	5d6+10	+4	+1 Any
6	6d6+12	+5	
7	7d6+14	+5	+1 Any
8	8d6+16	+6	
9	9d6+18	+6	
10	10d6+20	+7	+1 Any

Partial Expert/Partial Mage

Level	Hit Dice	Attack Bonus	Focus Picks
1	1d6	+0	1 Expert + 1 Any
2	2d6	+1	+1 Any
3	3d6	+1	
4	4d6	+2	
5	5d6	+2	+1 Any
6	6d6	+3	
7	7d6	+3	+1 Any
8	8d6	+4	
9	9d6	+4	
10	10d6	+5	+1 Any

Partial Mage/Partial Warrior

Level	Hit Dice	Attack Bonus	Focus Picks
1	1d6+2	+1	1 Warrior + 1 Any
2	2d6+4	+2	+1 Any
3	3d6+6	+2	
4	4d6+8	+3	
5	5d6+10	+4	+1 Any
6	6d6+12	+5	
7	7d6+14	+5	+1 Any
8	8d6+16	+6	
9	9d6+18	+6	
10	10d6+20	+7	+1 Any

CHOOSE FOCI

Once you know your hero's class, you can choose their **Foci**, special knacks or talents that your hero has developed. Each Focus generally come in two levels; the first time you pick it you get the first level of the Focus, and the second time you choose it you gain its second level.

Once a Focus has been bought up to its maximum level, it generally can't be picked again. Sometimes the same Focus can be taken more than once to apply to different skills, such as taking **Specialist** twice to apply to both Sneak and Know skills.

Many Foci grant a bonus skill. You gain this skill at level-0 if you don't already have it, or level-1 if you already have it at level-0. If you already have it at level-1, pick any other skill except Magic. If you earn a Focus later in your adventuring career, after first level, you instead improve the skill as explained on page 11.

Every PC can pick one Focus of any kind representing past experiences or native talent. This free Focus doesn't necessarily have to have anything to do with your class; a Mage might actually be a vicious knife fighter with the **Close Combatant** Focus, or a Warrior might be exceptionally **Cultured**.

Aside from this free Focus, a Warrior or Partial Warrior can pick one Focus related to their martial background, and an Expert or Partial Expert can pick one Focus related to something other than combat. In ambiguous cases, the GM decides if the Focus really does relate to their class; some Foci might be usable for both.

Alert

You are keenly aware of your surroundings and virtually impossible to take unaware.

Level 1: Gain Notice as a bonus skill. You cannot be surprised, nor can others use the Execution Attack option on you. If the GM rolls initiative by sides, you can add a +1 bonus to your side's initiative roll, though multiple **Alert** PCs don't stack this bonus. If you roll initiative individually, you can roll it twice and take the better result.

Level 2: You always act first in a combat round unless someone else involved is also this **Alert**.

Armored Magic

Usable only by Mage heroes who would otherwise be prevented from casting spells or using arts while armored, this Focus reflects special training in channeling magic through the hindering materials of conventional armor.

Level 1: You can cast spells or use arts while wearing armor that has an Encumbrance value of no more than two. You can use a shield while casting, provided your other hand is empty for gesturing.

Level 2: You can cast spells while wearing armor of any Encumbrance. You've also learned to cast spells while both your hands are full, though not bound.

Armsmaster

You have an unusual competence with thrown weapons and melee attacks. This Focus' benefits do not apply to unarmed attacks or non-thrown projectile weapons. This Focus' bonuses also don't stack with **Deadeye** or other Foci that add a skill's level to your damage or Shock.

Level 1: Gain Stab as a bonus skill. You can Ready a Stowed melee or thrown weapon as an Instant action. You may add your Stab skill level to a melee or thrown weapon's damage roll or Shock damage, assuming it has any to begin with.

Level 2: The Shock from your melee attacks always treats the target as if they have AC 10. Gain a +1 bonus to hit with all thrown or melee attacks.

Artisan

You have remarkable gifts as a crafter and can often improvise techniques even in fields unrelated to your usual background. You are able to create mods for equipment even if you are not an Expert, as per the rules on page 56.

Level 1: Gain Craft as a bonus skill. Your Craft skill is treated as one level higher, up to a maximum of 5, for purposes of crafting and maintaining mods. Mods you build require one fewer unit of arcane salvage, down to a minimum of one. Your Craft skill is applicable to any normal crafting profession's work, allowing you to fashion their wares without penalty.

Level 2: The first mod you add to an item requires no Maintenance and only half the silver piece cost usually required. This benefit is in addition to the benefits of installing a mod in masterwork gear you build. You automatically succeed at any attempt to build masterwork gear, and once per month you can reduce a created mod's salvage cost by one further unit, down to a minimum of zero.

Assassin

You are practiced at sudden murder, and have certain advantages in carrying out an Execution Attack as described in the rules on page 44.

Level 1: Gain Sneak as a bonus skill. You can conceal an object no larger than a knife from anything less invasive than a strip search. You can draw or produce this object as an On Turn action, and your point-blank thrown or melee attacks made during a surprise round with it cannot miss the target.

Level 2: You can take a Move action on the same round as you make an Execution Attack, closing rapidly with a target before you attack. You may split this Move action when making an Execution Attack, taking part of it before you murder your target and part of it afterwards. This movement happens too quickly to alert a victim or to be hindered by bodyguards.

Authority

You have an uncanny kind of charisma about you, one that makes others instinctively follow your instructions and further your causes. At level 1, this is a knack of charm and personal magnetism, while level 2 might suggest latent magical powers or an ancient bloodline of sorcerous rule. Where this Focus refers to followers, it means NPCs who have voluntarily chosen to be in your service. PCs never count as followers.

Level 1: Gain Lead as a bonus skill. Once per day, you can make a request from an NPC who is not openly hostile to you, rolling a Cha/Lead skill check at a difficulty of the NPC's Morale score. If you succeed, they will comply with the request, provided it is not significantly harmful or extremely uncharacteristic.

Level 2: Those who follow you are fired with confidence. Any NPC being directly led by you gains a Morale and hit roll bonus equal to your Lead skill and a +1 bonus on all skill checks. Your followers and henchmen will not act against your interests unless under extreme pressure.

Close Combatant

You've had all too much practice at close-in fighting and desperate struggles with drawn blades. You're extremely skilled at avoiding injury in melee combat, and at level 2 you can dodge through a melee scrum without fear of being knifed in passing.

Level 1: Gain any combat skill as a bonus skill. You can use knife-sized thrown weapons in melee without suffering penalties for the proximity of melee attackers. You ignore Shock damage from melee assailants, even if you're unarmored at the time, but invoking this benefit disrupts any spellcasting you might do that round due to the need for violently active evasion.

Level 2: The Shock damage from your melee attacks treats all targets as if they were AC 10. The *Fighting Withdrawal* combat action is treated as an On Turn action for you and can be performed freely.

Connected

You're remarkably gifted at making friends and forging ties with the people around you. Wherever you go, you always seem to know somebody useful to your ends.

Level 1: Gain Connect as a bonus skill. If you've spent at least a week in a not-entirely-hostile location, you'll have built a web of contacts willing to do favors for you that are no more than mildly illegal. You can call on one favor per game day and the GM decides how far they'll go for you.

Level 2: Once per game session, if it's not entirely implausible, you meet someone you know who is willing to do modest favors for you. You can decide when and where you want to meet this person, but the GM decides who they are and what they can do for you.

Cultured

Through wide travel, careful observation, or extensive study, you've obtained a wide experience of the cultures of your region and an ability to navigate their customs, laws, and languages. You know what to do and say to impress others with the reasonableness of your wishes.

Level 1: Gain Connect as a bonus skill. You can fluently speak all the common languages of your native region and convey at least basic information in the uncommon or esoteric ones. You can learn a new language with only a week's practice with a native speaker. Once per game day, your polished ways automatically gain a minor favor from an NPC that would not put them to significant expense or risk, assuming the NPC isn't hostile to you.

Level 2: Once per game session, reroll a failed social skill check as you use your cultural knowledge to push your interlocutor toward the desired result.

Die Hard

You are surprisingly hard to kill. You can survive injuries or bear up under stresses that would incapacitate a less determined hero.

Level 1: You gain an extra 2 maximum hit points per level. This bonus applies retroactively if you take this Focus after first level. You automatically stabilize if Mortally Wounded, provided you have not been incinerated, dismembered, or otherwise torn apart.

Level 2: The first time each day that you are reduced to zero hit points by an injury, you instead survive with one hit point remaining. This ability can't save you from large-scale, instantly-lethal trauma.

Deadeye

You have a gift with ranged weapons. While this talent most commonly applies to bows, it is also applicable to thrown weapons or other ranged weapons that can be used with the Shoot skill. For thrown weapons, you can't use the benefits of the *Armsmaster* Focus at the same time as *Deadeye*.

Level 1: Gain Shoot as a bonus skill. You can Ready a Stowed ranged weapon as an Instant action. You may use a bow or two-handed ranged weapon even when an enemy is within melee range, albeit at a -4 hit penalty. You may add your Shoot skill level to a ranged weapon's damage roll.

Level 2: You can reload crossbows or other slow-loading weapons as an On Turn action, provided they don't take more than a round to reload. You can use ranged weapons of any size in melee without penalty. Once per scene, as an On Turn action when target shooting at an inanimate, non-creature target, you automatically hit unless you roll a 2 on your Shoot skill check or the shot is physically impossible.



Dealmaker

You have an uncanny ability to sniff out traders and find good deals, licit or otherwise. Even those who might not normally be disposed to bargain with you can sometimes be persuaded to pause and negotiate, if you have something they want.

Level 1: Gain Trade as a bonus skill. With a half hour of effort you can find a buyer or seller for any good or service that can be traded in the community, legal or otherwise. Finding a marginally possible service, like an assassin willing and able to target a king, or some specific precious ancient artifact, may require an adventure if the GM allows it at all.

Level 2: Once per session, target a sentient who is not just then trying to kill you or your allies and make a request of it that it can comprehend. If it's at all plausible for it to make such terms, it will do so for a price or favor it thinks you can grant, though the price for significant favors might be dear.

Developed Attribute

Your hero has a remarkable degree of development to one or more of their attributes. This may be derived from an eldritch bloodline, native brilliance, or sheer, stubborn determination. This Focus cannot be taken by heroes with the Mage or Partial Mage classes.

Level 1: Choose an attribute; its modifier is increased by +1, up to a maximum of +3. The actual score does not change, but the modifier increases, and may increase again if later advancement improves the attribute enough. You can choose this Focus more than once to improve different attributes.

Diplomatic Grace

Your skill at personal negotiations is enormous and uncanny. Some might even think it supernatural in nature.

Level 1: Gain Convince as a bonus skill. You speak all the languages common to your region of the world and can learn new ones to a workable level in a week, becoming fluent in a month. Reroll 1s on any skill check dice related to negotiation or diplomacy.

Level 2: Once per day, silently consecrate a bargain; the target must make a Mental save to break the deal unless their life or something they love as much is imperiled by it. Most NPCs won't even try to break it. The deal must be for something specific and time-limited, and not an open-ended bargain.

Gifted Surgeon

You have an unusual gift for saving Mortally Wounded allies and quickening the natural recovery of the wounded in your care.

Level 1: Gain Heal as a bonus skill. You may attempt to stabilize one Mortally Wounded adjacent person per round as an On Turn action. When rolling Heal skill checks, roll 3d6 and drop the lowest die. You heal twice as many hit points as usual when applying first aid after a battle, as described on page 48.

Level 2: Your curative gifts count as magical healing. You can heal 1d6+Heal skill in damage to an adjacent wounded ally as a Main Action, potentially reviving them without any lingering Frailty. Each such application of healing adds 1 System Strain to the target, and the gift cannot be used on targets already at their maximum System Strain.

Henchkeeper

You have a distinct knack for picking up lost souls who willingly do your bidding. You might induce them with promises of money, power, excitement, sex, or some other prize that you may or may not eventually grant. A henchman obtained with this Focus will serve in loyal fashion until clearly betrayed or placed in unacceptable danger. Henchmen are not "important" people in their society, and are usually marginal sorts, outcasts, the desperate, or other persons with few options.

You can use more conventional pay or inducements to acquire additional henchmen, but these extra hirelings are no more loyal or competent than your pay and treatment can purchase.

Level 1: Gain Lead as a bonus skill. You can acquire henchmen within 24 hours of arriving in a community, assuming anyone is suitable hench material. These henchmen will not fight except to save their own lives, but will escort you on adventures and risk great danger to help you. Most henchmen from a civilized society will be treated as Peaceful Humans from the bestiary section of the book. You can have one henchmen at a time for every three character levels you have, rounded up. You can release henchmen with no hard feelings at any plausible time and pick them back up later should you be without a current henchman.

Level 2: Your henchmen are remarkably loyal and determined, and will fight for you against anything but clearly overwhelming odds. Whether through natural competence or their devotion to you, they're treated as Veteran Soldier from the bestiary section. You can make faithful henchmen out of skilled and highly-capable NPCs, but this requires that you actually have done them some favor or help that would reasonably earn such fierce loyalty.

Impervious Defense

Whether through uncanny reflexes, remarkable luck, supernatural heritage, or magical talent, you have natural defenses equivalent to high-quality armor. The benefits of this Focus don't stack with armor, though Dexterity or shield modifiers apply.

Level 1: You have an innate Armor Class of 15 plus half your character level, rounded up.

Level 2: Once per day, as an Instant action, you can shrug off any single weapon attack or physical trauma inflicted by a foe. Environmental damage, falling damage, or other harm that couldn't be forfended by strong armor cannot be resisted this way.

Impostor

You are exceedingly skilled at presenting yourself as something you are not, including disguises, voice mimicry, and lightning-fast wardrobe changes. Some impostors rely on the acting skills of Perform, while others lean more to the nefarious tricks of Sneak.

Level 1: Gain Perform or Sneak as a bonus skill. Once per scene, reroll any failed skill check or saving throw related to maintaining an imposture or disguise. Create one false identity of no great social importance; you can flawlessly pretend to be that person, such that only extremely persuasive proof can connect you with it. You can change this identity with a week's worth of effort in building a new one.

Level 2: You can alter your clothing and armor such that a single Main Action lets you swap between any of three chosen appearances. In addition to your original false identity, you can establish a new false identity in each city or significant community you spend at least a day in.

Lucky

Some fund of remarkable luck has preserved your life at least once in the past, and continues to give you an edge in otherwise hopeless situations. This luck does not favor the already-blessed; this Focus can only be taken by a PC with at least one attribute modifier of -1 or less.

Level 1: Once per week, a blow or effect that would otherwise have left you killed, mortally wounded, or rendered helpless somehow fails to connect or affect you. You make any rolls related to games of chance twice, taking the better roll.

Level 2: Once per session, in a situation of need or peril, you can trust to your luck and roll 1d6. On a 2 or more, something fortunate will happen to further your goal, provide an escape from immediate peril, or otherwise give you an advantage you need, if not immediate victory. On a 1, the situation will immediately grow much worse, as the GM sees fit.

Nullifier

Something about your hero interferes with easy use of magic on them. It may be a strangely powerful birth blessing, a particular supernatural bloodline, or simple occult incompatibility. This Focus cannot be taken by Mages or Partial Mages.

Level 1: You and all allies within twenty feet gain a +2 bonus to all saving throws against magical effects. As an On Turn action, you can feel the presence or use of magic within twenty feet of you, though you can't discern details about it or the specific source. The first failed saving throw against a magical effect you suffer in a day is turned into a success.

Level 2: Once per day, as an Instant action, you are simply not affected by an unwanted magical effect or supernatural monstrous ability, even if it wouldn't normally allow a saving throw. Immunity to a persistent effect lasts for the rest of the scene.

Poisoner

You are a skilled poisoner, capable of compounding toxins out of readily-available flora and minerals. It takes an hour to brew a poison, and you can keep as many doses fresh as you have levels. Blade venoms take a Main Action to apply and last for ten minutes or until a hit or Shock is inflicted, whichever comes first. Detecting poisoned food is a Wis/Notice skill check against 10, or 12 if the diner's not a noble or otherwise normally wary of poison. One dose can poison up to a half-dozen diners.

Level 1: Gain Heal as a bonus skill. Gain a reroll on any failed saving throw versus poison. Your toxins inflict 2d6 damage plus your level on a hit or Shock, with a Physical save for half. Your incapacitating or hallucinogenic toxins do the same, but those reduced to zero hit points are simply incapacitated for an hour.

Level 2: You are immune to poison and can apply a universal antidote to any poisoned ally as a Main Action. Any attempt to detect or save against your poisons takes a penalty equal to your Heal skill. Your ingested poisons count as an Execution Attack against unsuspecting targets, as per page 44, with Heal used for the Physical saving throw penalty and 1d6 damage per level done on a success. Such poisons can be non-lethal at your discretion.

Polymath

You have a passing acquaintance with a vast variety of practical skills and pastimes, and can make a modest attempt at almost any exercise of skill or artisanry. Note that the phantom skill levels granted by this Focus don't stack with normal skill levels or give a skill purchase discount. Only Experts or Partial Experts can take this Focus.

Level 1: Gain any one bonus skill. You treat all non-combat skills as if they were at least level-0 for purposes of skill checks, even if you lack them entirely.

Level 2: You treat all non-combat skills as if they were at least level-1 for purposes of skill checks.

Rider

Anyone with any level of Ride skill can fight competently on horseback or keep their mount healthy. You have an almost supernatural bond with your steeds, however, and can push them beyond normal limits.

Level 1: Gain Ride as a bonus skill. Your steeds all count as Morale 12 in battle, use your AC if it's higher than theirs, and can travel 50% further in a day than normal for their kind. You can intuitively communicate with riding beasts, gaining as much information from it as its intellect can convey.

Level 2: Once per scene, negate a successful attack against your steed as an Instant action. Once per scene, reroll any failed Ride skill check. You can telepathically send and receive simple warnings, thoughts, and commands to and from your steed so long as it's within two hundred feet. You can so bond with one steed at a time, taking an hour to do so.



Shocking Assault

You're extremely dangerous to enemies around you. The ferocity of your melee attacks stresses and distracts enemies even when your blows don't draw blood.

Level 1: Gain Punch or Stab as a bonus skill. The Shock damage of your weapon treats all targets as if they were AC 10, assuming your weapon is capable of harming the target in the first place and the target is not immune to Shock.

Level 2: In addition, you gain a +2 bonus to the Shock damage rating of all melee weapons and unarmed attacks that do Shock. As usual, regular hits never do less damage than this Shock would do on a miss.

Sniper's Eye

You are an expert at placing a thrown knife or arrow on an unsuspecting target. These special benefits only apply when making an Execution Attack with a bow, hurlant, or thrown weapon, as described on page 44.

Level 1: Gain Shoot as a bonus skill. When making a skill check for a ranged Execution Attack or target shooting, roll 3d6 and drop the lowest die.

Level 2: You don't miss ranged Execution Attacks. A target hit by one takes a -4 penalty on the Physical saving throw to avoid immediate mortal injury. Even if the save is successful, the target takes double the normal damage inflicted by the attack.

Special Origin

Heroes in *Worlds Without Number* are assumed to be human, or close enough as to make no real difference. PCs who want to belong to some more exotic species or demihuman kind can pick the origin Focus appropriate to their chosen species, such as those given in the bestiary chapter for different types of creatures.

The availability of these special origins will depend on the campaign and the GM's permission. Even if elves and dwarves do exist in the campaign world, the GM is not obliged to let players use them as PCs if that choice doesn't fit the tone or location being used.

Note also that a PC who just wants to be different without asking for any special mechanical benefits does not need to buy any special Focus. If their particular demihuman or alien has no real advantages over a human, then they can just proclaim their nature as such, assuming the GM allows such beings in their campaign.

Specialist

You are remarkably talented at a particular skill. Whether a marvelous cat burglar, a famed athlete, a brilliant scholar, or some other savant, your expertise is extremely reliable. You may take this Focus more than once for different skills.

Level 1: Gain any skill as a bonus, except for Magic, Stab, Shoot, or Punch. Roll 3d6 and drop the lowest die for all skill checks in this skill.

Level 2: Roll 4d6 and drop the two lowest dice for all skill checks in this skill.

Spirit Familiar

You have a minor spirit, devil, construct, magical beast, or other creature as a devoted companion. While its abilities are limited, it is absolutely loyal to you.

Level 1: Choose a form for your familiar no smaller than a cat nor larger than a human. It has the traits and abilities of an entity created by *Calculation of the Evoked Servitor* on page 68, but may be summoned or dismissed as a Main Action, appearing within melee range of its owner. It cannot carry objects with it during its vanishment aside from the clothing natural to its shape. It has no need for food, water, or sleep. If killed, it vanishes and cannot be re-summoned for 24 hours. Once per day, it can refresh one point of Committed Effort for you.

Level 2: Pick two benefits from the list below for your familiar. This level may be taken more than once, adding two additional options each time.

- It has hit points equal to three times your level
- It gains the ability to attack with a hit bonus equal to half your level, rounded up, doing 1d8 damage on a hit with no Shock
- It gains a +1 skill check bonus and can apply it to a range of situations equivalent to one normal human background
- It gains another shape of your choice which it can adopt or discard as an On Turn action
- It can hover or fly at its usual movement rate
- It can communicate freely with others in any language you know

Trapmaster

You have uncommon expertise in handling traps and snares, both mundane ones and the magical perils sometimes found in Deeps or the lairs of sorcerers. You know how to improvise traps with materials you easily carry.

Level 1: Gain Notice as a bonus skill. Once per scene, reroll any failed saving throw or skill check related to traps or snares. Given five minutes of work you can trap a portal, container, passageway, or other relatively narrow space with foot snares, caltrops, toxic needles, or other hazards. Non-lethal traps cause the first victim to trigger it to lose a round of actions while dangerous ones inflict 1d6 damage plus twice the character's level, with an appropriate saving throw for half. Only one such improvised trap can be maintained at a time. More fearsome traps may be laid with congenial circumstances and the GM's permission.

Level 2: You know secrets for unraveling even magical traps or arcane hazards that would normally require a wizard to dispel them. Once per scene, your efforts count as an *Extirpate Arcana* spell against the trap or hazard, cast as if a Mage of twice your level, with any relevant skill check being Int/Notice or Dex/Notice. This ability can be used against any stationary magical effect that's susceptible to being dispelled by *Extirpate Arcana*.

Unarmed Combatant

Your empty hands are more dangerous than swords in the grip of the less gifted. Your unarmed attacks are counted as melee weapons when it comes to binding up opponents wielding bows and similar ranged long arms, though you need at least one hand free to do so.

Level 1: Gain Punch as a bonus skill. Your unarmed attacks become more dangerous as your Punch skill increases. At level-0, they do 1d6 damage. At level-1, they do 1d8 damage. At level-2 they do 1d10, level-3 does 1d12, and level-4 does 1d12+1. At Punch-1 or better, they have the Shock quality equal to your Punch skill against AC 15 or less. While you normally add your Punch skill level to any unarmed damage, don't add it twice to this Shock damage.

Level 2: Even on a miss with a Punch attack, you do an unmodified 1d6 damage, plus any Shock that the blow might inflict on the target.

Unique Gift

Your hero has some unusual ability or magical knack that can't be adequately described by an existing Focus. This choice is a catch-all meant to represent a special power that's in some way worth a Focus pick.

The exact effect of the ability should be defined by the player and the GM together, working out some result that seems fair and reasonable. This will vary from table to table and from campaign to campaign; an innate ability to breathe water is little more than a novelty in a desert setting, while a campaign based on piracy in an endless archipelago might make it far more significant.

As with any power, the group should be willing to reconsider the gift if it turns out to be exceptionally weak in play or a stronger power than was anticipated.

Valiant Defender

You are a bodyguard, shieldbearer, or other gifted defender of others, accustomed to the roil of bloody battle and desperate struggle. You have an exceptional ability to shield your allies from the attacks of those who would slay them.

Level 1: Gain Stab or Punch as a bonus skill. Gain a +2 on all skill checks for the *Screen Ally* combat action. You can screen against one more attacker per round than your skill would normally allow. Once per round, you can *Screen Ally* against even intangible spells or magical attacks or bodily shield them from an area-effect explosion or magic. Such attempts require the usual successful opposing skill check, with the assailant using their Magic skill.

Level 2: The first *Screen Ally* skill check you make in a round is always successful. Gain +2 AC while screening someone. You can screen against foes as large as ogres or oxen.

Well Met

You have a striking ability to charm and pacify people and creatures you've just met. Once they get to know you, however, their opinions are more likely to be based on experience; this Focus works only once on a target.

Level 1: Reaction rolls made by those the party meets are given a +1 bonus so long as you are present, whether or not you do the talking. Even hostile encountered beings will usually give the party a round to parley before attacking unless they're in ambush or have a clear reason for immediate violence.

Level 2: Once per game session, when a reaction roll is made, cause the subject to be as friendly and helpful to you and your party as it's plausibly possible for them to be. It's up to the GM to decide why the creature becomes so; it might be mistaken about your nature, or find you hilarious, or perhaps want a favor from you and your allies.

Whirlwind Assault

You are a frenzy of bloody havoc in melee combat, and can hack down numerous lesser foes in close combat... assuming you survive being surrounded.

Level 1: Gain Stab as a bonus skill. Once per scene, as an On Turn action, apply your Shock damage to all foes within melee range, assuming they're susceptible to your Shock.

Level 2: The first time you kill someone in a round with a normal attack, either with its rolled damage on a hit or with the Shock damage it inflicts, instantly gain a second attack on any target within range using any Ready weapon you have.

Xenoblooded

You have been both blessed and cursed by the Outsiders, gaining the ability to survive in alien environments that humans were never meant to tolerate. This may be from ancient modifications made to your lineage in order to make them better servants, or it could be that you're some sort of alien-human hybrid yourself. Those cursed with such a hated heritage usually have considerable physical variations from human normality, and usually try to pass themselves off as merely an unusual kind of demihuman or unfortunate human mutant.

Level 1: Choose one set of benefits from the list below to reflect your alien heritage. Other gifts may exist.

- You are immune to heat damage and can breathe and see through smoke without hindrance.
- You are water-adapted and can breathe water and see through it up to 120' regardless of light. You swim at double your normal Move rate.
- You were built to heavier or lighter gravity conditions; gain a +1 to either your Strength or Dexterity modifiers, to a maximum of +3, and a -1 penalty to the modifier of the other attribute.
- You are nourished by invisible radiations and need neither eat, sleep, nor breathe. You can see clearly even in the absence of any light.

FINAL TOUCHES

The final stage of creating your hero involves noting down some numbers and particulars to round off their creation. You'll need to roll their starting hit points, pick a free skill, and do a little extra record-keeping to save time during play.

ROLL YOUR STARTING HIT POINTS

Roll to determine your initial maximum hit points; if you run out of them, your PC will be mortally wounded or killed outright. The die you roll depends on your class: Warriors roll 1d6+2, Experts roll 1d6, and Mages roll 1d6-1, with Adventurers using the tables on page 21 depending on which partial classes they picked. Add your Constitution modifier to this roll to get your initial maximum HP, with a minimum of 1 point even for heroes with a Constitution penalty.

PICK A FREE SKILL

Pick one skill of your choice to reflect your hero's past interests, talents, or professional work, gaining it at level-0 proficiency. If you already have this skill at level-0, it becomes level-1. You cannot use this free pick to improve a skill that's already at level-1.

RECORD YOUR SAVING THROWS

Note down your beginning saving throw scores for your Physical, Evasion, Mental and Luck saving throws. Physical saves against poison, disease, or exhaustion are 15 minus the best of your Strength or Constitution modifiers. Evasion saves to dodge sudden perils or dive away from explosives are 15 minus the best of your Intelligence and Dexterity modifiers. Mental saves to resist psychic influence or mind-bending sorceries are 15 minus the best of your Wisdom or Charisma modifiers. Your Luck save is a flat score of 15, and rolled against when only blind luck can save you.

RECORD YOUR BASE ATTACK BONUS

Your hero has a certain minimal competence in combat, regardless of their combat skills or the weapon used. This base attack bonus varies with their class, and is noted on the class tables. Write it down on your sheet.

MAGES CHOOSE STARTING SPELLS

Spellcasting full Mages begin play knowing four first-level spells and partial Mages begin play knowing two. Adventurers with two partial spellcasting Mage classes, such as a partial Necromancer/partial High Mage know four. These spells may be chosen from any spell list available to them. A novice High Mage, for example, would pick first-level spells from the High Magic spell list, while a new Elementalist could pick them from either the High Magic or Elementalist spells.

RECORD STARTING LANGUAGES

Characters begin with the knowledge of their native language, Trade Cant, and fluency in additional ones based on their Connect and Know skill levels. Level-0 in either grants one more language and level-1 grants two. Thus, a PC with Connect-1 and Know-1 skills would start fluent in their native tongue, Trade Cant, and four additional languages of their choice. Increasing Connect or Know skills later can allow them to learn one more language for each level they gain, as can spending a few months immersed in a culture. On page 107 you'll find a list of the tongues common to the Gyre region of the Latter Earth.

CHOOSE STARTING EQUIPMENT

You can either pick a starting equipment package from the choices on the opposite page, or roll 3d6 x 10 to find out your starting silver pieces to spend on gear or keep in your pocket. The starting packages will generally give you more equipment than the random roll would, but items can be swapped at the GM's discretion.

RECORD WEAPONS AND ARMOR

Now that you know what kind of weaponry or armor your hero has, take a moment to record the total hit bonus for your weaponry. This is equal to your base attack bonus plus your relevant Stab, Shoot, or Punch skill, and the relevant attribute modifier for the weapon given on the table on page 37. If two attributes are listed for a weapon, use whichever is better for you. If you lack even level-0 skill in the weapon, take a -2 hit penalty with it.

For each weapon's damage and Shock, note down the information from the table. You add your attribute modifier to both damage rolls and Shock. Punch weapons or unarmed attacks can also add your Punch skill.

For your PC's Armor Class, record the AC of the armor you usually wear. Unarmored humans have an AC of 10. Armor Class is modified by your Dexterity modifier, improving it on a bonus and worsening it on a penalty.

PICK A NAME, GOAL, AND TIES

Lastly, crown your newly-minted hero with a suitable name, a goal in life, and a reason why they are willing to adventure with the other PCs.

It is crucial for every PC to have an active goal in the world, something they are willing to risk their life to pursue. This goal can and almost certainly will change as play goes on, but they need a reason to venture out into the world, risk terrible dangers, and seek great deeds. Make sure your goal is one that won't interfere with the fun of the rest of the group.

Aside from that, you also need a reason to trust and work with your comrades. You may not like each other very much, but you should have enough faith in each other to be willing to dare great adventures together.

EQUIPMENT PACKAGES

To determine your hero's starting equipment you may pick a suitable package from the selections below. Optionally, you can roll 3d6 x 10 to find out your PC's starting silver and purchase items individually from the section starting on page 33. As a matter of simplicity, it's often easiest to simply pick a serviceable package and perhaps swap out an item if the GM thinks it's reasonable.

PCs are assumed to have an ordinary suit of clothing and such small personal effects as anyone would carry on their person. Such things do not count against the

hero's Encumbrance, as explained on page 32, though a spare set of clothing kept in a backpack would do so.

The equipment packages include the Encumbrance cost of each item. Remember that armor must be worn Ready in order to do any good, and weapons that are kept Stowed will take an extra Main Action to get ready for use. Backpacks and other storage gear generally counts as Stowed unless the hero wants to tie it loosely and thus be ready to drop it at a moment's need... such as when they may need to outrun a slower compatriot.

Adventuring Peasant	Enc
War Shirt (AC 11)	0
Large Shield (AC 14 when held)	1
Light Spear (1d6 dmg, Shock 2/AC 13)	1
Dagger (1d4 dmg, Shock 1/AC 15)	1
Backpack	1
Rations, 1 week	4
Mule and small cart	-
Tinder box and 3 torches	1

Armored Warrior	Enc
Pieced Armor (AC 14)	2
Large Shield (+1 AC when wearing armor)	1
Short Sword (1d6 dmg, Shock 2/AC 15)	1
Dagger (1d4 dmg, Shock 1/AC 15)	1
Backpack	1
Tinder box and 3 torches	1

Gentry Wayfarer	Enc
Buff Coat (AC 12)	0
Small Shield (AC 13 when held)	1
Short Sword (1d6 dmg, Shock 2/AC 15)	1
Backpack	1
Rations, 1 week	4
Waterskin	1
Fine suit of clothing carried in the pack	1
Writing kit & 20 sheets of paper	1
20 silver coins in cash	-

Ranger or Archer	Enc
Buff Coat (AC 12)	0
Bow, Large (1d8 damage, no Shock)	2
20 arrows & quiver	1
Dagger (1d4 dmg, Shock 1/AC 15)	1
Hand Axe (1d6 dmg, Shock 1/AC 15)	1
Backpack	1
Cooking utensils and 1 week of rations	5 total
Waterskin	1
Tinder box and 3 torches	1
20 silver pieces in cash	-

Roguish Wanderer	Enc
Buff Coat (AC 12)	0
Small Shield (AC 13 when held)	1
Short Sword (1d6 dmg, Shock 2/AC 15)	1
Throwing Blades, 5 (1d4 dmg, no Shock)	1
Backpack	1
Rations, 1 week	4
Waterskin	1
Tinder box and 3 torches	1
Grappling hook and 50' of rope	2 total

Mage, Healer, or Scholar	Enc
Daggers, 2 (1d4 dmg, Shock 1/AC 15)	2
Staff (1d6 dmg, Shock 1/AC 13)	1
Backpack	1
Lantern, tinder box, and 2 pint flasks of oil	3 total
Writing kit & 20 sheets of paper	1
Rations, 1 week	4
Waterskin	1
Healer's pouch	1
80 silver pieces in cash	-



EXAMPLE CHARACTER CREATION

At the start of a new campaign, Jack needs to roll up a fresh hero. He has no particular ideas about what to play, so he rolls 3d6 six times to find his PC's initial statistics, getting results of Strength 9, Dexterity 6, Constitution 10, Intelligence 12, Wisdom 12, and Charisma 9. His hero is a very ordinary person in the main, if perhaps a little slower and clumsier than most. His attribute modifiers are all +0, except for Dexterity, which is -1.

Because Jack chose to roll his attributes, he can swap one score out with a score of 14, giving it an attribute modifier of +1. Jack decides to hold off that decision for a moment until after he's picked his background and class, so he can become better at whatever will serve his hero best.

Trusting the dice for inspiration, Jack decides to roll randomly to find out what kind of background his hero possesses. The dice tell him that he was formerly a Peasant. The gods clearly have no special favor for this budding hero.

Jack's a little amused at how this hard-luck hero is shaping up, so he decides to continue with the random theme in rolling for skills. He gets a Peasant's automatic free skill of Exert-0 and then can roll three more times on either the Growth or Learning tables for the background. If he'd chosen his skills instead, he'd only be allowed to pick two more from the Learning table, and couldn't roll or pick from the Growth table at all.

Jack chooses to roll once on the Growth table and twice on the Learning table, for the results of "Any Skill", "Sneak", and "Work". Being a peasant, Jack decides that his "Work" result refers to his farming and husbandry skills, and "Sneak" suggests that he wasn't the most honest of men, which leaves Jack suspecting that his young peasant was a poacher. That means his "Any Skill" is probably best chosen as Shoot, for taking game in secret. As a result, Jack's hero now has skills of Exert-0, Work-0, Sneak-0, and Shoot-0.

If he's to be a hard-bitten peasant poacher, then he's going to need to be a better shot with his bow. Jack decides to put his free 14 score into Dexterity, improving its modifier from -1 to +1. He's now a much better Bowman and stealthier sneak.

Jack needs to decide on his hero's class now. While there's no rule that the new PC couldn't have become a wizard after his youth as a peasant and poacher, Jack decides that he's really not a good fit for being a Mage. While he's a good archer, he's also not really a slayer of men by profession or inclination, so Warrior is out as well. Expert seems the most likely choice, with his focus being on his sneaking and woodsman skills.

Jack thinks a bit on whether to make him an Adventurer with partial Warrior and partial Expert classes. While that would make him considerably tougher and more dangerous with his bow, a pure Expert has a versatility in skill use that an Adventurer can't match. Jack

decides that with a decent Shoot skill and an Expert's natural competence at fighting, he ought to be able to hold his own in battle without splitting his class.

Having decided on a background and class, Jack needs to pick two Foci for his hero: one non-combat one suitable for an Expert, and one of any kind he wishes. For the first, Jack decides that his hero is *Alert*, his senses honed by a life of constant watchfulness and fear of the authorities. The Focus gives him Notice as a bonus skill, which Jack adds to the PC's sheet as Notice-0.

For the second, Jack decides it'd be fun to add a little bit of the uncanny to this poacher, and gives him the *Spirit Familiar* Focus. His faithful hunting-beagle Limper starved last winter when the game was too scarce and the warden too watchful, but the beast was too loyal to notice. Now Limper's spirit manifests as a perfectly ordinary-looking dog, yet one with an intuitive knowledge of the PC's wishes and a positively human sharpness of intellect.

Jack now looks at the hero's current list of skills: Shoot-0, Exert-0, Notice-0, Sneak-0, and Work-0. He may pick one skill of his choice as a free pick, and decides to round off his competence with Survive-0, to reflect the hero's experience in living rough and enduring privations.

With these choices, the hero is mostly finished. All that remains is some recording-work of writing down bonuses and totals as described on page 28 and rolling the hero's initial maximum hit points. As an Expert with a Constitution modifier of +0, Jack rolls 1d6 and gets 4. One good spear-thrust is likely to down the poacher, so Jack resolves to steer clear of combat whenever possible.

Jack also needs to pick equipment for the hero. Rather than spend the time and effort of sorting through the equipment lists, he just picks the "Ranger or Archer" equipment package as a good fit for his needs.

Yet the important task of choosing a name, a character goal, and a suitable tie to the rest of the group remains. A downtrodden peasant poacher could come from almost any quarter of the Gyre, but Jack decides that Llaigis is the best fit for his hero's history. That grim land doesn't lack for oppressive lords and harsh privation. If he's from Llaigis, Jack decides his hero is Ulf, a thin, scarred Khalan man who expects nothing good from life but is willing to be surprised. He ran away from his lord when brutal taxes led to Limper's starvation, and now his burning ambition is to be so rich and powerful that he will be able to avenge himself on his cruel former master.

Jack decides that when Ulf met the party out hunting, Limper took a liking to them. The poacher trusts the dog's judgment implicitly, so he'll gladly cooperate with the rest of the party. The young Khalan is willing to take any job that shows a prospect of paying well or striking at a corrupt noble, so the GM makes a note to use these goals as convenient adventure hooks. Ulf is now ready to go forth and adventure.

WORLDS
WITHOUT NUMBER

NAME	_____
PLAYER	_____
HOMELAND	_____
OCCUPATION	_____
RACE/SPECIES	_____
GOAL	_____
DESCRIPTION	_____

BACKGROUND	_____
DETAILS	_____

CLASS	_____
BENEFITS	_____

LEVEL.	
XP	Lv1 2 - 3/6 sp Lv1 3 - 6/15 sp Lv1 4 - 12/36 sp Lv1 5 - 18/46 sp Lv1 6 - 27/51 sp Lv1 7 - 29/69 sp Lv1 8 - 36/72 sp Lv1 9 - 21/65 sp Lv1 10 - 93/139
BASE ATTACK BONUS	
MELEE ATTACK BONUS (+STR Mod.)	
RANGED ATTACK BONUS (+DEX Mod.)	
INITIATIVE BONUS (+DEX Mod.)	

SKETCH OR SIGIL

[illegible]

	Worn	Armor	AC	Special
	☐			
☐				
☐				
☐				

DEX Mod. _____

Current	System Strain	SAVES
		PHYSICAL 16-HI - STR/CON Mod. EVASION 16-HI - DEX/INT Mod. MENTAL 16-HI - WIS/CHA Mod. LUCK 16-HI

WEAPONS				
Name	Bonus to Hit	Damage	Range	Special and Shock
Name	Bonus to Hit	Damage	Range	Special and Shock
Name	Bonus to Hit	Damage	Range	Special and Shock
Name	Bonus to Hit	Damage	Range	Special and Shock
Name	Bonus to Hit	Damage	Range	Special and Shock
AMMUNITION				
Name	Bonus to Hit	Damage	Range	Special and Shock

SKILLS		SKILL POINTS	
Administer	Lead	Sail	
Connect	Magic	Shoot	
Convince	Notice	Sneak	
Craft	Perform	Stab	
Exert	Pray	Survive	
Heal	Punch	Trade	
Know	Ride	Work	

EQUIPMENT, ARMOR, AND WEAPONRY

There are countless different currencies in the Latter Earth, some familiar enough and others largely incomprehensible to outsiders. Some places use no recognizable “money” at all. In most regions, however, some variety of metal coinage is used. While it lacks the occult power of certain ancient magic-based currencies, it can be minted by any local lord with a furnace and a hammer. Many do, and the finer points of coin purity, weight, and value are of keen interest to merchants the world over.

For most adventurers, however, a coin is a coin. Copper coins are the daily-use money of urbanites, where village folk more often trade goods and services through a complex but well-understood balance of favors done and owed. Silver coins are for larger purchases, while golden coins are the currency of rich merchants, nobles, and others who deal with great affairs.

Silver is the usual currency of record, with the prices of most expensive goods given in silver pieces. Amounts in gold are often considered more honorable, and so a lord’s income or a king’s reward will often be phrased in terms of gold coins, even if ultimately paid in silver.

Common Exchange Rates

1 gold coin	is	10 silver coins
1 silver coin	is	10 copper coins

ENCUMBRANCE

There is a limit to the amount of gear that a hero can comfortably carry. While a GM is perfectly justified in deciding to handle the matter loosely, and to just eyeball a reasonable maximum for the party’s allowed gear, some prefer a more organized system.

Encumbrance is measured in **items**. Most ordinary objects that can be comfortably carried in one hand count as one item. Two-handed weapons, heavy objects, or unwieldy things count as two, or sometimes even more in the more extreme cases.

Very small objects do not count as items unless carried in unusual numbers. Normal clothing being worn does not count as an item. Gems, jewelry, and other small objects usually aren’t tracked as items, though every full 100 coins counts as one item.

Bulk goods such as torches, empty waterskins, oil flasks, or the like can be bundled together, with three of them counting as one item. Such carefully-packed bundles require a Main Action to break open if the PC wants to get at the contents, however.

A hero can carry a number of **Readied** items equal to half their Strength attribute, rounded down. Readied items include worn armor, carried shields, weapons sheathed or at the ready, or anything else the PC wants immediate access to. PCs can use Readied items as part of whatever action they’re doing without taking any extra

BUYING EQUIPMENT AND SERVICES

The following tables give the common prices for assorted goods, weapons, armor, and services of interest to adventurers. These prices are usually significantly higher than those that would be paid by a reasonably well-connected local or native; adventurers and other wayfarers tend to pay a premium for their gear. A prudent, patient native might pay half as much for many of these things.

Most of the equipment listed can be acquired in any decent-sized market town or city. Truly costly items of several thousand silver pieces or more may require special contacts to purchase in a timely fashion, or else the patience to wait out the equipment’s construction.

In villages and other rural areas, much of this gear will be unavailable at any price. The village guardians might have a few spare spears or battered buff coats to sell at a stiff mark-up, but hurlants, war-horses, chain hauberks, and other expensive, specialized gear is unlikely to be available save by pure luck and much silver.

Hirelings and other servants are most easily found in towns and cities as well, though a village may have a few strapping lads willing to risk their necks for more silver than they’ll see in half a life. If those lives are cut short, however, don’t expect replacements to step forward.

time to draw them, dig them out of a pack, or get them ready for use. Thus, a hero with a sheathed sword that is Ready can draw it as part of the attack they’re making, and a hero with a Readied magical potion can quaff it without spending any extra time finding it in his pack.

A hero can carry a number of **Stowed** items equal to their full Strength score. Stowed items are tucked away in packs, carefully organized in pouches, and otherwise stored so as to be as compact as possible. A hero who wants to use a Stowed item needs to spend a Main Action digging it out before they can employ it.

Characters can push their limits by carrying more than is comfortable. An extra two Readied or four Stowed items can be carried, but this slows them down; their Move action allows them to move only 20 feet instead of 30. A further two Readied or four Stowed items can be carried beyond that, but that slows them down to 15 feet per Move action.

It’s assumed that the heroes have sufficient packs, sacks, pockets, and pouches to actually carry all of their gear. While a PC might have enough Strength to cart around a dozen pieces of adventuring gear, if they don’t have a backpack or some other way of actually storing these things, the GM may not allow them to do it. In the same vein, some relatively light objects that are very bulky or awkward might count as several Encumbrance points.

ADVENTURING GEAR

Most of the equipment listed below is largely self-explanatory. The prices given are average for adventurers in most urban areas, though acquiring some of the objects may be more costly in less prosperous surroundings.

Some groups prefer to have less fine-grained tracking of a party's resources and would rather not record each torch and flask of oil. Those who would prefer to be a little more general can instead use the adjacent gear bundle options, assuming the GM permits it.

Adventuring Gear

Item	Cost	Enc
Arrows, 20	2 sp	1
Backpack	2 sp	1§
Boots	2 sp	1§
Candle	1 cp	*
Cart, one-horse	50 sp	N/A
Clothes, common	25 sp	1§
Clothes, fine	100 sp	1§
Clothes, noble	500 sp	2§
Cooking utensils	4 sp	1
Crowbar	4 sp	1
Firewood, one night's fire	2 cp	4
Flask, metal, one pint	3 sp	1
Grappling hook	5 sp	1
Hammer or small tool	2 sp	1
Healer's pouch	5 sp	1
Hurlant bolts, 20	20 sp	1
Iron spikes, 10	1 sp	1
Lantern	10 sp	1
Mirror, hand	10 sp	*
Oil, one pint	1 sp	1#
Paper, 10 sheets	1 sp	*
Rations, one week	5 sp	4
Rope, 50'	2 sp	2
Sack	1 sp	1
Shovel, pick, or similar tool	4 sp	2
Tinder box	1 sp	*
Torch	2 cp	1#
Waterskin, one gallon	1 sp	1
Writing kit	3 sp	1

* the item is effectively weightless in modest numbers
§ the item doesn't count for encumbrance purposes while being worn

can be bundled in units of three for the same encumbrance, with a Main Action to break open a bundle to get at the contents

GEAR BUNDLES

Depending on the tastes of the group, some parties might enjoy tracking every torch and carefully weighing their resource expenditures on perilous expeditions. Others prefer to gloss over the details. The "gear bundle" options below cover all the non-weapon, non-armor gear expected of a particular role and the usual encumbrance weight of it all. The specific contents of each bundle are as broad as the GM finds reasonable for the role. A GM who prefers exact accounting can disallow bundles.

Gear Bundles

Item	Cost	Enc
Artisan's Equipment	50 sp	5
Criminal Tools	100 sp	3
Dungeoneering Kit	200 sp	6
Noble Courtier Outfit	1,000 sp	2
Performer's Implements	100 sp	3
Wilderness Travel Gear	100 sp	5

BEASTS AND TRANSPORT

The animals below are generally similar to those known in contemporary Earth, though subtle changes in behavior or physiology are common. Some nations have access to exceptionally swift flying beasts or remarkable airships surviving from former days, but the availability of such exotic modes of transport is at the GM's discretion.

Beasts and Transport

Item	Cost
Horse, riding	200 sp
Horse, draft	150 sp
Horse, battle-trained	2,000 sp
Mule	30 sp
Cow	10 sp
Ox, plow-trained	15 sp
Chicken	5 cp
Pig	3 sp
Dog, working	20 sp
Sheep or goat	5 sp
River ferry, per passenger	5 cp
Ship passage, per expected day	2 sp
Carriage travel, per mile	2 cp
Rowboat	30 sp
Small fishing boat	200 sp
Merchant ship	5,000 sp
War galleon	50,000 sp

HIRELINGS AND DAY LABOR

The party may find it useful to employ temporary labor in their adventures, either for extra warm bodies in combat or for the special talents the hireling might bring.

Adventuring hirelings will demand at least a half-share of treasure in addition to their daily pay and will undertake no risks that their employers don't share. Their combat statistics will be as normal for their type, usually equal to a common human soldier for most. After a particularly dangerous adventure, the hireling must make a Morale check; on a failure, they decide the adventuring life is too risky, and will no longer accompany the party.

On the rare occasions that a competent mage can be found willing to hire out their services, they almost never have spellcasting abilities beyond that of a first or second level Mage.

Most communities have a limited number of men and women willing to risk an awful doom while adventuring. If the party makes a habit of returning without their employees, the GM may well decide that no further locals are willing to sign on.

Non-adventuring hirelings who are employed to guard the party's residence, haul their equipment on expeditions, work on their behalf, and otherwise conduct normal business will require no more than their daily wage. If they can't go home at the end of the day, food and fit lodgings must be provided as well.

Where it matters, common hirelings can be assumed to have a total +1 bonus on relevant skill checks.

Hirelings and Day Labor

Item	Cost/day
Bard of Small Repute	2 sp
Common Prostitute	2 sp
Dragoman or Skilled Interpreter	10 sp
Elite Courtesan	100 sp
Farmer	1 sp
Guard, ordinary	2 sp
Guard, sergeant, for every ten guards	10 sp
Lawyer or Pleader	10 sp
Mage of Minor Abilities	200 sp
Mundane Physician	10 sp
Porter willing to go into the wilds	5 sp
Porter only for relatively safe roads	1 sp
Navigator	5 sp
Sage, per question answered	200 sp
Sailor	1 sp
Scribe or Clerk	3 sp
Skilled Artisan	5 sp
Unskilled Laborer	1 sp
Veteran Sellsword	10 sp
Wilderness Guide	10 sp

SERVICES AND LIVING EXPENSES

Heroes who are sufficiently established as to have their own homes or businesses can live comfortably on their own resources. Other PCs, however, must pay for their keep when not out adventuring.

Impoverished lifestyle costs cover only the bare minimum of food and a mostly-dry squat to sleep in. Heroes who can afford nothing better suffer a -1 penalty to all social skill checks due to their unkempt state and must make a Physical saving throw each night to benefit from the usual nightly decrease in System Strain.

Common lifestyle fees for an adventurer usually cover adequate food and a shabby private inn room. No penalties or benefits are granted by living this way.

Rich lifestyle costs generally include a rented townhouse, a small staff of servants, and social entree into high society circles that are forgiving of the nouveau riche... at least, as long as their coin remains good.

Noble lifestyles provide the very best the community can offer in fine lodging, luxurious food, sycophantic servants, and the provisional friendship of useful parasites. Once per game session, the PC can ask a favor of a hanger-on in their retinue, who will perform it if it is not more than mildly humiliating, dangerous or illegal.

Aside from these weekly lifestyle costs, some other services often required by adventurers are listed. Individual circumstances and the quality of the help hired may drastically increase these fees, and bribes are not always successful in buying forbearance.

Services and Living Expenses

Item	Cost
Impoverished lifestyle, per week	5 sp
Common lifestyle, per week	20 sp
Rich lifestyle, per week	200 sp
Noble lifestyle, per week	1,000 sp
Magical healing of wounds	10 sp/hp*
Magical curing of a disease	500 sp*
Lifting a curse or undoing magic	1,000 sp*
Casting a minor spell	250 sp*
Bribe to overlook a minor crime	10 sp
Bribe to overlook a major crime	500 sp
Bribe to overlook a capital crime	10,000 sp
Hire someone for a minor crime	50 sp
Hire someone for a major crime	1,000 sp
Hire someone for an infamous crime	25,000 sp

* These services are rarely available without personal connections or doing special favors, and many communities may lack them entirely.

ARMOR

While some martial adepts or tradition-bound sorcerers shun armor, most adventurers find it necessary to put something solid between them and their enemies.

Armor must be worn as a Readied item, counting against the hero's encumbrance limit. Each type of armor grants a different base Armor Class to the wearer, making it more difficult for enemies to land a telling blow. This Armor Class is modified by the wearer's Dexterity modifier and by any shield they might carry, as described below. Multiple suits of armor do not stack; only one can usefully benefit a wearer at any one time.

A hero wearing no armor at all has a base Armor Class of 10, modified by their Dexterity modifier. If they pick up a shield they can improve this to either AC 13 or AC 14, depending on the size of the shield.

Light armor may be decidedly heavy, but it is loose and flexible enough to offer minimal hindrance to the wearer's actions. Some varieties are also discreet enough to be worn politely in common society. **Medium armor** is significantly noisier and more overt; it cannot be worn discreetly and applies its encumbrance as a penalty to any physical Sneak rolls made by the wearer. **Heavy armor** is the thickest, toughest panoply available on the market, and its bulk and noise make its encumbrance apply as a penalty to Sneak or Exert checks made by the wearer.

The armors listed on the table are simply some of the most common harness to be found in the Latter Earth. Enchanted and exotic panoply can be found in many places, some of which is scarcely recognizable as armor.

Shields come in two general varieties. Small ones, often made of costlier metal, can be strapped to the wearer's arm and allow them to hold and manipulate objects with that hand, albeit not wield a weapon with it. Larger shields are of cheaper wood and require a good grip.

A small shield user has a base AC of 13, while a large shield user has a base AC of 14. Unlike other armor, however, if the user is already wearing equal or better armor the shield grants a +1 bonus to their AC. Shields allow the bearer to ignore the first instance of Shock they might otherwise suffer in a round.

War shirts are nothing more than blessed shirts, lucky cloaks, auspicious warpaint, or whatever tokens of martial victory are favored by the poor and humble of a given culture. While they may look like nothing but normal clothing, their war-luck is still sufficient to interfere with a spellcaster's abilities should they try to wear one.

Buff coats are long coats of thick, supple hide, sometimes worn to cushion the bite of heavier armor and sometimes sported as ornamented street clothing for the gentry who can afford such luxuries. **Linethorax** armor is a stiffer armor of glued, layered cloth, often as elaborately decorated as the arts of its maker allow.

A **war robe** is a catchall term for various outfits involving layers of reinforced cloth or leather. Bits of metal, layers of thick hide, or weaves of tough cordage might all go into the various layers of the suit, making it a very heavy, if effective, piece of equipment.

Armor

Light Armors	AC	Cost	Enc
No Armor	10	None	N/A
War Shirt	11	5 sp	0
Buff Coat	12	50 sp	0
Linethorax	13	20 sp	1
War Robe	14	50 sp	3
Pieced Armor	14	100 sp	2
Medium Armors			
Mail Shirt	14	250 sp	1
Cuirass and Greaves	15	250 sp	2
Scaled Armor	16	500 sp	3
Heavy Armors			
Mail Hauberk	16	750 sp	2
Plate Armor	17	1,000 sp	2
Great Armor	19	2,000 sp	3
Grand Plate	16	2,000 sp	3
Shields			
Small Shield	13	20 sp	1
Large Shield	14	10 sp	1

Pieced armor is assembled of a thicker or more durable chestpiece and piecework limb armor. While less effective than a proper cuirass and greaves, it's often the best that scavengers or poor adventurers can get.

Mail shirts are usually of iron or steel wire, though bronze and other more exotic materials are not unknown. Such shirts cover only the vitals of the wearer, but are much less burdensome than a full hauberk.

Cuirass and greave armor reflects those different designs that rely on solid metal plating over the wearer's vitals along with lighter limb armor. **Scaled armor** includes both armor of metal scales on a flexible backing, brigandine, jacks of plate, and other armor made up of small, connected plates that cover most of the wearer's body. Most are noisy, heavy suits, albeit flexible ones.

A **mail hauberk** in the listed style covers not only the wearer's chest, but also their arms, with a long skirt extended to the knee. **Plate armor** is an extremely expensive suit of tailored metal pieces that cover both the vitals and the limbs of the wearer. **Great armor** is less finely tailored, relying instead on stacking layer upon layer of mail, plates, hide, cloth, and other protective materials.

Grand plate is so finely-jointed that a weapon must either be very large or very armor-piercing to harm the wearer; they're immune to non-magical melee or thrown weapons unless the weapon is two-handed, has a Shock rating of AC 16 or more, or the wearer is currently grappled by someone as per the rules on page 43. This tight protection comes at the cost of the thick plating found in great armor or conventional plate.

WEAPONS

The tools of a bloody trade are familiar to most adventurers. While some Vowed or trained pugilists might scorn the use of material weapons, most sentient combatants must rely on something better than their natural gifts.

Each of the weapons on the adjacent page has a listed damage it inflicts on a successful hit, an amount of Shock inflicted on a miss to targets with an AC equal or less than that given, and a particular attribute relevant to the weapon's use. That attribute's modifier is applied to all hit rolls, damage rolls, and Shock inflicted by the weapon. If more than one attribute is listed, the wielder can use whichever one is better. Using a melee weapon without at least Stab-0 skill inflicts a -2 penalty on hit rolls, as does using ranged weapons without at least Shoot-0 skill. Thrown weapons can be used with either.

Ranged weapons have both short and long ranges listed in feet. Attacking a target within short range may be done at no penalty, while hitting a target at long range is done with a -2 penalty to the hit roll. Two-handed ranged weapons cannot be used while an enemy is locked in melee with the wielder, and even one-handed or thrown weapons suffer a -4 penalty to hit in such circumstances.

Some weapons have additional unique traits, perhaps being particularly slow to reload, or requiring two hands to wield correctly, or being easily hidden in common clothing. The GM might choose to apply these traits to improvised weapons snatched up by the PCs if any of them seem appropriate.

Axes given here are those fashioned for war; lighter and more agile than their working cousins, though still capable of hacking through a door or hewing a cable if needed. War axes are big enough to demand two hands for their use.

Blackjacks include not only obvious weapons loaded with sand or iron shot, but any small, stunning fist load. A blackjack or other small fist load is easily concealed as some ornamental component of ordinary clothing.

Bows cover everything from the small self bows of horse archers to the man-tall longbows wielded by foot archers. Larger bows are more cumbersome and impossible to shoot from horseback, but usually have superior strength. An archer with a Readied quiver can load a fresh arrow as a Move action each turn, or as an On Turn action if they have at least Shoot-1 skill.

Claw blades are the sharper kin of fist loads, being small blades or finger talons that are easily concealed or disguised as metal ornaments. While they are vicious weapons, they can't be usefully thrown.

Clubs, staves, and maces are of much the same genus, though the latter is usually made of metal. While fully capable of killing a man, a careful user can usually avoid inflicting lethal injury.

Crossbows come in heavier varieties than the one listed, but such slow, bulky arbalests are rarely in the hands of adventurers. Reloading a crossbow of this size takes a full Main Action, but due to the simplicity of their

operation, someone without Shoot-0 can still use them at no unskilled hit penalty.

Daggers come in ten thousand varieties, but the listed kind is a common fighting dirk, big enough to push through light armor while remaining small enough to be discreetly hidden. **Stilettoes** and similar armor-piercing daggers aren't usually effective as thrown weapons.

Halberds and other polearms can be somewhat awkward in narrow spaces, but remain popular military weapons in some armies. The statistics given here can also be used for fauchards, bills, voulges, spetums, bardiches, glaives, guisarmes, guisarme-glaives, glaive-guisarme-glaives, and similar weapons.

Hammers listed here are the fighting variety, narrow-headed and made for penetrating or shocking heavy plates of armor.

Hurlants are a wide range of ancient and modern projectile weapons that launch specially-prepared charges through various means, both sorcerous and semi-scientific. The tremendous accumulation of ancient Legacy manipulations intended to disarm subject populations and restrict advanced weaponry to a given age's ruling caste has made it very difficult to create firearms, as most conventional chemical or magical reactions are specifically disrupted by the Legacy.

Hand hurlants are usually pistol-sized, most often carried by the wealthy as a single-shot opener at the start of hostilities. Long hurlants are rifle-sized weapons favored by elite snipers and assassins who don't expect a need for a second shot. Great hurlants are usually eight feet long and a hundred pounds in weight, and launch tremendous bolts that can transfix even monstrous targets. Those able to afford their use generally mount them on ships, gun carriages, or on important fortifications.

Hurlants are too expensive and difficult to craft to be practical as widespread military weapons in most regions. In some areas, even hurlants fail to function correctly; a GM who prefers not to include them can simply disallow them in their own campaign region.

Spears, and their longer cousin the **pike**, are common military weapons throughout the Latter Earth. Lighter spears are effective thrown weapons, while heavier two-handed versions penetrate armor well.

Shields can be an effective weapon when used to bash or pummel an enemy. If used as a weapon or as part of a dual-wielding attack, a shield grants no AC or Shock protection benefits until the wielder's next turn.

Swords are common sidearms throughout the Latter Earth. The expense of forging a large blade makes it a symbol of wealth and status in many cultures, and its convenience makes it a favored arm for street wear.

Throwing blades are small leaves or spikes of steel that are not terribly useful as melee weapons but are easy to carry discreetly in considerable numbers.

The **unarmed attack** given here is a common punch or kick, unimproved by a Vowed's arts or a Focus. Unarmed attacks add the assailant's Punch skill to the damage roll as well as the attack roll.

Weapon	Dmg	Shock	Attribute	Range in Feet	Traits	Cost	Enc
Axe, Hand	1d6	1/AC 15	Str/Dex	10/30	T	10 sp	1
Axe, War	1d10	3/AC 15	Str	-	2H	50 sp	2
Blackjack	1d4	None	Str/Dex	-	S, LL	1 sp	1
Bow, Large	1d8	None	Dex	100/600	2H, R, PM	20 sp	2
Bow, Small	1d6	None	Dex	50/300	2H, R, PM	20 sp	1
Claw Blades	1d6	2/AC 13	Str/Dex	-	S	10 sp	1
Club	1d4	None	Str/Dex	10/30	T, LL	-	1
Club, Great	1d10	2/AC 15	Str	-	2H	1 sp	2
Crossbow	1d10	None	Dex	100/300	2H, SR, PM	10 sp	1
Dagger	1d4	1/AC 15	Str/Dex	30/60	S, T, PM	3 sp	1
Halberd	1d10	2/AC 15	Str	-	2H, L	50 sp	2
Hammer, Great	1d10	2/AC 18	Str	-	2H	50 sp	2
Hammer, War	1d8	1/AC 18	Str	-		30 sp	1
Hurlant, Great	3d10	None	Dex	600/2,400	FX, SS, AP	10,000 sp	15
Hurlant, Hand	1d12	None	Dex	30/60	SS, AP	1,000 sp	1
Hurlant, Long	2d8	None	Dex	200/600	2H, SS, AP, PM	4,000 sp	2
Mace	1d6	1/AC 18	Str	-	LL	15 sp	1
Pike	1d8	1/AC 18	Str	-	2H, L	10 sp	2
Shield Bash, Large	1d6	1/AC 13	Str	-	LL	-	-
Shield Bash, Small	1d4	None	Str/Dex	-	LL	-	-
Spear, Heavy	1d10	2/AC 15	Str	-	2H	10 sp	2
Spear, Light	1d6	2/AC 13	Str/Dex	30/60	T	5 sp	1
Throwing Blade	1d4	None	Dex	30/60	S, T, N	3 sp	1
Staff	1d6	1/AC 13	Str/Dex	-	2H, LL	1 sp	1
Stiletto	1d4	1/AC 18	Dex	-	S, PM	10 sp	1
Sword, Great	1d12	2/AC 15	Str	-	2H	250 sp	2
Sword, Long	1d8	2/AC 13	Str/Dex	-		100 sp	1
Sword, Short	1d6	2/AC 15	Str/Dex	-		10 sp	1
Unarmed Attack	1d2+Skill	None	Str/Dex	-	LL	-	-

WEAPON TRAITS

Some of the weapons listed above have certain specific traits that affect their use.

2H: *Two Handed.* The weapon requires two hands to use in combat. Ranged two-handed weapons cannot be fired effectively while an enemy is within melee range.

AP: *Armor Piercing.* This weapon ignores non-magical hides, armor and shields for purposes of its hit rolls.

FX: *Fixed.* The weapon is too heavy and clumsy to use without a fixed position and at least five minutes to entrench it.

L: *Long.* The weapon is unusually long, allowing melee attacks to be made at targets up to 10 feet distant, even if an ally is in the way. Even so, the wielder still needs to be within five feet of a foe to count as being in melee with them for purposes of forcing **Fighting Withdrawals**, disrupting large ranged weapons, or similar maneuvers.

LL: *Less Lethal.* Foes brought to zero hit points by this weapon can always be left alive at the wielder's discretion.

N: *Numerous.* Five of these count as only one Readied item.

PM: *Precisely Murderous.* When used for an Execution Attack, the weapon applies an additional -1 penalty to the Physical save and does double damage even if it succeeds.

R: *Reload.* The weapon takes a Move action to reload. If the user has at least Shoot-1 skill, they can reload as an On Turn action instead.

S: *Subtle.* Can be easily hidden in ordinary clothing or concealed in jewelry.

SR: *Slow Reload.* It takes a Main Action to reload this weapon.

SS: *Single Shot.* This weapon takes ten rounds to reload, and the reloading effort is spoiled if an enemy melees the wielder.

T: *Throwable.* While the weapon can be used in melee, it may be thrown out to the listed range as well, albeit it does no Shock in that case. Throwing a weapon while a foe is in melee range applies a -4 penalty to the attack roll.

THE RULES OF THE GAME

Every hero must encounter situations in which the outcome is not a given. Whether putting steel to the lapdogs of some corrupt noble or leaping among the rooftops of an ancient city's slums, they will often attempt deeds that may not be so successful as they would wish. A GM needs fair and consistent systems by which to judge these efforts and give the players the right rewards for their daring.

This chapter contains the rules for *Worlds Without Number*. With the characters made in the prior chapter and the guidelines given here, a GM should be able to adjudicate the great majority of the challenges and daring exertions undertaken by the heroes.

THE BASIC SYSTEMS

There are a few basic systems in the rules that every GM and player should understand. These particular systems come up regularly during play, and it can slow down the game considerably if they need to be explained too often.

Skill checks are used whenever the PCs are attempting some feat of skill that doesn't involve combat. When the PCs try to climb an obsidian cliff, persuade a crime boss to sell them some juicy blackmail material, pick the lock of a Deep's treasure-vault, or do something else that requires expertise, a skill check is in order. This section also describes those situations in which a skill check is *not* necessary, such as when the feat is something ordinary for a character's background or too uninteresting to merit the roll.

Saving throws are rolled when the heroes try to dodge some dire fate. Poisons, evil spells, stumbling plunges into fathomless pits, and resisting the pangs of privation might all call for a saving throw. Not every misfortune allows a save; a spear in the gut must be evaded with efforts in combat, and not with an Evasion save. Even so, a GM can always call for a particular save to give a hero a chance to escape the worst of some other calamity.

Combat is something almost inevitable to most campaigns, though it can be lethal for novices and scarcely less dangerous for more experienced heroes. This system will help you find out whether your PC has succeeded in gutting the Anak warrior who was trying to brain them, or if their skull has been smashed by his iron club. Cunning maneuvers to save your own hide or perforate your foe are described in this section, along with rules for the Shock of bloody melee and the panic of broken Morale.

Players familiar chiefly with more modern games are encouraged to give the combat section a careful read. The heroes of *Worlds Without Number* have nothing in the way of plot armor or special mechanical advantage in avoiding death. Confident daring that might be perfectly appropriate to more narrative-based games can be a quick return ticket to character generation here. Heroes are mortal, and should carry themselves accordingly.

USING THESE SYSTEMS IN PLAY

While every player is encouraged to read and understand the basics of the foregoing systems, a practical GM must recognize that the great majority of players will read and digest no more of a rulebook than they absolutely must, and often not even so much as that. A GM needs to know how to use these systems, and how to handle certain issues that are likely to crop up in play.

Be willing to translate actions into rolls. There is a certain breed of player who is fun to play with, engaged in the game, and a credit to the group... but quite unable to master specific rules. They may just not be very good at it, or they may have so little time outside of the game that they really can't afford to spend it studying rulebooks.

For players like these, just let them say what they're trying to do and then tell them what to roll. If they say they're swinging their axe at a bandit, just tell them to roll 1d20, see if they hit, and then tell them what damage die to roll. The player may or may not pick up the rules eventually, but you'll keep things moving quickly.

The GM decides what is rolled. The players always decide what their heroes are trying to do, but the GM decides what they roll for it, or if any roll is possible or needed at all. A PC with Convince-4 skill may be great at persuading others of things, but they can't just decide that they're going to talk a duke into handing over a border keep and then reach for their dice to roll a skill check. The GM is the one who decides if a particular action is plausible, whether it can be accomplished by a skill check at all, and if so, what the skill and difficulty will be. A PC's manner of action might make a roll harder, or easier, or even omit it entirely if their actions are particularly apposite or hopeless.

The GM makes the rules. While this chapter has many rules in it, not all of them will be right for every game table. Groups will dislike certain rules, and forget others, and reinterpret a few more. Just because a rule is in this book does not mean it has to exist at your table. The GM and the group know best what kind of game they want to have, and if they think a different rule ought to be used, then they're probably right. Ultimately, the GM's decision about which rules best suit the campaign and group they're working with are final, and no contradiction in this book can make them wrong.

Lastly, **hold these rules lightly.** If you can't remember a rule mid-game, then make a call that sounds reasonable and keep going. Spending five minutes digging through the chapter for an edge-case rule isn't as good as taking ten seconds to make a judgment call and playing on. There will be time to look it up afterwards and decide if the printed rule is better. To help you, the quick reference sheet on page 59 is formatted to be printed off for use at the table, and any often-missed rules you need to add can be scribbled on the back.



SCENES, TURNS, AND DURATIONS

Most time can be tracked relatively loosely during play but sometimes it becomes important to know how long it takes to accomplish a particular activity, or how long a magical effect can be trusted to last.

The *scene* is the basic measurement for most effect durations. A scene is simply one general event or activity. A single fight is a scene, infiltrating a smuggler's warehouse is a scene, negotiating with a merchant prince is a scene, and so forth. So long as the PCs are doing the same general thing in the same general place, it's usually a single scene.

Most scenes last no longer than fifteen minutes or so, though some stretch is possible at the GM's discretion. Many powers and abilities are listed as lasting for one scene; this means that when the PCs trigger them while doing something, the effect is going to last for as long as they keep up their current activity. If it runs particularly long, however, a GM is justified in letting these effects run out partway through.

SAVING THROWS

Adventurers tend to face horrors of innumerable varieties, from the festering poison that smears some Deep-dwelling degenerate's bone spear to the shadow of falling stones from above to the bite of some devil-wizard's hideous sorcery. In order to avoid perishing to such dooms, they can attempt a *Saving Throw*. A saving throw is a chance a hero has to avoid some particularly grim outcome.

To make a saving throw, the subject rolls a d20 and tries to roll equal or higher than the relevant saving throw score. There are four different kinds of saving throws.

Evasion saves are made to dodge hurled perils, take cover from explosions, pull back from sudden pits, and face other challenges of nimbleness and reaction speed. Evasion saves for PCs are equal to sixteen minus the hero's level and minus the best of their Intelligence or Dexterity modifiers. Thus, a third-level hero with an Intelligence modifier of +1 and a Dexterity modifier of -1 would have an Evasion save of 12.

Mental saves are made to resist mind-affecting magic, disbelieve illusions, throw off intangible magical afflictions, and other tests of willpower or force of character. Mental saves for PCs are equal to sixteen minus the hero's level and minus the best of their Wisdom or Charisma attribute modifiers.

Physical saves are made to resist poisons, diseases, exhaustion, bodily transformation, or other taxes on the subject's physical strength. Physical saves for PCs are equal to sixteen minus the hero's level and minus the best of their Strength or Constitution modifiers.

Sometimes it's important to track the time of a more complex operation, like exploring a Deep or navigating the trackless depths of some ancient ruin. In such cases, the *turn* is a common measure of time. Each turn lasts ten minutes and is equivalent to one scene for those situations when it matters.

GMs use turns to track exploration usually, so as to keep a firm grip on light sources running out, unplanned monster encounters, movement speeds, and other important elements of delving into pits of ineffable darkness.

Situations that don't require this degree of carefulness with time-tracking can generally be glossed over as taking so many hours or however many days they might require. GMs are advised to keep a calendar on hand, however, and mark off time accordingly when the PCs are at their adventures. A land that seems to dwell in ageless indeterminate summer can sometimes lack a little something in verisimilitude.

Luck saves are for occasions of blind random fortune, where no quality of personal strength or cunning can help the hero. The GM might call for a Luck save when it really is nothing but sheer good luck that a hero might avoid some danger. Luck saves for a PC are equal to sixteen minus the hero's level, unmodified by any attribute.

Note that saving throws are meant to be last-ditch chances to avoid the worst of unusual perils or uncommon dangers. You can't make an Evasion saving throw to dodge a sword stroke; that's what the hit roll is for. It's up to the GM to decide whether a particular danger might allow a saving throw or not.

MONSTERS AND SAVING THROWS

Monsters, NPCs, and other creatures other than PCs don't bother with four different saving throws. Instead, they just have a single save equal to 15 minus half their hit dice, rounded down. Thus, a peasant with one hit die would have to roll 15 or better to make a saving throw against something, while a slaving hell-beast with 14 hit dice would only need to roll 8+ to succeed.

Some monsters might have particular bonuses against certain kinds of effects or perils, and the GM might decide to give some exceptional humans a boost based on their possession of unusual quickness or bodily fortitude.

SKILL CHECKS

Most characters are skilled, competent men and women who are perfectly capable of carrying out the ordinary duties of their role. Sometimes, however, they are faced with a situation or challenge beyond the usual scope of their role and the GM calls for a *skill check*.

To make a skill check, roll 2d6 and add the most relevant skill level and attribute modifier. If the total is equal or higher than the check's difficulty, the check is a success. On a failure, the PC either can't accomplish the feat at all or they achieve it at the cost of some further complication to the situation. The GM determines the specific outcome of a failure.

If the character doesn't even have level-0 in the pertinent skill, they suffer a -1 penalty to the roll. In the case of particularly technical or esoteric skills they might not even be able to attempt the skill check at all.

Some checks might be suitable for more than one skill. A javelin-throwing contest might use Exert for being an athletic contest, or Shoot for involving a ranged weapon, or Stab for using a muscle-powered thrown weapon. In such cases the PC can use the best applicable skill. In other situations, a skill might seem peripherally relevant; trying to find the damaged component in the ancient magical engine before it explodes would certainly be Magic, but a GM might also let Notice or Craft be applied, as a skilled craftsman or sharp-eyed observer might be able to recognize signs of damage. In such peripheral cases, the check difficulty usually increases by 2.

Skill Check Difficulties

- | | |
|-----|---|
| 6 | A relatively simple task that is still more than the PC would usually be expected to manage in their regular background. Anything easier than this isn't worth a skill check. |
| 8 | A significant challenge to a competent professional that they'd still succeed at more often than not. |
| 10 | Something too difficult to be expected of anyone but a skilled expert, and even they might fail. |
| 12 | Only a true master could expect to carry this off with any degree of reliability. |
| 14+ | Only a true master has any chance of achieving this at all, and even they will probably fail. |

Particularly helpful or hostile circumstances might give a bonus or penalty to the skill check. As a general rule, extremely bad circumstances or tools would apply up to a -2 penalty to the skill check, while a very good situation or the perfect set of tools might give up to a +2 bonus to the roll. Usually, no combination of modifiers should add more than +2 or -2 to any given skill check.

WHEN TO CALL FOR A CHECK

The GM calls for skill checks, but they should only be called for challenges that fall outside the PC's background and common experience. A PC with the background of a sailor should not be rolling skill checks to dock a ship or navigate to a commonly-known destination. As a general rule of thumb, if failure at a particular task would make the PC seem notably incompetent at their role in life, then they shouldn't have to roll a skill check for it. In addition, if failure or success at a check really doesn't *matter* in the game, if it won't produce some interesting result either way, then a check shouldn't be made.

Even concept-related feats might require a skill check, however, if the situation is especially bad or the circumstances particularly hostile. The sailor might have to make a Sail skill check to dock a ship if they attempt it in the middle of a gale wind, and a noble might have to make a Connect skill check to find shelter with an aristocratic relation if they're currently wanted by the Witch-King's inquisitors.

AIDING A SKILL CHECK

Sometimes one PC will want to lend a hand to another as they attempt a difficult feat. To do this, the player first describes what sort of action they are taking to help their comrade. If the GM agrees that their effort makes sense and would be helpful, the player then rolls a relevant skill check against the same difficulty as the original check. If it's a success, the other PC gets a +1 bonus on their roll. Multiple PCs can try to help, but the acting PC can't earn more than a +1 total bonus.

The helping skill doesn't necessarily have to be the same skill the PC is checking. If a player can think of a way to help a Sneak check with Convince, then so be it.

OPPOSED SKILL CHECKS

Sometimes a PC wants to accomplish something that another character wants to prevent. Sneaking past an alert guard, winning an archery tournament, or besting a squamous monster in a tentacle-wrestling competition might all be opposed skill checks.

In such cases, all participants roll their relevant skills and the highest score wins, with ties going to the PC. To make the NPC's roll, check their listed skill bonus; they can add it to any skill check appropriate to their role or profession. If the NPC has no reason to be particularly good at the challenge, they simply roll 2d6 and add nothing.

In most cases, the relevant skills are obvious. A character trying to skulk past a vigilant guard would be rolling their Dex/Sneak against the guard's roll, while one trying to out-tentacle a monster would be rolling Str/Exert. When in doubt, the GM decides which skill or attribute is most applicable.



COMBAT

A hero's trade being what it is, it's to be expected that the PCs might find themselves locked in bloody battle. The rules below explain how such frays are to be managed, but every hero must remember well their own mortality. Even a veteran hero may fall to the spears of a sufficient mob of foes, and novice adventurers run the risk of death from a single sure stroke of a blade.

ROUNDS, INITIATIVE, AND SURPRISE

Combat and other time-sensitive situations are broken into **rounds**, each of which is roughly six seconds in length. During a round every participant gets to take a turn, after which a new round begins.

The order of action is determined by **Initiative**. To determine initiative, each side rolls 1d8 and adds the highest Dexterity modifier in the group. NPCs usually have no modifier, unless the GM decides they're exceptionally quick. The side with the highest roll goes first in whatever order the members choose, and then the other sides act in their respective order. The PC party wins any initiative ties. At the end of the round, it cycles back to the first group and repeats accordingly.

Optionally, some groups prefer to use "individual initiative", with each participating rolling their own initiative roll and going in order. This takes a little longer and can complicate party plans that require each member to act in a particular sequence, but it also mitigates the risk of the group being overwhelmed by foes before anyone can act. The GM chooses which version to use.

In some cases a group may be ambushed or surprised by a foe. The more alert the targets, the more difficult it is to ambush them; a group of heroes prowling through a Deep is going to be much more difficult to surprise than one having dinner in a tavern. Generally, if the group is alert for danger an ambush has to either crash down on them suddenly or come from an angle or location they never suspected.

If the GM decides that surprise is possible, an opposed Wis/Notice versus Dex/Sneak skill check should be rolled. If the attackers win, they surprise the targets and get a full round of action to themselves before initiative is rolled and the combat progresses as usual. An ambush might also provoke a Morale check in undisciplined or unmilitary targets at the GM's discretion.

ACTIONS IN COMBAT

When it's a given participant's turn in combat, they can take their action. There are four different kinds of actions in combat or other time-sensitive situations.

Main Actions are actions that take up most of the actor's round. Attacking someone, manipulating some device, applying first aid to a downed ally, casting a spell, or other complex actions that would take several seconds to perform are all Main Actions. A participant gets one Main Action every round.

Move Actions involve moving up to the participant's normal movement rate. Thus, a normal human with a movement rate of 30 feet can move up to that distance with a Move action. Climbing, swimming, crossing difficult terrain, or other challenging movement usually is only half as fast as normal combat movement. A participant gets one Move action per round, though they can also choose to spend their Main Action taking an additional Move action if they wish.

A combatant in melee who moves away from their enemy must take a *Fighting Withdrawal* action or suffer a free Instant attack from all enemies in melee with them.

A Move action must spend all its movement at once; it cannot split it around a Main Action. Thus, it's not possible to move 10 feet, shoot a foe with a Main Action, and then dive another 20 feet behind cover.

On Turn Actions are quick, simple acts that take very little time and focus to perform, such as falling prone, saying a few words, a skilled archer reloading a bow from a Readied quiver, drawing out a Readied object, or similar things. A participant can only perform an On Turn action on their own turn, but they can do as many of them as the GM thinks is reasonable.

Instant Actions are so fast and simple that the participant can use them at any time, even when it's not their turn. They can even use them after the dice have been rolled, delaying their use until they're sure the action is needed. Instant actions are generally related to special powers and abilities, like a Warrior's **Veteran's Luck** class ability or certain magical arts. If multiple Instant actions are triggered at the same time, they execute in whatever order the GM thinks is most reasonable. There is no limit to the number of Instant actions a participant can take.

This section includes a list of common combat activities and their respective action types. If a PC wants to do something different, the GM should simply pick an action type for it that seems to make sense.

ATTACKING A FOE

When a combatant wants to harm an enemy, they need to make a **hit roll**. An attack usually counts as a Main Action and the assailant must be close enough to actually hit the target with whatever weapon they have to hand.

To make a hit roll, the attacker rolls a d20 and adds their relevant combat skill, their class attack bonus, and their relevant attribute modifier. If they lack even level-0 skill in the weapon being used, they suffer a -2 penalty. Any other situational modifiers or penalties are also added to the roll.

If the total is equal or greater than the target's Armor Class, then the attack hits and damage is rolled. If less, then the attack misses. A missed melee attack may still inflict Shock damage, if the weapon has a Shock rating and the target's Armor Class is equal or lower than it.



To roll damage, the attacker rolls the weapon's listed damage die and adds their relevant attribute modifier and any bonus from a magical weapon, Focus, or other special benefit.

The damage is then subtracted from the target's hit points. If the target is reduced to zero hit points, it is either dead or mortally wounded. Generic NPCs with no name worth remembering are usually dead on the spot. PCs and NPCs significant enough to deserve characterization are instead Mortally Wounded.

Some attacks may not be lethal in nature. If a non-lethal attack reduces a target to zero hit points, the attacker can choose to simply have their victim be unconscious or helpless, unable to act and reviving ten minutes later with one hit point. Attacks that are psychic or emotional in nature may reduce their victims to helpless shock or numbing confusion when they bring them to zero hit points, likewise incapacitating them for ten minutes.

Unarmed attacks can always be non-lethal at the attacker's discretion. Attacks with blunt and relatively forgiving weapons such as batons, staves, or clubs might also qualify, though it may take a Str/Stab or Dex/Stab skill check against the target's Morale score to see whether that last blow pacified them or accidentally knocked their brains out. In ambiguous cases, it's the GM's call as to whether damage is or isn't non-lethal.

A "hit" in combat doesn't always mean a physical blow landed. Creatures or PCs with many hit points might take several "hits" before actually going down. In such a case, these successful hits are blows that exhaust the target, tax their luck, force them out of position, or otherwise bring them closer to losing. It may be that the only serious physical hit is the one that brings them down.

HIT ROLL MODIFIERS

The table below notes some common cumulative hit roll modifiers. GMs should use them as general guidelines when applying their own adjustments to hit rolls for circumstances not listed on the chart.

Circumstance	Mod
Shooting at a distant prone foe	-2
Shooting or meleeing an adjacent prone foe	+2
Melee attacking while prone	-4
The target is at least half behind cover	-2
The target is almost completely in cover	-4
Thrown attack while being meleed by a foe	-4
Shooting a bow while being meleed by a foe	N/A

Note that no penalty is given for shooting or throwing a weapon into a melee. It's assumed that PCs have worked together enough to coordinate such attacks and avoid getting in each other's way. A PC whose combat style is built around ranged attacks can easily end up frustrated by the rest of the party if they have to spend extra effort on special Foci or accept hit penalties simply because the rest of the group prefers to fight up close.

SHOCK DAMAGE

Some melee attacks inflict **Shock**, the inevitable harm that is done when an unarmored target is assailed by something sharp in melee range.

Shock for a weapon is listed in points of damage and the maximum AC affected. Thus "Shock 2/15" means that 2 points of damage are done to any target with AC 15 or less. More heavily-armored targets are immune to the weapon's Shock.

Assailants add their weapon's attribute modifier to Shock, along with any magical bonus to the weapon and any damage bonuses that are explicitly noted as adding to Shock. Other damage bonuses do not increase Shock.

An attack never does less damage on a hit than it would do in Shock. Thus, if an attack that would normally do 4 points of Shock to AC 15 hits a target with AC 13 and rolls a 3 for damage, 4 points are done instead.

DUAL-WIELDING WEAPONS

PCs who wish to wield two one-handed weapons at once may do so if they have at least Stab-1 skill. Doing so grants them a +2 bonus to damage rolls, albeit not to Shock. They suffer a -1 penalty on hit rolls, however, due to the extra complication. Only one weapon may be used to attack in any given round, but either one may be used. Unarmed combatants cannot dual-wield.

SHOVING AND GRAPPLING

To shove a target or force them back, the attacker must first hit the target normally for no damage and then succeed in an opposed Str/Punch or Str/Exert skill check. If the attacker succeeds in the skill check, the target is forced back up to ten feet or knocked prone.

To grapple a foe, the attacker must first hit with an unarmed attack, doing no damage, and then both must make opposed Str/Punch skill checks. If the attacker wins, the defender is grappled and remains that way until released or until they spend a Main Action and succeed in a new opposed check. An attacker can grapple only one target at a time, though multiple attackers can cling to the same luckless defender. In such cases, the defender's single skill check is compared against all of their foes.

While grappling, neither attackers or defenders can move from their current location, nor can they fight with anything but unarmed attacks. At the end of each round in which a defender remains grappled, they suffer damage from each attacker as if hit with an unarmed attack from each foe grappling them.

If the attacker wishes to move the target, they must spend a Main Action and succeed in an opposed Str/Punch skill check. If they win, the target is either moved ten feet along with them, or thrown five feet and knocked prone. If they lose, the defender breaks free.

These rules assume both targets are man-sized. Grappling or shoving significantly larger but still humanoid targets is done at a -2 penalty on all skill checks by the attacker. Doing so to creatures only barely plausible for such manhandling is done at a -4 skill check penalty.

EXECUTION ATTACKS

A target that is completely unaware of danger is vulnerable to a quick and bloody death, no matter how great their martial prowess or how thick their armor. An **Execution Attack** gives an assailant an opportunity to slay a foe with a single well-placed arrow or blade.

Setting up such an attack requires a full minute of preparation. Archers, gunmen, and other ranged attackers must spend it judging distance, wind, and details of aim, while melee assassins must use it to drift up to the target and position themselves in the exact right place for the attack. Melee assassins must use a weapon for an Execution Attack, unless they have such special training as to make their unarmed attacks unusually lethal. If the target is spooked, the opportunity is lost.

Once the preparation is complete, the assailant may use a Main Action to attack. The target's Armor Class is irrelevant, assuming the attacker is using a weapon that can hurt the target. A melee Execution Attack will always hit. A ranged Execution Attack requires a Dex/Shoot skill check against a difficulty of 6 for a point-blank shot, 8 for one at the weapon's normal range, and 10 for a shot at extreme range. A Warrior can use their **Veteran's Luck** ability with this skill check, but it only allows a reroll on a failed check rather than forcing an automatic hit.

If the Execution Attack hits, the target must make an immediate Physical saving throw at a penalty equal to the attacker's combat skill level. If they fail, they are Mortally Wounded on the spot, or knocked unconscious if the attacker was using a plausibly non-lethal weapon. If they succeed, the weapon still does its maximum damage.

Attacking an unconscious or incapacitated target will always leave them Mortally Wounded.

COMMON COMBAT ACTIONS

The actions below include some of the more common actions a participant might take during combat. The GM can make individual judgments about other types of activities that might be attempted.

Make a Melee Attack Main Action

The combatant attacks an enemy within melee range with a Readied weapon, rolling a normal hit roll and inflicting damage on a successful hit. Most melee attacks inflict Shock damage on a miss, if the target's Armor Class is low enough, and no successful hit does less damage than the weapon's Shock would have done on a miss.

Make a Ranged Attack Main Action

The combatant fires or throws a Readied ranged weapon at a target. The combatant can't *Make a Ranged Attack* with a two-handed weapon such as a bow if there's a enemy armed with a melee weapon within melee range; it's too easy for the assailant to hinder the use of a bow. One-handed ranged weapons and thrown weapons can still be used, albeit at a -4 penalty to hit.

Make a Snap Attack Instant Action

A combatant with a Ready weapon can rush their attack, sacrificing accuracy for speed. The combatant must still have their Main Action impending or available. As an Instant, they can sacrifice it to make a melee or ranged attack against a foe, whether a snap shot with a bow or a quick thrust at an adjacent melee foe. This attack takes a -4 penalty to its hit roll. If multiple Snap Attacks go off at the same time, they are resolved simultaneously.

Snap Attacks are normally only possible for PCs and other very well-trained or talented combatants. If an opponent isn't significant enough to have been given a name, they probably shouldn't be using Snap Attacks.

Make a Swarm Attack Main Action

Each assailant takes this action against a target in range of their current weapon, until up to four have done so. When the final participant has taken this action, one of the mob can elect to make an immediate melee or ranged attack against their target, gaining a +2 bonus to hit and +1 to damage for each other surviving attacker, up to +6/+3. This damage bonus does not add to Shock and it cannot drive the attack's damage over the maximum usually possible for the blow, but Shock from it always harms the target, even if they have a too-high AC, are using a shield, or have a Focus immunity to Shock. The sheer swarming numbers of foes are bound to inflict some kind of harm on the target provided they're not completely immune to the mob's weaponry.

Cast a Spell Main Action

An arcanelly-gifted PC can cast a spell as a Main Action. If they've suffered any hit point damage this round, drawn or sheathed an item with their spellcasting hand, or have been severely jostled they cannot take this action. If they suffer hit point damage while casting, such as by someone who has held their action to attack at that moment, the spell fizzles uselessly and the spell slot is wasted.

Charge Special

A combatant can make a wild charge before hurling a weapon or crashing into a foe, moving up to twice their normal move in a straight line before making a melee or thrown attack at +2 to hit. The charging attacker must be able to move at least 10 feet to get the requisite momentum and suffers a -2 AC penalty for the rest of the round. Charging takes both a Move and Main Action.

Shatter a Shield Main Action

To shatter a shield, the attacker must be using an axe, a mace, a Focus-improved unarmed attack, or some other crushing or hewing attack. The maneuver requires a successful hit roll and then an opposed Str/Stab skill check between the attacker and the defender, with the defender gaining a +1 bonus on their check. No damage is done, but if the attacker wins then the shield will be broken. Magical shields cannot be broken this way. Patching a damaged shield takes a scene's work and Craft-0 skill.

Screen an Ally**Move Action**

The PC moves up to their normal Move rate towards an ally and then physically blocks opponents from attacking them, provided they remain within ten feet. Until the PC's next turn, enemies who wish to make a melee or ranged attack against the screened ally must succeed in a successful Str or Dex-based opposed skill check against the PC using the combat skill applicable to their weapon; on a failure, the attack roll is automatically directed toward the screening PC.

A PC can screen against a number of attackers in one round equal to their combat skill; thus, Stab-2 lets them block the attacks of two different attackers. PCs with level-0 or worse combat skills can't effectively screen. Multiple PCs can try to screen the same ally; in such a case, the attacker's skill check is compared against all blockers and the lowest-rolling successful blocker is attacked. PCs can only screen against foes and attacks they could plausibly physically parry or block with a shield.

Total Defense**Instant Action**

As an Instant action, the combatant focuses on nothing other than avoiding knives, arrows, hurled crystalline spears, or other perils in the vicinity. Using *Total Defense* costs the user their Main Action for the round, and cannot be used if they've already employed their Main Action. They become immune to Shock damage for the round, including from *Swarm Attacks*, and gain a +2 bonus to their Armor Class until their next turn.

Run**Move Action**

The combatant moves their normal combat movement rate, which is 30 feet for most humans. If they're climbing a surface, swimming, or navigating extremely rough terrain, this movement rate is halved, and they might have to make an Exert skill check to achieve even that. Prone characters crab along at half this rate.

Make a Fighting Withdrawal**Main Action**

The combatant disengages from any melee foes around them. They don't actually move away, but they can now get away from their assailants without giving them a free melee attack. Usually, this means the combatant uses their Move action to get clear, because if they just stand there the enemies might choose to re-engage them.

Use a Skill**Main Action**

The combatant uses a skill that could be plausibly applied in a few seconds. An Int/Heal or Dex/Heal skill check to stabilize a wounded comrade is one such potential use, as is turning a creaking engine wheel, shouting out a stirring rallying cry to timorous NPC allies, or anything else that might be done quickly.

Ready or Stow an Item**Main Action**

The combatant draws a weapon, extracts an item from their backpack, digs a potion out of a belt pouch, or otherwise moves an object around on their person. They can Ready an item this way or Stow it.

Reload a Weapon**Main Action**

The combatant reloads a weapon like a crossbow or an ancient projectile launcher with a Readied magazine or a quarrel from a Readied quiver. Bows can be reloaded as an On Turn action, assuming the archer has a Readied quiver and Shoot-1 skill; otherwise it's a Move action.

Drop an Item**Instant Action**

The combatant drops something they're holding. They can do this Instantly at any time to free up their hands.

Pick up an Item**Move Action**

The combatant can scoop an object off the floor if they have a free hand, leaving it Readied in their grip.

Stand Up**Move Action**

The combatant gets up from a prone position, gathering any dropped belongings. Most characters that have just been revived from unconsciousness must get up before they do much else.

Go Prone**On Turn Action**

The combatant falls flat, forcing distant ranged attackers to take a -2 penalty to hit them. Adjacent melee enemies find them an easier target, however, gaining +2 to hit.

Hold An Action**Move Action**

By choosing to *Hold An Action*, the combatant can delay taking the rest of their actions until later in the round, activating them as an Instant action. Thus, a hero who wins initiative might use their Move action to *Hold An Action*. Later in the round, as an enemy rushes around a corner, he may Instantly elect to use his Main Action to *Make A Ranged Attack* with his readied crossbow. If acting in response to someone else's impending action, the held action is resolved first.

Delay an Action**On Turn**

The combatant simply chooses to delay the remainder of their actions this turn until after a particular other participant has acted. Such a pause may be needed for some tactical plan or to respond to a particular enemy's action. Unlike *Hold An Action*, however, they cannot suddenly choose to act earlier than their chosen place in the turn order; they must wait until the participant they chose has acted before using whatever remaining actions they may have for the turn.

EXAMPLES OF COMBAT

Combat in *Worlds Without Number* is based on a rules chassis that dates back almost fifty years, but some readers may still be new to it, or a little uncertain of the tweaks and options that the game adds to the classic fundamentals. The following are a few examples of how these rules work in practice.

OUR HEROES

The characters in these examples are ordinary, first-level adventurers fresh into the trade. Having met on a caravan trip into Llaigis, they've resolved to work together to find a better fortune than fate has sent them thus far.

Zenobia is an embittered Adunic clerk let go from the retinue of her beggar-noble employer after the money finally ran out. An Expert in cadging a living any way she can, she wears a buff coat for armor and bears a short sword and a selection of knives, which she uses effectively with her Stab-0 skill. More nimble than most with a Dexterity of 14, she has an effective Armor Class of 13 while wearing the coat, counting the buff coat's value of 12 plus her Dexterity modifier of +1. When she fights with the sword or daggers, her attack bonus is +0 for being a first-level Expert, +1 for her Dexterity, and +0 for her Stab-0 skill, for a total of +1. She adds that +1 Dexterity modifier to the damage dice or Shock of both sword and dagger, as both can be used with either Strength or Dexterity as the modifier to hit and damage, depending on which is better for the wielder.

Kham is a great bull of a man, a back-country Warrior from Emed-Kist with mighty thews and empty pockets. His wealth all went to his harness, which includes pieced armor, a sturdy longsword he uses with Stab-1 skill, and a stout large shield. His Strength of 18 is tremendous, but he's a little clumsy, with a Dexterity of 7. His effective Armor Class is 14 from the pieced armor, +1 for carrying a shield, -1 for his Dexterity modifier, for a total of 14. His hit bonus with the longsword is +1 for being a first-level Warrior, +2 for his Strength, and +1 for his Stab-1 skill. His damage and Shock with the sword are also boosted by his Strength modifier and *Killing Blow* class ability.

Sarra is a Llaigisan hedge-witch driven out of her village on the death of her much-despised mentor, though her powers as a Mage are very real. Proud of her occult arts, she shuns armor, as she can cast no spells while her limbs are profaned by its coarse mundanity. She carries a staff, though she uses it chiefly for driving off exceptionally importunate beggars and starving dogs as she lacks any combat skill at all. With no unusual Dexterity, her Armor Class is 10, for being a normal unarmored person. If driven to use the staff in combat, her hit bonus is +0 for being a Mage, +0 for her attribute modifier, and -2 for lacking even level-0 combat skill, for a total bonus of -2. It does its normal, unmodified 1d6 damage and Shock of 1/AC 13.

THE MEAN STREETS OF GATHIS

The trio wander onto the wrong street in Gathis one night and are set upon by four half-starved thugs. Sickly, unarmored and carrying nothing more than knives, the thugs have AC 10, four hit points each, and do 1d4 damage with their daggers and a Shock of 1/AC 15. In a city like Gathis, a few more bodies in the street will pass without comment in the morning.

As everyone involved was half-expecting trouble, there is no chance for surprise. Each side rolls 1d8 for initiative, adding the best Dexterity modifier of their side. The GM decides the thugs have no particular nimbleness, so rolls 1d8 for a result of 5. The heroes roll 1d8 and add Zenobia's +1 Dexterity modifier to it for a result of 7. The heroes go first.

Zenobia is first to act, deciding on her course of action while the other two players are still mulling their options. She uses her Move action to close with a thug and stabs at him with her Readied short sword, rolling 1d20 and adding her hit bonus of +1, and rolls an 8. Because that's less than the thug's Armor Class, she misses. The sword's Shock value is 1/AC 15, however, which means she still inflicts Shock on him because his AC is less than that of the dagger's Shock value. She inflicts 1 point of damage from the sword and +1 from her Dexterity, for a total of two points. The wretched hooligan yowls as she carves a divot in his beard.

Kham decides that the fight will be much shorter if he thins the enemies early. He uses his Move action to close with the nearest thug and then makes an attack with his longsword, which he has Readied as part of his encumbrance. He rolls 1d20 and adds his +4 hit bonus to the result, unluckily getting a 9. He decides to use his *Veteran's Luck* class ability to turn that miss into a hit, however, rolling 1d8 for damage and adding +3 for his Strength and *Killing Blow*, doing 7 points of damage. This reduces the thug's hit points to zero, and as he's a mere common goon he dies instantly, gurgling out his life.

Sarra decides that hacking up thugs is no part of her role in the group, and uses her Move action to get behind Kham and Zenobia. Her Main Action is given to *Total Defense*, improving her AC by 2 for the rest of the round and making her immune to Shock.

Because the thugs have lost their first comrade, the GM rolls a Morale check for the group on 2d6, getting a 10. This is higher than the thugs' Morale score of 7, so they turn to flee in a reckless, undisciplined panic. The goon engaged with Zenobia turns his back on her and runs; because he doesn't spend his Main action making a *Fighting Withdrawal*, Zenobia gets a free attack on him as he flees. His death is certain, as even if she misses the Shock of her sword will be enough to cut away his last two hit points. The two surviving footpads race down different alleyways, yelping like scalded dogs.

VILLAGE FISTICUFFS

Kham finds himself in a Thurian village, squaring off with the hamlet's strongest farm boy in a "friendly" sparring bout. The lad's broad as an oak tree, with eight hit points, an unarmored AC of 10, and a +2 bonus to hit and 1d4 damage with his fists because the GM decides that sounds about right for a small village's best pugilist. Kham is without his armor or shield and lacks even Punch-0 skill; despite this, his Warrior hit bonus of +1 and his Strength modifier of +2 cancel out the -2 penalty for fighting without a skill, giving him a total of +1 to hit. If he lands a blow, he does 1d2 damage unarmed, +2 for his Strength modifier and +1 for **Killing Blow**. Having no special unarmed Focus, his fists do no Shock.

Initiative is rolled, and the young peasant rolls a 6. Kham also rolls a 6, but has to apply his -1 Dexterity modifier as a penalty, so the boy goes first.

The lad rolls 1d20+2 to hit and gets a 9. Normally an unarmored man has an AC of 10, so it would miss, but clumsy Kham's Dexterity penalty to his AC means that the haymaker lands. The GM rolls 1d4 for damage and gets 4; Kham's down to 4 hit points after that wallop.

Kham retaliates, giving the bumpkin an elbow for a roll of 13 on his 1d20+1 hit roll. He rolls 2 on his 1d2 damage dice, but his great Strength increases that to 4, and his **Killing Blow** ability adds +1, so he loosens the boy's teeth and drops him to 3 hit points.

Staggered but unbowed, the villager misses his next punch with a roll of 6. Kham's blow goes wild as well, but he triggers his **Veteran's Luck** to turn it into a hit, doing 4 points of damage and dropping the big fellow into the dust.

Because the two were fighting with non-lethal weapons and not trying to kill each other, the boy is just winded rather than dead, and in ten minutes or so will regain one hit point and be able to function more or less normally as he buys Kham a round at the village alewife.

A FEARSOME FOE

The heroes are in trouble now. They're face to face with the bandit chief who rules this Deep, an expert combatant with four hit dice, 22 hit points, a +5 bonus to hit with his sword, a Shock score of 2/AC 13, and an Armor Class of 14 with his buff coat and large shield. If they hadn't lured the rest of his men away with a distraction further down the tunnels, they'd be swarmed by now. Luckily, the heroes won the initiative.

The heroes have been working together long enough to have built tactics for a situation like this. Sarra moves in first, her staff up and prodding at the chief to open up his guard. She uses the *Make'a Swarm Attack* action, doing no damage but setting her allies up for a better attack.

Kham follows up, using his Move action to *Screen an Ally* for Sarra and his Main Action to *Make'a Swarm Attack* as well. Zenobia goes in directly for an attack, rolling a 15 and getting a lucky short sword hit in for 1d6+1 damage, with a roll of 5. The chieftain's down to 17 hit points.

Now the two heroes who made a swarm attack can choose one of their number to make a hit roll, gaining +2 to hit and +1 to damage for every other ally who took the action. Kham is the obvious choice, so he rolls 1d20+4 to hit for his sword, +2 for Sarra's help, for a total of 14. That's just enough to hit the chieftain, and he rolls 1d8+4 for damage, rolling a whopping 12 points. That's more than the weapon's maximum without the *Make'a Swarm Attack* bonus, however, so it's capped at 11 points. That still leaves the chieftain down to a mere 6 hit points.

The furious chieftain whips his blade at the unarmored Sarra to cut her down, but Kham's *Screen an Ally* action forces him to make an opposed Str/Stab check against Kham. The GM decides the chief can apply his skill check bonus to the roll, but his 2d6+1 gets an 8, while Kham's 2d6+3 gets a 10. His attack is redirected at Kham.

The chief rolls 1d20+5 to get a 16, enough to hit the Warrior. Worse still, he rolls an 8 for his sword's damage. Kham would be mortally wounded by such a blow, but he triggers his **Veteran's Luck** to negate the hit, letting it glance off his shield rim and miss his head by a hairsbreadth.

On their turn, Sarra and Kham repeat their actions; one more hit from the huge Kistian will probably drop the villain. Zenobia helps with another attack of her own, rolling a mere 6 to hit this time. She tries to apply 2 points of Shock, since her shortsword can do so to AC 15 or less, but the bandit chief's shield negates the first Shock he'd take each round and blocks the sword. Kham rolls his swarm attack with Sarra's help and once again hammers the knave, though he rolls a mere 5 points of damage. The chieftain is left with a single hit point between him and a gory end.

The GM knows the chieftain is a canny survivor. He could probably mortally wound Zenobia or Sarra before he died, if that Kistian ox doesn't get in his way, but if Kham drops his big blade and goes in with a knife and Zenobia joins him with her pigsticker he's going to die from the Shock no matter what happens. Being a rational combatant who prizes nothing as much as his life, he's not going to fight to the death unless he has no choice. Rather than face the prospect of being dragged down and stabbed to death by his assailants, the chieftain uses his Main action for *Total Defense* to hide behind his shield, and swears he'll tell the heroes where he buried his loot if they spare his life....

INJURY, HEALING, AND SYSTEM STRAIN

Despite the eons of meddling and corruption, the Legacy has still conferred a certain degree of health and recuperative ability on the humanity of the Latter Earth. While this hardness is a subtle quality, the natives of this age can recover with unusual quickness.

MORTAL WOUNDS AND STABILIZING

A creature reduced to zero hit points is dead or dying. Ordinary NPCs or unremarkable creatures will generally die on the spot. PCs and those NPCs important enough to have deserved a name will be **Mortally Wounded**.

A Mortally Wounded creature is helpless, unable to do anything but scream, writhe, or lie unconscious. At the end of the sixth round after they were downed, they will die. They'll die instantly if they take more damage.

An ally can attempt to stabilize a Mortally Wounded companion. Doing so is generally an Int/Heal or Dex/Heal skill check, one requiring a Main Action.

The difficulty for this skill check is 8 plus the number of full rounds since the target was downed. If the healer lacks any useful medical implements, the difficulty for this skill check is increased by 2. Only one ally can try to stabilize a target in any given round, though others can attempt to aid their skill check, and a failed check can be re-attempted the next round.

Once stabilized, the target recovers with 1 hit point after ten minutes of rest, and can rise and act normally thereafter. They count as **Frail**, however, and will remain Frail until they have had at least a week of bed rest. Frail PCs cannot heal damage through natural healing and will die immediately if brought to zero hit points again.

A physician can try to remove the Frail condition with an hour's work and a skill check against difficulty 10. They only get one chance to remove a given Frailty.

NATURAL HEALING

A wounded creature recovers its level or hit dice in lost hit points after every night's rest, assuming they're properly fed and can get decent sleep. At this time they also lose one point of accumulated System Strain.

Creatures that are Frail do not recover hit points this way, nor do they lose System Strain.

MAGICAL HEALING

Some healers have access to abilities that automatically heal hit points, such as a Healer's arcane arts or the vitality-transmitting spells of a Necromancer. Other PCs might have elixirs of health, artifacts that cure injuries, or other sources of magical healing.

A character healed by any amount of magical healing automatically loses any Mortally Wounded or Frail qualities and can immediately rise. A downed hero at zero hit points who gets 3 points of healing from a magic potion, for example, can immediately get up on their next turn and return to the fray without any frailty.

FIRST AID

The powerful vitality of the people of Latter Earth can be complemented by skilled medical attention and the use of numerous herbs, compounds, and other "mundane" techniques. While this can't work miracles, it can prevent even significant injuries from slowing a victim too much.

By spending a few minutes tending an ally, a healer can cure 1d6 plus their Heal skill in points of damage. They suffer a -1 on this roll if they have no Heal skill, perhaps doing no good at all. Each such application of first aid adds 1 System Strain to the target, but it can be repeated for a wounded ally as often as the healer wishes and the subject's System Strain allows.

A single ten-minute turn or scene is usually sufficient to apply as much first aid as the party wants to apply. First aid can restore lost hit points to a Frail PC, but it cannot get rid of the Frail quality itself.

SYSTEM STRAIN

Most forms of healing and certain other magical powers add to a target's **System Strain**. System Strain is a measure of how much stress the target's body is under, and how profoundly it has been taxed by magical energies, hunger, privation, and forced healing acceleration.

A character's maximum System Strain is equal to their Constitution attribute. Thus, someone with a Constitution of 13 could accumulate up to 13 points of System Strain. This strain is usually lost at a rate of one point for every night of good, refreshing sleep.

Healing often adds to a target's System Strain, whether as first aid or as the effect of some magical power. If the target is already at its maximum System Strain, it can't handle the additional stress and gets no benefit from the effect or attempting healing.

POISONS AND DISEASES

When a character is struck by some poison, they generally get a Physical saving throw to avoid its effect, or at least mitigate its harm. Particularly powerful poisons might apply a penalty of up to -4 on this check, while weak toxins might grant a bonus of up to +4. The exact effect of a failed save depends on the poison.

Diseases also generally allow a Physical saving throw, but are significantly slower in onset. If the first saving throw is a success, the target has avoided infection. If it's a failure, the disease begins to take hold. The victim can make further saving throw attempts at weekly intervals, generally, with a certain number of successes sufficient to throw off the disease. Each failed save tends to make things worse, however, and fatal diseases can kill after three or four failed saves.

Those with the Heal skill can tend the sick, granting a bonus to their saving throws equal to twice their Heal skill, or +1 in the case of a nurse with Heal-0 skill.

FALLING AND OTHER HAZARDS

An adventurer's lifestyle leaves them susceptible to certain hazards. While every situation has its particulars, the guidelines below can be used to cover some of the most common.

Falling: Most creatures will take 1d6 damage per 10 full feet they fall, up to 20d6 maximum. Spikes or other hazardous terrain at the bottom will add at least 1d6 to the total. A creature that intentionally leaps or skids down in a controlled way may make a Dex or Str/Exert skill check at a difficulty of 7 + 1 for every 10 full feet; on a success, the effective distance fallen is halved.

Suffocation: Creatures can fight or act normally without air for one round per point of Constitution, or 10 rounds for most NPCs. If they don't move, they can quadruple this time. Once they run out of air, they must make a Physical save each round or take 1 hit point of damage per HD or level they have.

Poisons: Typical dungeon poisons found crusted on needle traps force a Physical save or a loss of half the victim's maximum hit points. Very potent ones might kill a victim outright. Those who die due to poison damage usually take at least 1d6 minutes to actually expire, but are helpless in the meanwhile. An antidote applied during this time can revive them with 1 hit point. A skilled healer can try to counteract the toxin with an Int/Heal skill check at a difficult of at least 10 for most poisons, or 12 or more for truly fearsome ones.

Aside from any hit point damage a poison does, many also have lingering side effects, such as penalties to hit rolls or skill checks, or the loss of Move actions for a certain period of time. Some also add System Strain to the victim due to the stress they put on their bodies. A victim forced above their maximum System Strain will collapse and die in minutes if the poison is not neutralized.

OVERLAND TRAVEL

PCs can generally travel for ten hours a day in most seasons, the rest being absorbed in rest, camp construction, and incidental activities. For each hour of travel they can cross as many miles of a given terrain as listed in the table. This travel presumes that the PCs are moving directly toward their destination and not taking any particular time to scout the area for points of interest or investigate their surroundings. This rate of travel also assumes average walking or wagon speeds; horses can be used by their riders for quick bursts of speed to chase or avoid others, but don't increase the average travel rate much.

The roads of the Latter Earth are seldom safe, and even less secure are the trackless wilds surrounding them. For every day of travel and every night of camping outdoors, the GM rolls one die for a wandering encounter check, as explained on page 51. The die used will depend on the terrain, with safer or more peaceful lands using a larger die size. On a 1, the PCs come upon creatures or a situation that requires their attention.

Assuming it's not an ambush or a sudden encounter in an obscured area, the groups usually encounter each other at maximum sight range. An opposed Wis/Notice check can be used to determine who spots who first; PCs who get the edge can usually avoid the other group automatically if they have sufficient cover.

PCs traveling with a caravan or riding a well-stocked travel wagon need not concern themselves with details of food, drink, and shelter, but PCs who plan on making an overland expedition without these ready comforts should consult the rules for overland exploration on the next page for details on the supplies and difficulties involved.

Terrain Type	Miles per Hour
Plains or savannas	3
Light forest or desert	2
Dense forest or rugged hills	1.5
Swamp or marsh	1
Mountains or <i>arratu</i> wastelands	0.5
There is a road through the terrain	x2
Foul weather, mud, or heavy rain	x0.5
Deep snow on the ground	x0.1

SEA TRAVEL

Granted fair winds and an absence of sea monsters, a ship can usually manage about six miles an hour of travel when under sail, and can sail around the clock if far from coasts and other perils. Oar-powered galleys average the same speed, but are heedless of the winds. An ordinary crew can only row for eight hours a day, however.

Encounters at sea are rarer but potentially more hazardous; the GM should roll daily and nightly checks on 1d10 or 1d12. On a 1, some creature has come across the ship, a troublesome wind or storm has sprung up, something has been damaged on the ship or gone awry with the crew, or otherwise complicated the vessel's journey. Some such encounters can be overcome with a good plan and a decent Sail skill check, while others may require bloodier answers.

WILDERNESS EXPLORATION AND EXPEDITIONS

Heroes are inclined to venture into the wilds for their own purposes, chiefest being the gathering of loot and glory. Unfortunately, such expeditions are dangerous, difficult, and oftentimes costly in support and supplies. Once a GM has drawn up a hex map with the tools on page 120, these rules can be used to handle the actual exploration.

Magical devices or special circumstances might alter these rules, allowing swifter movement, faster surveying, or better supply. Of course, should these magics be lost halfway through a trip, the consequences can be dire.

SUPPLIES FOR ADVENTURING

When venturing into the untamed wilderness, a group is going to need certain supplies. Fire, water, shelter, and food are the four most critical. In some places, some of these supplies may be easily acquired along the way, such as fresh water from a river the PCs are following, or shelter when the climate is warm and pleasant around the clock, but usually some kind of provision will need to be made for bringing or gathering these things.

Food is measured in days of food per person. Each day's needed food counts as one item of encumbrance, though they can be packed snugly together as weekly rations that count as four items instead. Some magical items or Mages might be able to create food; a party who relies entirely on such things had best hope nothing happens to their literal meal ticket.

Water is also measured in days of water per person, each unit counting as one item of encumbrance. Exceptionally hot or dry climates may require multiples of this to avoid dehydration or overheating.

Shelter means adequate clothing for the climate and some kind of tent or lean-to to protect from the elements while resting. Characters with Survival-0 can put together a minimal lean-to of boughs and branches in wooded areas, but in places of torrential rain, fierce

PACK ANIMALS AND PORTERS

Pack beasts can carry a certain amount of items of encumbrance, assuming they're packed carefully. Professional porters are also common hires for adventurers, though they generally refuse to enter dangerous ruins.

Most beasts of the Latter Earth can survive on nightly browse and brief water stops for the duration of an expedition. In barren lands, food and water must be packed in for the beasts as well as the humans.

During combat, porters will hide or fight as normal humans to defend their lives. Pack beasts might panic if not calmed by a handler's successful Cha/Ride skill check made as a Move action, usually against a difficulty of 8 or more. Carters, nomad riders, and other professional stock handlers always succeed at these calming checks barring the most unusual circumstances.

EXPLORING A HEX

To lightly explore a standard six-mile hex for points of interest takes a full day of scouting. If the terrain is especially rugged or concealing, such as a range of mountains or trackless swamp, this time is doubled or tripled.

This much time is sufficient to find most major points of interest that the GM may have placed in the hex. It won't necessarily catch small features or provide a detailed survey of the terrain.

Supply Encumbrances

Type	Enc
One day of food or water	1
One week of carefully-packed food	4
One night's load of fire fuel	4
One day's fodder for a horse or large beast	4
One day's fodder for a mule or small beast	2
Daily water for a large beast	8
Daily water for a small beast	4

snows, or other extreme conditions it may prove more difficult. Lack of shelter can make it impossible to rest comfortably, or even threaten a PC's life.

Fire means fuel sufficient to cook food, dry wet clothes, and warm PCs after they've stopped moving for the day. In most places it's easy enough for even the least wood-wise PC to scavenge enough dry wood or twigs to get a minimally sufficient fire going, but voyages into a land devoid of woody vegetation can mean trouble. A load of dung cakes, charcoal, or other fuel sufficient to keep a group warm for an ordinary night counts as four items of encumbrance.

Pack Animal and Porter Loads

Type	Enc
Riding horse or warhorse, with laden rider	5
Riding horse or warhorse, pack only	20
Heavy pack horse	30
Mule or donkey	15
Professional porter	12
Two porters carrying a shared litter	30

At need, a healthy horse can be butchered into 30 days of rations, and a mule or similar-sized beast into 15 days. Preserving this meat takes time and fire, as explained in the Foraging section.

STARVING, THIRSTING, AND FREEZING

If the PCs don't have enough food, water, warmth, or shelter, bad things will start to happen. Each day without these necessities will apply the following penalties.

System Strain is gained. If this would put the PC over their maximum, they must make a Physical save or die by dawn if not fed, watered, and sheltered by a rescuer. On a success, they're helpless until death or rescue.

They can't recover System Strain, gain nightly hit point healing, refresh daily Committed Effort, or restore expended spells until they've had a day of proper food, water, and warm sleep.

FORAGING

PCs who find themselves low on supplies or lacking a particular resource can take time to forage the surrounding terrain. It's assumed the group sticks together during this process, sacrificing efficiency for security. They can split up if desired, but each group then risks encounters.

Some supplies can be gathered as normal parts of travel. If passing through ordinary, non-arid, non-barren terrain it's assumed the PCs can refill their waterskins whenever they wish and can scrounge enough dry firewood as they walk along to have an adequate campfire.

Foraging requires either a half-day or a full day of effort. The group's most apt member makes a Wis/Survive check against the difficulty listed on the table, and on a success earns 1d6 units of forage plus the sum of the group's Survive skill levels, to a maximum of 10. Those without the skill at all subtract 1 from the total, to a minimum of one unit found by the group.

Each forage unit is worth either a day of food for a person, a day of water for a person, or a night's firewood for the party, and the group can decide how much of each was found after the roll is made. PCs who are barbarians

Situations That Cause Privation

Circumstance	Sys. Str.
First day without enough food	+0
Consecutive day without food	+1
First day without enough water	+2
Consecutive day without water	+3
Night without adequate shelter or fire	+0
Harsh night without shelter or fire	+1

Foraging

Type of Foraged Terrain	Diff
Woodlands or areas of heavy vegetation	8
Mountains, scrublands, savannas	9
Deserts, badlands, or normal barrens	12
Arratus or barely human-survivable lands	14
A full day foraging rather than a half-day	-2
Each successive day foraging the same hex	+1
On success, 1d6 units of forage are found, plus the total Survive skills of the foragers. Those without even level-0 skill in it subtract 1 from the total found.	

or other natives of the wilds never find less than two units of forage, barring extreme situations.

Foraged food is unpreserved and will spoil in three days. Smoking or drying it requires use of a day's worth of firewood and a half-day's labor. Any reasonable amount of forage can be preserved with a single half-day's work.

WANDERING ENCOUNTERS

PCs risk encountering trouble in their expeditions. Every so often, a Wandering Encounter check die should be rolled by the GM, with example probabilities on the adjacent table. If the GM rolls a 1, something comes up. A GM should roll an encounter check...

Once per day of travel and once per night of camping outdoors. Such encounters will commence at the terrain's usual maximum sight range, with a Wis/Notice opposed check to see who first spotted who.

Once per foraging attempt. Whether a half-day or a full day, one check is made per attempt, per foraging group. If the group forages all day instead of traveling, the daily travel check above is omitted.

The precise nature of a Wandering Encounter will depend on the terrain and the GM's preparations. A pack of bandits might lurk along a trade road, while a rampaging monster might roar through a deep wilderness. These encounters fit the logic of the situation, not the levels of the PCs, so a swift retreat may be in order.

Wandering Encounter Checks

Type of Terrain	Chance
Dangerous wilderness area	1 in 6
Area of civil unrest or heavy banditry	1 in 6
Ordinary trade road	1 in 8
Well-policed trade road	1 in 10
Borderlands or rural back country	1 in 8
Ordinary wilderness	1 in 8

Not all Wandering Encounters are hostile or involve combat, however. A pompous noble might be clearing rabble off the road in front of him, or a woodsman might be found with a broken leg, or the bandit crew might be carousing and willing to have visitors join in. In general, they're simply situations, creatures, or events that the PCs will need to react to, even if that reaction is simply to duck back behind the brush and put their spurs to their horses.

SITE EXPLORATION

Sooner or later the heroes are almost certain to plunge into a freshly-unearthed Deep, ancient ruin, Outsider outpost, bandit fortress, or other place of peril and mystery. While the details for actually creating such a site are explained in the adventure creation chapter, this section gives guidelines for running the exploration of the place.

These rules are meant for tracking adventures in a dangerous site where perils could spring up at any moment. They're not meant for casual exploration of some bosky glade or city street, and in such cases the PC actions can just be followed scene-by-scene as usual.

It's important that GMs understand the purpose of the Wandering Encounter checks in a site. They're intended to put constant pressure on the party to get in, accomplish their purpose, and get out before they're worn down by encounters or the natives realize that they're being invaded. Not all Wandering Encounters are hostile, but each is a risk of pointless fighting or sudden alarm.

Note that some groups will prefer to do things more loosely than is prescribed here. Issues of resource management and measured risk aren't as interesting to these groups, and they'll instead prefer to use something more like the simplified rules given in this section.

TIMEKEEPING IN THE RUIN

Once the heroes intrude on a ruin, Deep, corrupt noble's mansion, or other potentially-dangerous site the GM starts tracking time in **turns**. Each turn counts as about ten minutes or one scene. Members of the party can generally do one significant thing per turn. Different party members can be doing different things in the same turn, such as one of them picking a chest's lock while the others ransack the room for hidden valuables.

The point of tracking turns isn't to have a minute-by-minute tally of PC activities, but to have a rough measure of how much activity they're engaging in within the ruin. The more they do and the longer they stay, the more likely that they'll run into Wandering Encounters or the natives will have time to realize that intruders are present. Eventually, the PCs need to either pull back or clear the site entirely of its dangerous inhabitants.

MOVEMENT AND FLEEING

For the simplified diagram sites built by the procedures on page 243, movement between rooms of interest just takes one turn. Once inside a room or location, PCs move at their usual movement rate.

If forced to flee, the party needs to decide how exactly they're retreating, and what measures they're taking to dissuade pursuit: blocking doors, throwing food to slaving beasts, dropping treasure, jumping from windows, or other means of retreat. In some cases, this alone will be enough. The GM may decide the pursuers have no reason to chase them beyond a certain point.

THE ORDER OF PLAY

At the start of each turn after the PCs enter the site:

- **Roll a secret Wandering Encounter check** if necessary. On a 1, the encounter will happen at some appropriate moment this turn.
- **The PCs decide what they want to do** this turn, be it move into a new room, carefully search their current location, fiddle with some object they've found, or something else that takes ten minutes.
- **Tell them the result of their actions**, whether that's a first-glance description of a new room, notice of the hideous abomination that's rearing up before them, or the explosive detonation of the crystal they just experimentally rapped.
- **Start over from the top**, assuming their actions have consumed a full turn, until they withdraw from the site or it becomes safe enough to stop counting turns.

Example Time Costs in Turns

Activity	Turns
Move from one room of interest to another	1
Pick a lock or disarm a trap	1
Get in a fight with something	1
Perform first aid and looting after a fight	1
Search a room carefully	1
Have an extended parley with inhabitants	1
Jury-rig something or work a complex device	1
Time a torch lasts until burning out	6
Time a filled lantern lasts before burning out	24

If their foes are determined, the PC with the best Dex/Exert skill makes an opposed check against the pursuing group. They get a +1 on the roll if the PCs are fewer in number than the pursuers, and possibly another bonus if their escape plan is good. The group with the slowest member takes a -2 penalty to their skill check.

On a success, the PCs eventually outpace or lose their pursuers. On a failure, they're caught somewhere along their escape route. A successful escape usually takes up one turn worth of time and leaves the PCs in whatever location the GM decides they've eventually fled to.

ENCOUNTERS AND SURPRISE

Usually, PCs are sufficiently alert when exploring a site to avoid any chance of surprise, barring a set ambush. If they burst in on the natives suddenly, however, the locals might be too stunned to act for a round. If the GM thinks this is possible, give it X-out-of-6 odds and roll it.

If the PCs run into a Wandering Encounter in a room, the creatures will enter through one of the available entrances. In the corridors outside, they're usually 1d8 x 10 feet away when first spotted or heard, assuming there's enough space for such a distance.

LIGHT, LOCKS, AND SEARCHING

A torch or lantern will cast usable light in a thirty-foot radius. Objects outside this range are too indistinct to be made out in the typical stygian gloom of a Deep.

Locks, discovered traps, stuck doors, and other obstacles usually take a full turn to pick or pry free. Most locks or small traps can be defeated with a Dex/Sneak skill check. The difficulty begins at 8 for a fairly good lock or average needle trap. If the PC is in a panicked haste, an attempt can be made as a Main Action at +2 difficulty, but failure means the lock's jammed against further attempts. Failing to disarm a trap usually sets it off.

WANDERING ENCOUNTER CHECKS

Every so many turns, a GM should roll 1d6 to check for a Wandering Encounter. On a 1, the PCs will run into one at some point during the turn. The frequency of the check will depend on how vigorously alert and organized the site's inhabitants are.

The actual contents of the encounter are decided when the GM puts together the site with the tools on page 246. Not all encounters involve running into creatures. Some are mere events or situations that fit the site. In the same vein, not all encounters are necessarily hostile, either. Reaction rolls should be made for all creatures.

SIMPLIFIED RUIN EXPLORATION

The rules on these pages are meant to create a tense expedition into the site, with the party constantly forced to weigh the advantages of plunging deeper with the risk that they'll be worn down by foes before they can escape the site. It requires tracking time, light sources, and other resources fairly carefully, but it rewards good judgment with successful mission completion or plundered loot and punishes imprudence with the risk of death.

Not all groups are interested in that sort of play, however, and some don't find any pleasure in tracking turns, minding light sources, or worrying about Wandering Encounters. Such an approach is a perfectly reasonable one and much in line with certain styles of play.

For these groups, the GM can drop the timekeeping and just maintain the usual scene-based structure of play. Each room or location of interest counts as its own scene for purposes of fighting, searching, or meddling with the contents, and the PCs shift to a new scene each time they venture into a new place within the ruin.

Remember to make a reaction roll when PCs encounter creatures, as explained on page 296. Not every group of Deep denizens will immediately lunge for their weapons when they spot intruders.

Usually, there's a brief, tense moment of recognition when the PCs encounter creatures, just enough time for a reaction roll and a chance to size up the odds of diplomacy. The GM should always give the PCs a chance to parley or run when encountering creatures unless the situation makes that completely impractical.

To search a room, the PCs need to spend a turn and describe just what it is they're searching: whether they're looking under beds, pushing over the big iron cauldron, knocking around the chimney with a pole, or so forth.

If they search where the GM knows something is hidden, they find it automatically. If they don't mention it, the PC with the best Wis/Notice skill then rolls a skill check at a difficulty chosen by the GM. If it's a success, the group happens to also search where the hidden object is concealed and will discover it. Other PCs can aid this skill check as usual.

When to Roll an Encounter Check

Type of Location	Turns
Alerted site with organized defenders	Every 1
Unalert site with organized defenders	Every 2
Site with no organized or active defense	Every 3
Site with very few mobile inhabitants	Every 4
Abandoned or disused nook in a site	Every 6
Hidden area or concealed chamber unknown to the natives of the site	No check

A Wandering Encounter check is made only when the PCs do something that might attract attention, or when they pause in a single location for an unusually long time. PCs that avoid slowing down and that keep their actions discreet can escape any risk of such encounters.

PCs in such groups are assumed to have adequate light sources unless there's some reason they shouldn't. The typical adventurer's gear bundle from the equipment list has all the requisite tools necessary for ordinary dungeoneering, and it's not necessary to track each picklock, crowbar, or torch. Abuse or loss of these items, however, might make them unavailable until replacements are obtained.

GMs who use this simplified method should keep in mind the practical realities of the site. Just because you're not making regular encounter checks, it doesn't mean the site won't react violently if the PCs make a big enough fuss or do something that would logically bring the place's inhabitants down around their ears.



CHARACTER ADVANCEMENT

When characters accumulate enough experience points, they advance a **character level**. New PCs start out at level one and the most experienced, capable heroes in the kingdom might reach level ten. Advancing beyond such prowess is the realm of the Legates, a matter discussed more fully in the deluxe edition of this book.

GAINING EXPERIENCE POINTS

To advance in capability, PCs need to earn **experience points**. Once they accumulate enough experience, they can advance to the next character level, representing the sharpening of their skills and the heroic veterancy that comes of surviving perils and dire challenges. Experience points earned are cumulative, and do not reset each level.

There are many different things that can earn a hero experience points, and the kind of activities and goals that reward them will vary with the kind of campaign you're playing. The GM should make clear to the whole group what kind of things earn the PCs experience.

For some games, success might lie in plundering forgotten hoards or clawing wealth from the hands of desperate patrons. Other games might reward the PCs for achieving personal goals, whether or not there was any money in it. Some might even award XP only for spending gold, requiring every PC to recklessly waste their wealth before gaining a level. It's up to the GM to pick a method that fits the group's tastes.

The adjacent table indicates how many experience points need to be earned before a PC can advance to that level. Once the requisite number of XP are earned, the hero gains their new level and all the benefits, improving them as soon as they get a day or two of downtime.

Level	Fast Leveling	Slow Leveling
1	0	0
2	3	6
3	6	15
4	12	24
5	18	36
6	27	51
7	39	69
8	54	87
9	72	105
10	93	139
11+	Special	Special

Two different rates are given, one for campaigns where the group wants a quick climb to the upper levels and the other for games that want to spend more time at low levels. GMs can pick whichever suits their needs, or can adjust them to suit their own game's needs.

In general, you can assume that one "successful" gaming session should usually earn you about 3 XP.

ADVANCING PAST TENTH LEVEL

By default, it's assumed that heroes stop advancing at tenth level. That pitch of power is as much as a mortal can attain without tremendous luck, hideous pacts, uncanny natural gifts, or other special advantages.

GMs who want to take their heroes beyond tenth level can consult the Legate rules in the deluxe version of this book.

BENEFITS OF GAINING A LEVEL

Once a PC has been awarded enough experience points to reach the next level, they immediately gain the benefits of advancement. No special training is required as their abilities are assumed to have been honed by their adventures over the past level.

ROLL ADDITIONAL HIT POINTS

First, they become harder to overcome in combat. To determine their new maximum hit points, they roll the hit dice for their class and level as given on the chart in the character creation chapter, adding their Constitution modifier to each die. If the new total is no greater than the old, add one point to the old total and record it instead.

Thus, a Warrior who reaches third level and who has a +1 attribute modifier for their Constitution would roll 3d6+9 to find their new hit point total. If they already had 15 hit points and rolled a 12, they'd instead record 16 hit points as their new total.

IMPROVE ATTACK BONUS

A PC's base attack bonus improves according to their class and level, as given on the charts in the character creation chapter starting on page 18. Warriors rapidly gain new skill in martial undertakings, while other classes might need to advance considerably before their prowess improves. Heroes who want to get better with their weapons without an increased attack bonus should consider improving their Stab, Shoot, or Punch skills as explained on the following page.

IMPROVE SAVING THROWS

The PC becomes more capable of evading chance harms and perils. Their saving throw scores decrease by one, making it easier to succeed on saving throws by rolling equal or over it. As a first level character has saving throw scores of 15, reaching second level would lower them to 14, modified by attributes.

GAIN AND SPEND SKILL POINTS

A PC who advances a level gains three *skill points* they can spend on improving their skills or save to spend later. Experts and Adventurers with the Partial Expert class option gain an extra bonus skill point to spend on a non-combat skill or attribute improvement.

Skills that are gained or improved immediately on gaining a level are assumed to have been perfected over the past level and require no training time or teaching. If you save your skill points to spend them later then you'll need to find some teacher or other explanation for developing them in the meanwhile. It doesn't take more than a week to refine your new ability, but you can't usually spend your points mid-scene to develop a heretofore-unmentioned expertise with hurlants.

The cost for improving a skill is listed below. Every skill level must be purchased in order; to gain level-1 in a skill you need to pay one point for level-0 and then two points for level-1. A PC must be the requisite minimum level to increase a skill to certain levels. Less hardened heroes simply don't have the focus and real-life experience to attain such a pitch of mastery.

A PC cannot "partially buy" a skill level. If they don't have enough skill points to buy a new level, they need to save them up until they can. A PC cannot develop skills beyond level-4.

New Skill Level	Skill Point Cost	Minimum Character Level
0	1	1
1	2	1
2	3	3
3	4	6
4	5	9

ADD NEW SPELLS AND ARTS

Some Mage classes automatically acquire new spells as the fruits of their recent researches. Partial Mages learn them just as full Mages do, but an Adventurer PC with two Partial Mage classes must pick one or the other for the purposes of gaining new spells each time they advance a level.

High Mages can pick any two High Magic spells they are capable of casting, adding these spells to their spellbooks. Necromancers and Elementalists may pick only one, but may make their choice from among High Magic spells or those New Magics unique to their particular tradition.

In addition to this, Mages may sometimes pick a new art, as given in the class charts for each magical tradition. Adventurers with two Partial Mage classes gain these bonus arts from both traditions, though the new picks must be made from arts allowed to that class. Thus, a Partial Necromancer/Partial Elementalist who reached third level could pick one new Necromancer art and one new Elementalist art, but they could not pick two from the same tradition.

PURCHASE IMPROVED ATTRIBUTES

A veteran adventurer may have trained or honed their natural abilities well enough to improve one of their six base attributes. While even the most determined development isn't enough to turn complete ineptitude into gifted competence, a hard-working adventurer can hone their existing strengths considerably.

The first time a PC improves an attribute, it costs 1 skill point and adds +1 to an attribute of their choice. The second improvement to their attributes costs 2 skill points, the third 3, and so forth. Each improvement adds +1 to the attribute, potentially improving its modifier. A PC can only ever make five such improvements total; not five per attribute.

PCs must be a certain level before purchasing the third, fourth, or fifth attribute boost. No more than five attribute boosts can ever be purchased by a PC.

Attribute Boost	Skill Point Cost	Minimum Character Level
First	1	2
Second	2	2
Third	3	3
Fourth	4	6
Final	5	9

CHOOSE NEW FOCI

Finally, the PC might be eligible to pick an additional level in a Focus. At levels 2, 5, 7, and 10 a PC can add a level to an existing Focus or pick up the first level in a new Focus.

If this is the first level they've taken in the Focus, they might be granted a skill as a free bonus pick, depending on the Focus' benefits. During character creation, this bonus skill pick is treated like any other skill pick. If the Focus is taken as part of advancement, however, it instead counts as three skill points spent toward increasing the skill. This is enough to raise a nonexistent skill to level-1, or boost a level-1 skill to level-2. They may do this even if they aren't high-enough level to normally qualify for a skill level that high.

If the skill points aren't quite enough to raise the skill to a new level, they remain as credit toward future advances. If applied to a skill that is already at level-4, the PC can spend the three skill points on any other skill of their choice.

CHANGING LEVELING CHOICES

Once made, Focus picks, skill purchases, and other leveling choices are permanent. Some great sorcery or adventure reward might allow a reconfiguration, but a PC is usually obliged to live with the choices they make.

An exception can be made by the GM if a particular choice or concept is proving troublesome in play or out of step with the rest of the group. Such reality rewrites should be reserved for genuine game problems, and not for the sake of "optimizing a build".

MODIFYING AND CUSTOMIZING EQUIPMENT

The ancients left a host of wondrous materials and enigmatic artifices in the ruins of Latter Earth, and the best of the modern crafters have learned how to make the most of these ancient relicts. Exceptionally talented NPC crafters, Experts, and Partial Experts are able to use this salvage to create *modifications* to gear, provided they have the requisite Craft skill.

Unfortunately, these ancient leftovers are finicky, fragile, and subject to decay and decalibration if not carefully maintained by a competent crafter. If left long enough, they often decay to uselessness, and even a relatively short period of neglect can make the item they're used in ineffective until they've been properly maintained. As such, modified equipment is rarely for sale on the open market, as uneducated owners aren't capable of maintaining it properly. Neither are they often found in ancient salvage, as such a long period of neglect usually ruins them. Most often, they are the customized works of expert crafters, made for their own use or the use of a skilled ally.

Any Expert or Partial Expert PC with at least Craft-1 skill, or any PC with the *Artisan* Focus, can modify equipment with ancient salvage. Their crafting background does not need to precisely match the gear they're modifying; the basic principles of using ancient salvage are the same among all disciplines.

MAKING MODIFICATIONS

Many modifications require *ancient salvage*. While salvage usually takes the form of ancient super-materials and wondrous substances in the Latter Earth, more traditional fantasy settings might instead use precious magical monster parts, legendary jewels, or other occult substances with magical properties. To simplify tracking, it's assumed that any piece of ancient salvage can be used to make any particular modification.

Modifying a piece of gear requires the usual tools necessary to create or repair the gear in question. Modifying a sword requires access to a forge, modifying a suit of linethorax armor requires sewing implements, and so on. It also usually requires a large number of expensive supplementary materials. Mods can be removed, but their materials cannot be salvaged.

Modifications have a minimum Craft skill required. An Expert crafter with inadequate skills can't install such a mod, though they can maintain it.

It takes one week to install a modification per level of Craft skill required. Thus, if the modification requires Craft-2 skill to create, it takes two weeks of work to properly install it. An assistant with at least Craft-0 skill can halve this time, and if the crafter does nothing but work, eat, and sleep, it can be halved again.



MAINTAINING MODIFICATIONS

The main reason modifications are not more widespread, aside from the rarity of usable ancient salvage, is that they require regular maintenance by a skilled crafter. Calibrating rituals, proper preservative oil application, counteracting thaumic stress points, and other skilled labor must be done if the modification is to continue functioning.

An Expert or Partial Expert crafter has a *Maintenance* score equal to the total of their Intelligence and Constitution modifiers plus three times their Craft level. Thus, an Expert PC with an Intelligence modifier of +1, a Constitution modifier of +0, and the Craft-0 skill would have a Maintenance score of 1. PCs with no Craft skill can't maintain modifications, nor can those without full or partial Expert classes. Mages who wish to create similar marvels must build them from scratch as magic items.

A crafter can maintain a number of modifications equal to their Maintenance score without cutting into their adventuring time. It's assumed that it's done during downtime and pauses. The work requires no particular special materials or expenses. If they don't adventure or do anything but work, they can double their Maintenance.

If a modification goes without maintenance for 24 hours, it stops working and no longer grants its benefit. If it's unmaintained for a week, the entire item becomes too dangerous or fragile to use. Lack of maintenance for years or ages may result in complete item destruction. A maintenance backlog can be cleared by an hour of work by a crafter capable of maintaining it.

A crafter who builds a mastercraft item from scratch, as explained on page 58, can tune it to better support their modifications if they wish. The first mod they add to such an item costs twice as much in arcane salvage and supplementary costs, but requires no maintenance.

EXAMPLE MODIFICATIONS

The mods listed here are merely some of the possibilities for using ancient salvage or large amounts of costly mundane materials. These mods are almost never available on the open market due to the rarity of usable salvage and the difficulty of maintaining the gear. Acquiring the salvage needed to make them usually means finding it as part of an adventure, receiving it in payment from a patron, or setting out on specific expeditions to find it.

Multiple modifications can stack, but cannot increase a hit, AC, or damage bonus above +3, or a skill check bonus above +1. Magical and masterwork weapons and armor can be modified, but mods can't improve them above this cap.

Arrow Storm (Craft-2): A bow or other projectile weapon automatically generates its own ammunition, albeit the conjured projectiles vanish a round after firing. This mod does not increase reload speed. Cost: One unit of salvage and 5,000 silver pieces.

Assassin's Trinket (Craft-2): A one-handed weapon is modified to adopt the shape of some item of jewelry or adornment. It can be shifted to or from this

shape by the owner as an On Turn action. Cost: One unit of salvage and 1,000 silver pieces.

Augmented Gear (Craft-1): A tool, medical kit, or other item of equipment is improved for a specific purpose chosen at the time of augmentation. Skill checks made for that purpose gain a +1 skill bonus with the item. Cost: One unit of salvage and 5,000 silver pieces.

Automatic Reload (Craft-2): A hurlant can be modified to reload itself, if ammunition is available. Once per scene, a man-portable hurlant can be reloaded as an On Turn action. Cost: Two units of salvage and 10,000 silver pieces.

Customized (Craft-1): The weapon or suit of armor has been carefully tailored for a specific user. When used by them, they gain a +1 to hit with the weapon or +1 Armor Class with the armor. This mod doesn't work with shields. Cost: 1,000 silver pieces.

Flying Razor (Craft-1): A throwing weapon is imbued with various esoteric materials, allowing it to return to the hand of its thrower after each attack. Cost: One unit of salvage and 5,000 silver pieces.

Harmonized Aegis (Craft-3): A suit of armor is altered to harmonize with the dangerous sorceries of allied casters. Provided the wearer and the caster have had ten minutes to coordinate the protection, the wearer is unharmed by the caster's harmful spells for the rest of the day, even if caught in their area of effect. Cost: One unit of salvage and 10,000 silver pieces.

Long Arm (Craft-2): A ranged or thrown weapon is modified to double its normal and maximum ranges. Cost: One unit of salvage and 5,000 silver pieces.

Manifold Mail (Craft-2): A suit of armor is augmented to allow it to shift its appearance to any of five or six pre-set choices, mimicking normal clothing or other armor types as an On Turn action. The armor's Encumbrance is not altered. Cost: One unit of salvage, 5,000 silver pieces.

Omened Aim (Craft-2): Occult components improve a ranged or thrown weapon's targeting, adding +1 to hit rolls. Cost: 4,000 silver pieces.

Preserving Grace (Craft-1): A suit of clothing or armor is specially altered to preserve the wearer. Once per week, when the wearer is Mortally Wounded, they will automatically stabilize. Cost: One unit of salvage and 5,000 silver pieces.

Razor Edge (Craft-2): A weapon has been given an improved edge or shifting weight system, adding +2 to the damage and Shock it does, albeit requiring far more care. Cost: One unit and 5,000 silver pieces.

Tailored Harness (Craft-2): A suit of armor is altered to perfectly fit a single wearer, decreasing its effective Encumbrance by 1 for them only. This does not affect skill check penalties or the *Armored Magic Focus*. Cost: 5,000 silver pieces.

Thirsting Blade (Craft-3): A weapon is imbued with a fated inclination to harm, adding +1 to hit rolls. Cost: Two units of salvage and 10,000 silver pieces.

BUILDING AND CRAFTING GEAR

It's not unknown for PCs to want to fabricate their own equipment, or earn some money with mundane skills, or make a desperate effort to jury-rig some critical piece of equipment just before calamity overwhelms them. While such ambitions aren't always practical, the guidelines here can help a GM sort out these goals.

CRAFTING NEW EQUIPMENT

Assuming a PC has the tools and workspace to fabricate a piece of equipment, they can generally do so. Raw materials for the equipment will cost half the usual retail price, and then some time must be spent crafting the gear.

No skill check is needed to simply craft the objects if they are of a kind appropriate to the crafter's background or habitual work. If the crafter is making something unusual for their skills, a skill check at difficulty 7 for simple objects, 9 for demanding works, and 11 for things only a specialist ought to be able to make might be required at the GM's discretion.

Small, simple equipment such as knives, spears, bundles of torches, cloaks, sacks, or the like takes about an hour to make for each piece or bundle of six simple objects such as torches.

Items that requires significant craftsmanship to make an adequate item, such as most clothing, leather armor, blunt weaponry, movable furniture, saddles, or other objects that require skill but not particularly lengthy effort can be made with one day of work per item.

Objects that are particularly large or that require very careful construction to make, such as large tempered blades, ox-carts, hourglasses, metal armor, or the like require one week of work to complete.

Crafters in a hurry can make an Int/Craft or Dex/Craft check against difficulty 9 to halve the time involved. If the crafter has an assistant with at least Craft-0 to help them, the skill check is made at difficulty 7. On a failure, half the raw materials were ruined and no speed gained.

CRAFTING MASTERWORK EQUIPMENT

A PC with the *Artisan* Focus or a background as a weaponsmith, armorer, or other maker of a specific type of goods can attempt to make a masterwork piece of equipment. The raw materials for such an undertaking cost ten times as much as the retail price of an ordinary item and the time needed to build it is twice as long.

At the end of that period, the crafter makes an Int/Craft or Dex/Craft skill check against difficulty 10. On a success, the piece is a masterwork. On a failure, the item is no better than an ordinary item.

Masterwork weaponry grants a +1 bonus to hit rolls with the item. Masterwork armor counts as 1 fewer point of Encumbrance, down to a minimum of 1 point, albeit not for purposes of the *Armored Magic* Focus. Masterwork items of other kinds may grant similar minor benefits at the GM's discretion.

JURY-RIGGING EQUIPMENT

Adventurers have the habit of needing the most unlikely objects at the worst possible times. It's not uncommon for them to need to jury-rig together a piece of equipment on short notice.

If the materials they have to work with don't seem completely inadequate to the GM, the crafter can make an Int/Craft or Dex/Craft skill check at a difficulty ranging from 7, for something that seems crude but plausible, to 10, for a jury-rig that stretches the boundaries of plausibility. The time taken is five minutes for small, simple objects, fifteen minutes for ones that would normally require some craftsmanship, or an hour for large objects or those that would normally need careful construction.

If the time is taken and the skill check is a success, the crafter has a usable item that will last at least as long as is needed for the particular purpose they jury-rigged it for. Its ramshackle construction will tell, however, and it will never work for longer than a day before falling to irreparable pieces.

BUILDING STRUCTURES

PCs who want to oversee the construction of buildings and other large structures can use the price lists given on page 341 to get an idea of the cost. If a PC is capable of personally overseeing the undertaking, these prices can be decreased by 10% due to saved labor and the avoidance of wastage.

The time to build these structures will depend on how much help is available. Assuming all the needed resources are on-site, one skilled worker can build 25 silver pieces worth of the structure for each day of labor. Thus, a building worth 10,000 silver could be constructed in 40 days by a team of ten skilled laborers. Unskilled laborers or those with no experience in construction are worth only 5 silver pieces of completed work per day. Large or complex structures built with less than 10% skilled labor may be less than perfect in execution.

WORKING AS A CRAFTER

PCs with salable professional skills can try to make some money by plying their trade, but this is a difficult undertaking. Few local crafters will have any interest in dealing with a potentially unreliable adventurer, and local guild laws and customs may flatly forbid strangers from working in a trade. Often a PC will have to make do with piecework and under-the-table help given to employers who are in no rush to pay them.

A PC with Craft or Work or some other salable skill can generally make one silver piece per day per skill level, to a minimum of 1 silver piece. The longer such work goes on, however, the more pressure they're likely to feel to join whatever guilds or social circles control the business in the area.



SYSTEM QUICK REFERENCE SHEET

SKILL CHECKS

- Roll 2d6 + the skill level + most relevant attribute modifier and equal or exceed the check's difficulty
- The easiest checks are difficulty 6, most are 8+, the most difficult are 12+
- Without even level-0 skill, take a -1 penalty if the skill can be attempted at all by the totally untrained
- Bad or good circumstances or tools can apply up to a -2 to +2 penalty or bonus to the roll
- Allies can aid with their own skill use at the same difficulty, granting a +1 bonus if any helper succeeds.

SAVING THROWS

- Roll 1d20 and equal or exceed your saving throw score to succeed
- Roll Physical saves against poison or bodily stresses
- Roll Evasion saves against perils you can dodge or duck
- Roll Mental saves against mental or intangible magic
- Roll Luck against things only blind luck can fend
- Monsters and NPCs have a single saving throw of 15 minus their halved and rounded-down hit dice

INJURY AND HEALING

- A creature dies or is mortally wounded at zero hit points
- Minor NPCs, PCs with the Frail quality, or creatures hit by unsurvivable injuries die instantly
- Others are Mortally Wounded and die six rounds later
- An ally can stabilize the Mortally Wounded with a Dex or Int/Heal check at a difficulty of 8 plus the number of full rounds since the target was felled
- Stabilized creatures stop dying and revive in ten minutes with one hit point and the Frail quality
- Creatures lose the Frail quality after magical healing or a week of bed rest
- Magical healing stabilizes and revives a Mortally Wounded PC with no Frail quality applied
- First aid after a battle heals 1d6 HP plus the healer's Heal skill. This can be done multiple times, but each use adds 1 point of System Strain to the target
- A creature's maximum System Strain is equal to their Constitution score, and if maximized they can no longer benefit from any effect or healing that would add strain
- A creature that is not Frail recovers their level or hit dice in lost hit points after each good night's rest and also loses one accrued System Strain point

SPELLCASTING

- Casting a spell takes a Main Action, one free hand, and the ability to speak in a clear voice. Spells cannot usually be cast while wearing armor or while holding a shield
- If a caster suffers damage or is badly jostled, they cannot attempt to cast a spell for the rest of the round
- If the caster is struck while actively casting, they lose the spell slot and the spell fizzles uselessly

COMBAT ROUNDS

- A combat round lasts about six seconds
- At the start of combat, each side rolls initiative once on 1d8 and adds the best Dexterity modifier on their side. The highest-rolling group goes first; ties go to the PCs.
- At the GM's discretion, each individual combatant can roll initiative and then everyone acts in descending order
- On their turn in the round, a creature can take one Main Action, one Move action, and as many On Turn or Instant actions as the GM thinks reasonable
- Main Actions are attacks, spellcasting, or other activities that would eat up most of six seconds
- Move actions allow the PC to move 30 feet or do similar short, simple actions
- On Turn actions allow the PC to say a few words, drop prone, or do other reflexively simple things
- Instant actions can be taken at any time, even during someone else's turn, or even after dice have been rolled. Instant actions are usually special powers the PC can use or the result of holding an action in combat.

HITTING AND DAMAGE

- An attack is made with a hit roll of 1d20 plus the attack bonus, weapon skill, and the weapon's attribute modifier
- If the resultant roll is equal or higher than the target's Armor Class, the attack hits
- A roll of 1 always misses and a roll of 20 always hits
- On a hit, the attacker rolls the weapon's damage die and adds their relevant attribute modifier. That much damage is done to the target's hit points
- Weapons or unarmed attacks that use the Punch skill can also add the wielder's Punch skill to the damage total
- On a miss, melee attacks may do Shock damage. If the target's Armor Class is less than or equal to the weapon's Shock value, then Shock damage is done. Thus a weapon with "Shock 2/13" does 2 points of damage even on a miss to a target with an AC of 13 or less
- The wielder's attribute modifier and any Shock-specific damage bonuses are added to the Shock damage done
- Shields negate the first instance of Shock that a target would take each round. The *Total Defense* action makes the target immune to Shock for the rest of the round
- A successful hit can't do less damage than the weapon's Shock would do on a miss

MORALE CHECKS

- A Morale check is rolled on 2d6. If it's higher than the target's Morale score, they rout, retreat, or surrender, depending on the situation and their overall discipline
- PCs never check Morale. NPCs do so when an ally first is downed, when half of them are down, or when shaken by some great reverse or terrifying foe
- Even on a successful Morale check, NPCs will not continue to fight when it is obviously futile or not worth the risk

MAGIC AND THE ARCAINE TRADITIONS

The magic of Latter Earth is born from the Legacy, the accumulated mass of arcane laws and thaumic energies that have accrued over fathomless eons. From its first crude beginnings in the Highshine emergency recovery nano-systems of the ancient past to the modern alterations laid down by the conquering Outsiders and their vengeful usurpers, the Legacy and its magic has existed as a tool to serve the purposes of Latter Earth's masters.

Primitive societies might try to define the Legacy as a "nanite cloud" or a "malleable energy field", or some other technical description. It is more than that. It is the product of sciences and enlightenments utterly unfathomable by the modern dwellers of Latter Earth, and it has less relation to the crudity of a 25th century nanite swarm than a silicon chip has to a grain of sand. Its functions may as well be credited as magic, for in a very real sense that is what they are.

The Legacy has been influenced over the ages by the rulers of Latter Earth. New processes have been established, old ones deprecated, new limits placed on old powers and old powers transformed into newer, more serviceable functions. The incomprehensible science of the former ages was able to tune and adjust the Legacy, though rarely with perfect precision; just as they desired to change it to suit their purposes, former users had placed barriers and complications against undoing their own changes. Often the new masters had to make compromises in their plans in order to route around some old forbiddance.

The end result has been chaos. The natural decay of the Legacy has combined with the confused scrawlings of unnumbered eons to produce a power that is capricious, decadent, and unruly in the hands of Latter Earth's present occupants. Ancient magics no longer function as they once did, and new sorceries are tremendously difficult to devise. The power to actually amend the Legacy has been almost entirely lost to this world's modern inhabitants.

This decay is a torment to present-day wizards. The ancient magical techniques recorded in the most venerable grimoires no longer work as they once did, and alternate methods must be salvaged from the footnotes and digressions half-mentioned in these texts. Wizards may spend their whole lives simply trying to find a working substitute for some process that is vital to an ancient spell, conducting dangerous and difficult experimentation to feel out the technique. Success is rewarded by powers that may have been sleeping for an age. Failure, in the worst case, is punished by deaths so terrible that only a wizard could die of them.

Yet despite these hardships, mages persist on Latter Earth. These scholars and gifted souls yet seek to unravel the secrets of the Legacy and learn the methods by which its powers can be harnessed and invoked. The process is intensely laborious, requiring years of study and practice to master the trigger incantations, somatic gestures, psy-

chic configurations, and ritual keys that patch together a usable effect. Whole traditions of sorcery have developed, with mentors passing on their wisdom to new generations of wizards, hoping that those who come after might be able to drag more from the darkness of the past.

MAGES ON LATTER EARTH

Sorcerers have a varied reception among the nations of Latter Earth. In some they are accepted as skilled artisans with talents that are useful to society as a whole. In others they are counted as nothing more than dangerous lunatics who'll inevitably plunge their neighbors into some hellish nether-dimension with their crazed fumbblings. There are elements of truth to both opinions.

Most mages are trained into specific magical traditions. These traditions were formed at some ancient date by like-minded wizards who shared a similar goal or perspective on the Legacy, and their teachings have been passed down to the present day through formal magical schools or a tradition of master-pupil teachings. There are considerable advantages to having trained assistance in the research and development of new magics, to say nothing of the practical benefits of a live-in servant, so few accomplished wizards have been wholly without apprentices. Some of these masters are just, fair-minded men and women who require nothing more of their pupils than diligent study and honest labor. Others have less pleasant uses for their apprentices, and very final roles for those who fail to prove useful.

Other traditions have established magical academies for their pupils, usually with the patronage of the local nobility. In exchange for this generous tolerance such academies usually serve as training-grounds for mages dedicated to the service of their patrons, or those who pay a tribute of service as part of their tuition. The advantages of having a force of trained mages on hand are considerable, but some nations are reluctant to establish such a potent power center outside their own governing class.

A few wizards are even self-taught, having come to their powers through the study of old grimoires and personal experimentation. Such prodigies are exceedingly rare, however, as the slightest mistake in magical training can result in a hideous death. Only the truly brilliant or remarkably lucky can hope to self-study their way to occult power.

The magics practiced by PC wizards are not the only sorceries to be found in the world, however. Throughout the Latter Earth there remain innumerable small sects, isolated traditions, and mad geniuses possessed of secrets and methods long since lost to wider knowledge. There are sorcerers who can perform with ease such feats as would dazzle a traditional mage, yet it is not uncommon that these feats should come at a terrible price. Not all paths of magic are paid for with simple study, and the cost can be more than a wholly human heart can bear.



SPELLS AND ARTS

The ancient invocations and sorceries of yore are known conventionally as *spells*, each one ranked in power from level one, the relatively weakest, to level five, the most potent. There are hypothetical and legendary incantations supposedly of sixth level or higher, but such remarkable magics are not discussed in this book.

The common corpus of ancient spells is known as High Magic, a collection of scores of different invocations that all have been inherited from the deepest past. A separate body of sorcery known as “New Magic” exists in the form of jury-rigged enchantments cobbled together out of the very limited understanding of modern mages, but this form of magic tends to be extremely specific to individual casters and exceedingly difficult to develop. Only the most brilliant and determined mages can ever salvage a novel yet useful new spell.

In this book, a collection of several dozen High Magic spells are recorded. These are by no means the only spells extant but they are some of the most common. Careful researchers and bibliographers suspect that there may be as many as two hundred functional spells surviving from former ages, though some of these produce effects that are seemingly impossible to detect or entirely useless to modern sorcerers, and others may be no more than New Magic passed off by their developers as something more antique. Few wizards are willing to be overly specific about their available magical powers.

High Magic is extremely powerful. While the effects are rarely long-lasting, even the weakest rank of spells is capable of killing people outright, enslaving their thoughts, or conjuring perfectly convincing illusions. The most potent spells can destroy several city blocks, translate the caster over hundreds of miles of distance, or halt time temporarily. There are High Magic spells that create effects modern sorcerers do not understand, but there are no High Magic spells that create only *petty* effects.

It is this very power that makes High Magic so difficult to use. Even the most accomplished mage of the modern day can’t channel more than five or six spells before the eldritch energies exhaust them or burn out their vital forces for a time. A mage capable of hurling three High Magic spells in a single day is considered exceptionally capable. Most novices or modestly-talented wizards can’t manage more than one each day.

Innumerable generations of mages have struggled against these limitations, forming a host of unique magical techniques and quasi-spells built from their knowledge of High Magic. These New Magic “arts” are unique to each tradition of magecraft, building on insights and training techniques specific to that tradition’s education. Most of these arts are much easier to use than High Magic, and many traditions are capable of a considerable range of magical effects without ever calling on a true spell. Others have developed New Magic incantations related to their tradition’s special focus. Such customized magic is useless to other practitioners outside the tradition, as they don’t have the necessary grounding for it.

PREPARING AND CASTING SPELLS

Each High Magic practitioner must first learn a spell before they can cast it. They may be taught by a mage who already knows the spell, even if they’re from a different tradition, or they must find a grimoire laying out the fine details of the incantation. New Magic spells specific to a tradition cannot be learned by mages outside that tradition.

Learning a spell requires one week per spell level, less one week per level of the learner’s Magic skill, down to a minimum of one day. At the end of this time the student will either have mastered the contents of a written copy of the spell or created such a copy from their master’s tutelage. They must continue to retain access to this written document if they are to prepare the spell later, as it is an actual thaumaturgically-attuned artifact in itself. Without its formulas, attunement tables, and enchanted diagrams the mage will be unable to prepare the spell for later use. The full collection of these documents is generally known as the mage’s “grimoire” or “spellbook”, though some texts actually take the form of teaching artifacts or physical models.

A mage must be able to actually cast the spell in order to learn it. A novice mage can cast only first level spells, so they can learn only first level spells as well, even if they somehow come into possession of a grimoire with a more potent incantation. They’ll need to wait until their own enlightenment is sufficient to cast the spell before they can finally master it.

Once the spellbook is prepared, the mage must perform the necessary attunements and propitiations to prepare the spell for casting. The number of spells a mage can prepare at once varies with their experience level, from as few as two or three at first level to as many as twelve when at tenth level. The mage may prepare any spell they have in their spellbook; there’s no obligation to prepare a certain number of low-level spells should the mage wish to fill all their available “slots” with their most powerful magics and run the risk of lacking some lesser, yet more useful spell.

Preparing a new set of spells takes an hour, and can only be done after a good night’s rest, when the mage’s mind is most fresh and malleable. Once spells have been prepared they remain so indefinitely until replaced with a different set of magics.

Once a set of spells is prepared, the mage may then cast them at their leisure. Casting a spell usually requires a Main Action and at least one free hand, along with vocalizations at least as loud as clear normal conversation. The arcane gesticulations and vocal incantations are quite obviously occult to any onlookers, but it’s usually impossible to tell *which* spell a mage is casting merely by looking at them.

Casting a spell requires focus and undisturbed concentration. If a mage has taken hit point damage or has been severely jostled in a round, they cannot cast magic that round. Thus, a mage who acts late in a round runs the risk of being hurt and having their concentration

spoiled, thus forcing them to do something other than cast a spell when their turn comes around.

High Magic cannot normally be cast while wearing armor or restrictive clothing. The profane materials, restrictive fit, and unsalutary occult configurations of armor spoil the necessary flow of energy, as does the bulk and clumsiness of a shield. The same hindrances usually also spoil the use of any arts the tradition may teach, and not just spellcasting itself.

A mage can cast only so many spells each day before needing a full night's rest to recover. Novices can cast only one spell, while masters can manage six. The spell to be cast may be selected from any prepared by the mage; the same power can be used to invoke a mighty fifth-level spell or a relatively modest first-level incantation. The same spell may be cast more than once, if the mage has multiple castings left for the day.

Adventurers who take the Partial Mage class are more limited than more focused specialists. They are able to cast fewer spells each day and the maximum level of spell they can cast is also significantly lower as compared to an equivalent full Mage. The total spells they can prepare for the day are also often somewhat fewer than that of a full Mage. When they cast the spells, however, any level-based effects also use their full level, so a third-level Partial Necromancer's invocation of *The Coruscating Coffin* does 3d8 damage, just as a full Necromancer would.

Adventurers who take two different Partial Mage spellcaster classes use the table on page 64 to determine how many spells they can prepare and cast each day. A dual Partial Mage can prepare and cast spells from either of their traditions. PCs who pick one spellcaster partial and one non-spellcaster, like a Necromancer/Healer, do not use this table, but instead use the usual partial spellcaster table for their class.

CREATURES, TARGETS, AND VISIBILITY

Many spells or powers specify particular targets or creatures, or require that a target be visible. For purposes of these spells, "creature" means any animate entity, whether living, undead, or synthetic. Plants do not qualify as creatures unless they're some sort of plant monster.

A spell that can be aimed or used on one or more targets can include the caster as one such potential target, unless the spell indicates otherwise. If a spell specifies that it applies only to "chosen targets", the mage can pick and choose; otherwise all in the area are affected.

A "visible" target is one the caster can see or whose exact location is obvious. If a maximum range isn't given, assume it's no more than a bowshot away.

ARTS AND EFFORT

Arts are those special magical techniques and abilities taught by a particular magical tradition. These are much less powerful than actual High Magic spells, and often produce relatively minor, even trivial effects. Even so, they may be used with far more facility than the mighty spells

of ancient days and their practical utility is a blessing to modern sorcerers.

Each tradition has a list of available arts, though additional techniques might exist in far lands or isolated sub-sects of the group. A mage can pick one or more arts from this list as they rise in character level, while some traditions automatically grant certain arts to all members. Once picked, an art cannot be exchanged; the occult attunements involved are final and permanent.

Arts are fueled by **Effort**, a representation of the mage's available focus and magical energy. This Effort is separate from the power used to cast spells, and a mage who has exhausted his spells for the day might still have a considerable fund of Effort left. Effort is deployed and regained much more quickly than spellcasting slots.

Effort is measured in a score equal to one plus the mage's Magic skill plus the higher of their Intelligence or Charisma modifiers. Adventurers with the Partial Mage class have an Effort score one point lower than full Mages, though never less than one point. Healers, Vowed, and other Partial Mage classes have this decrease already factored into their listed Effort calculation.

Using Effort requires that it be **Committed**. The Effort is sunk into fueling the power, but will return automatically once a certain time has passed. There are three durations for which Effort is Committed, and each art indicates in its description how long the Effort must remain Committed to trigger it.

- **Commit Effort for the day** to trigger powerful arts. One point of Effort is invested in the power and returns the next morning after the mage has had a good night's rest.
- **Commit Effort for the scene** to trigger more modest abilities. One point of Effort is invested in the power, but returns as soon as the scene is done.
- **Commit Effort indefinitely** to activate a persistent, lasting ability that keeps active as long as you keep one point of Effort Committed. You can reclaim this Effort at any time as an Instant action, immediately turning off the art. This Effort can remain invested indefinitely even while you're asleep or unconscious provided you have a few minutes to prepare things properly before falling asleep. If you're suddenly struck unconscious or killed any such powers immediately end.

Whenever Effort is Committed, only a single point is required. A very few powers might require more than one point to be Committed, but if so, it will be specified in the ability.

Each tradition has a separate pool of Effort; there is Necromancer Effort and High Mage Effort and Healer Effort and so forth. An Adventurer who picks two different traditions has two different pools of Effort, neither of which can be used to fuel arts from the other.



DUAL PARTIAL MAGE TRADITIONS

Some Adventurer PCs are adepts of two different magical traditions, such as a Partial High Mage/Partial Necromancer, or a Partial Elementalist/High Mage. The rules for these combinations are a little bit different, as mixing two spellcasting traditions creates a little more aptitude for sorcery than merely mixing in a martial Warrior's training or learning the non-spellcasting magical arts of a Healer or Vowed.

Dual-spellcasting Adventurers have a wider range of arts and more prepared spells than their more focused peers, but they have slightly fewer spells usable each day, and they never attain mastery of the most powerful spells.

If the two Mage traditions are both spellcasters, they don't use the Partial Mage tables listed under each tradition to determine their allowed spells per day and preparation limits. Instead, they use the adjacent table to find out how many spells they can cast each day, how many they can prepare at once, and what the maximum level of spell they can cast might be. Spells can be prepared and cast from either of their partial traditions, so a Partial Elementalist/Partial Necromancer could prepare or cast High Magic, Elementalist, or Necromancer spells with their allowed slots.

Thus, a 1st level Partial High Mage/Partial Necromancer could prepare up to three first-level spells and cast one of them each day. He could pick one art from the High Mage list, because that's what a first level Partial High Mage can pick, in addition to one Necromancer art, because that's the allotment a novice Partial Necromancer gets.

Such polymaths do not attain the focused mastery of their specialist brethren, but tend to have more Arts and a wider breadth of prepared spells available.

Partial Mage/Partial Mage

Level	Hit Dice	Attack Bonus	Focus Picks
1	1d6-1	+0	1 Free
2	2d6-2	+0	+1 Free
3	3d6-3	+0	
4	4d6-4	+0	
5	5d6-5	+1	+1 Free
6	6d6-6	+1	
7	7d6-7	+1	+1 Free
8	8d6-8	+1	
9	9d6-9	+1	
10	10d6-10	+2	+1 Free

PCs with Dual Spellcasting Traditions

Level	Max Level	Spells Cast	Spells Prepared	Arts Gained
1	1	1	3	As per both partial classes, gaining each level's art picks as usual.
2	1	1	4	
3	1	2	5	
4	2	2	6	
5	2	2	8	
6	2	3	9	
7	3	3	10	
8	3	4	12	
9	3	4	13	
10	4	5	15	

High Magic Spell List

First Level Spells

Apprehending the Arcane Form	See magic for 15 minutes per level, while also seeing in the dark
Cognitive Supersession of the Inferior Orders	Telepathically bond with an animal, which obeys but won't fight
The Coruscating Coffin	Do 1d8 dmg/level to a visible target, save for half. 1 HD foes die
Damnation of the Sense	Take control of one sense of a target for a scene on a failed save
Decree of Ligneous Dissolution	Destroy all non-magic plant-derived matter in the target area
The Excellent Transpicuous Transformation	Turn one target per level invisible for an hour per caster level
Imperceptible Cerebral Divulgence	Detect a target's surface thoughts and get answers to questions
Ineluctable Shackles of Volition	Enslave a target's mind, leaving them visibly dazed but obedient
The Long Amber Moment	Put a willing creature into temporary invulnerable stasis
Phantasmal Mimesis	Create an independently-functional illusion in the target area
Velocitous Imbuement	Augment the movement speed and options of one target/level
Wardpact Invocation	Make a target partially weapon-immune or make a weapon useless
The Wind of the Final Repose	Put living targets of 4 HD or less to sleep within the area of effect